

Phil 230 The Philosophy of Ethics

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 230 • Dr. Stephen R. C. Hicks

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Lecture 1: Locke & Rousseau

At a glance — Locke and Rousseau.

- 1.1 All right, let's begin in 1603. This is a course, in modern ethics, and I want to emphasize both of those words, of course, on ethics, moral theory, but also an emphasis on the modern. By the time we get to 1603, the world has gotten clearly past a millennium of what we now call medieval times. We think of Columbus crossing the ocean at the end of the 1400s. We now have a sense of truly being part of the larger globe and the intermixing of all of those cultures and religions and ways of looking at the world.
- 1.2 If we think about artists like Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo, and of the 1400s on into the early 1500s, a more naturalistic way of doing art. If we think about religious thinkers like Martin Luther and John Calvin, and the big breakup of what had been, at least in the European context, a more or less unified Christian religion, into multiple, multiple competing sects. We are starting to think of ourselves as human beings in a much bigger, much more complicated world. We're doing art in a different way. We're doing religion in a different way. Then on top of that, the beginnings of what we now call modern science. That's coming into existence.
- 1.3 Thinkers like Copernicus, who suggests that maybe we should think of the sun at the center rather than the Earth at the center. Anatomists like Vesalius doing dissections and coming to understand this enormously complicated human body and the anatomical studies that make possible the beginnings of modern medicine. By the time we get to 1603, it's the modern world. Everything is different. I want to go to England in particular. Politically, the big powers, Portugal, Spain, and then France, are starting to get competition on the European scene from smaller upstate nations like the Netherlands and England.
- 1.4 So, much is new. In England, there's a new king. Queen Elizabeth I, who had been monarch for many, many years, died, and a new king, King James I, or James VI, because he was king of Scotland already, but now he also becomes king of England. I want to use him as our pivot from the old to the new, because when King James is early in his reign, he's making it clear what the moral justification for his reign is going to be, what it is for him to be a good king, what it will be for all of the English and Scottish subjects to be good subjects. What's the moral basis for the law for this political system?
- 1.5 He announced this quite forthrightly, then to great controversy in the English context, because England is starting to become a more modern society, he says this. The King is "a little God to sit on his throne and to rule over other men." Now, that is an old way of thinking about the proper relationship between citizens, as we now call them in the modern world, or subjects, as we used to call them. If you are a subject, you are subject to some higher authority. What he is suggesting is this principle of hierarchy.

- 1.6 In the political context, you, or I don't know your particular context as well, you might be a peasant. In much of Europe, you might be a serf. You might be a slave, although slavery was starting to be on the decline in Europe, but in much of the world slavery was still the norm. You might be a craftsman with a few more privileges and a member of a guild. You might be a member of the clergy, and then you have different responsibilities. You might be a member of the petty aristocracy or the higher aristocracy or the monarch. But the point is that society is organized hierarchically from the bottom to up, to up, to up, all the way up to the king. The right thing for you to do is to know your place in the hierarchy and therefore what you are supposed to do with your life.
- 1.7 "Kings are called Gods because they sit on his throne in the earth, and they have the count of their administration to give him." To whom is the king responsible? Not to the people, to God. Again, another hierarchical dimension. On the political side, we will have all of the subjects in increasing hierarchy all the way up to the king, and the king is subject then to God.
- 1.8 Then perhaps the corresponding religious hierarchy. We will have the laity, the ordinary religious believer, and then we have the priests, and then at least in the Catholic tradition, the longest tradition in Europe, at that point there is then a whole hierarchy going from bishop to archbishop to cardinal to Pope. Then the Pope is ultimately responsible and perhaps receiving communications from God. So politically, religiously, everything is hierarchically structured, and your job is to know your place in that hierarchy.
- 1.9 "Since God has hath only the power to make him, hath the power to unmake him, and ye to obey." What is the proper justification, the moral justification, for the king's power? God gave it to him. God granted it to him. It comes from down on high. It's not from the people who are going to grant it in some respect to whoever is going to be their political leader. The organizing moral concept for the vast majority of us is obedience, hierarchy and obedience.
- 1.10 If we ask then the ethics question, "What's the meaning of life?" That's the big one. How do I live the right life? That's a normative concept, the best life, the proper life, the good life, all of those synonyms that we use in the moral language. The traditional answer is, we answer that question in terms of hierarchy. You know your place and you know the obligations that are incumbent upon you according to your place in the hierarchy. You live your life meaningfully in that way.
- 1.11 Now, that's England. We're using England as a representative country, and in many ways, it is the first modern country, systematically. England is about to embark on a revolutionary century. I don't know how much of English history you know. This is not the place for that, but let me just give you some highlights. We go from King James early in the 1600s. And then when he dies, there's a civil war, largely over how we're going to do religion, how we're going to do politics.

- 1.12** The king loses the civil war, and then in this astonishingly symbolic act, the king is executed. He's executed by people who want to have a parliamentary, or a more democratic/republican style of government, where people have some sovereignty over their life, they elect people to represent them, and those people have power only because the people have given that power to them. Those guys won the civil war, and they, in that symbolic act, say, "Cut the king's head off." That's hugely symbolic.
- 1.13** Now, this early parliamentary democracy that was victorious in the civil war was itself rather dictatorial. To modern ears, it sounds a little bit odd, but it was a rather dictatorial democracy, and there is a way to put that together. That ultimately was rejected. There was a restoration of the monarchy. So again, we're back to monarchy. But it's a weakened monarchy. It's a little bit more modern. Then another king dies and another king comes into place, and parliament and the representatives of the people are asserting their power more, and they're saying, "We don't like this new king," for a variety of political and religious reasons. They say, "Go away."
- 1.14** There's a little bit of bloodshed, but not very much. Reluctantly, the king says, "OK, I will go away," and he goes into exile. Then we have a parliamentary democracy in England in the 1680s. Now, that's almost a century of English politics. But the point is that this is a revolutionary century where we're going back and forth. But by the time we get to 1688, 1689, we have a king, but the king is not God's chosen representative on Earth who has the power, and everybody is organized hierarchically, and power and authority and goodness flow down on your places, to know your place, rather, in the hierarchy and to obey. That has been literally revolved.
- 1.15** We're in the modern world, power starts at the bottom with individual human beings who have responsibility for their own lives. I notice that moral concept, responsibility. It's my life, my responsibility, and I'm going to delegate some power to some political authorities who will have some authority because we gave them power, and they will, on some matters, rule over us, but really, they are still servants of us. This is a remarkable transformation in one century in how we think about the important meaning of life issues, particularly in a political context.
- 1.16** Now, we're going to return to our first major philosopher of the course, John Locke. I'll make a claim: John Locke is the most influential philosopher in modern times. We're going to make some arguments about that right over the course of time, but I'm going to give you one slice of Locke, his moral philosophy. On the basis of that, we can make some judgments about his importance to modern moral philosophy.
- 1.17** 1688, there had been what the English called their Glorious Revolution. They'd kicked out their old king and invited another king from Holland to come over and to be their king. He said, "Thank you very much. I will be happy to be your king." But it was clear that parliament had the power and the king was going to be partly symbolic and certainly not God's chosen representative. He was chosen by parliament, not God, obviously. John Locke had been in exile in Holland for some years, partly because of

political issues and being on the wrong side of various political factions in the '70s and on into the 1680s.

- 1.18** He had gone to Holland, to Amsterdam in particular, which was famous for being a place of intellectual toleration, religious toleration. It had attracted very smart people who were intellectually ambitious, scientists, poets, philosophers, religious thinkers, who in their home countries had run into trouble with their authorities because they were speaking unpopular and inappropriate positions. Holland was a real melting pot of scientific and philosophical and religious and business and economic ferment. It was quite natural for many intellectuals to spend some time there. Locke had spent some time there.
- 1.19** When the revolution in England had been successfully prosecuted, he came back, and he came back on the ship of the woman who was to become the Queen of England, the husband of the man who had been invited to be the King. So he's already rather connected politically. And he's been doing a lot of writing, working out his philosophical system, and he starts to publish major works and the works that become extraordinarily influential in modern times.
- 1.20** If we ask then the question at the end of the 1600s, "What's the meaning of life? How am I supposed to live my life? What is good, right, correct, proper, best?" The answers are different now in the leading intellectuals and starting to percolate into more ordinary people living through their lives. The modern ethics project is underway. In the case of Locke, what we will find is the most important concept is not hierarchy and obedience, but rather, liberty. Every human being is a free agent, has free will, correspondingly has agency, responsibility for how he, and increasingly she, thinks and the character formation and how you behave in the world. The moral life is living as a free human being, and that's revolutionary.
- 1.21** Here's John Locke, a little excerpt from a work he wrote on education. He's saying, we're in modern times. When we're educating our children from the very beginning, how are we going to raise children to be the best human beings they can be? There had been lots of education manuals written over the course of many, many centuries. But what we find in Locke is to say we need to educate people to understand children right from the beginning, that they are free agents and how to live freely, how to govern themselves as free individuals. He's saying there's a natural fact about us as human beings, and this is where we should start.
- 1.22** "We naturally"—and notice that word, naturally, human nature. We're part of nature. When we're talking about education, we're not starting with God and 'God said.' We're starting with nature and human nature—"even from our cradles, love liberty, and have, therefore, an aversion to many things,"—that is to say, there's lots of things we don't like—"for no other reason but because they are enjoined us." That is to say, someone tells us, "You can't do that." What is human nature when someone tells you, "You can't

do that?" Boy, do I ever want to do that now. Just because someone said, "I can't do that," no one's going to tell me what to do. I am the decider in this case.

- 1.23** And Locke is saying this is a point about human nature, and it's a foundational point that all education, and certainly all of moral education has to take into account. You are dealing with a free agent. "I've always had a fancy that learning might be a play and a recreation to children." When we are raising children, what should life be all about? Well, it should be about fun, enjoying yourself, the pursuit of happiness in that more elevated language.
- 1.24** What had education typically been up until the modern world? And Locke makes the contrast. He says, well, you show up in school and you have this very frowny-faced teacher who sometimes has a stick in his hand or her hand. The clear message is, "I'm the boss, I'm the authority, and you will be obedient. If you step out of line, you are going to be beaten." And so out of fear, you learn. And Locke's saying, no, no, no. Exact opposite of that. We naturally enjoy learning, and we should enjoy learning, and life should be about enjoying and freely forming our characters and our lifestyles, and that's what education should be preparing human beings for. This is the modern world now.
- 1.25** Another quotation from the same work, just to indicate the modern times. "A sound mind in a sound body is a short but full description of a happy state in this world." Let's unpack this a little bit. One of the big philosophical issues of all times, of course, is what's the relationship between our mind and our body? One very prominent theory had been to say, well, our minds and our bodies are two very different things. One is spiritual or a soul, the other is physical and merely material. They have very different needs, very different agendas, and those two agendas are in conflict with each other.
- 1.26** You're this internal battle between what your body wants to do and what your soul aspires to. Your soul aspires, rather, to higher things, but your body is stuck in this low, physical, materialistic world. If you're going to be a good person, what you should do is control your body, maybe even deny your body, not be interested in physicalistic, materialistic things, rather free your soul from your body so it can pursue its true agenda, its true aspirations, in a spiritual, non-materialistic way.
- 1.27** Now, we've all heard that story. That's an ages-old story. What Locke is doing is like, no. We are a mind in a body. We are a mind-body. We are, and then the inward, we are then philosophically an integrate. It's not that there's the mind and the body and there are two different things that just happen to be together for a few short years in this life. We are an integrated being of mind and body. We should get them to work together. We want to develop our bodies and we want to develop our minds in an integrated fashion. That's revolutionary. That's very modern.
- 1.28** But it also then means that we should think of healthy and as good as positive, the development of the bodily side of human beings. How we think about food and money

and sex and so forth, all of those physical things. It's not that, oh, those are beneath our dignity and you should rise above them. No, learning how to do all of those things and enjoy them is also part of the good life. "Sound mind in a sound body," and the last part of that sentence, "a happy state in this world." What are we trying to be? Happy.

- 1.29** Again, the contrast here is not thinking about life as a set of duties or obligations or things that you are supposed to be obedient to, and a good person does those things, whether they make you happy or not, whether you want to or not. The old idea, you are not here to be happy. You are here to do your duty, to fulfill your obligations, to higher authority. And Locke is saying, "No, you're not. You are here to be happy." Now, what happiness means, big complicated subject. Locke writes a very fat book, making the full philosophical case for all of this. We know the physiology, the psychology, and so forth. The social conditions are very complicated. But as a signal of where we are going in the modern world, this is important.
- 1.30** Now, Locke returns from Amsterdam, the so-called Glorious Revolution in England of 1688. This is the new king. You'll notice the Dutch flag on the ship coming from Holland where he had been invited. So Parliament has sent away the old king. They've invited a new king to come along, and then Locke and his philosophical system comes to join. Parliament very quickly passes an act of toleration. Of course, one of the big battles in the early modern world, the 1500s and the early 1600s, had been all of the religious conflict, nasty in many cases, religious conflict over what is the right way of understanding religion, the right way of conducting religion, to the point where neighbors hate each other, parents and their children are estranged from each other.
- 1.31** Right, too, all of the horror stories we've heard about torture and killing of people over religious differences, all augmented by the idea that the church and the state or religion and politics need to be integrated, and that whoever holds political power is also a religious authority and has the power to enact the proper way of doing religion. One of the first very modern things parliament does is pass The Act of Toleration, which largely says, "We are not, as your political leaders, going to tell you how to do religion. We are going to tolerate a diversity of religions inside our regime. We're not going to pass laws that exile people for their religion, make them second- or third-class citizens for their religion. Rather, we will tolerate."
- 1.32** And it's a pretty wide range of toleration for the 1680s, a diversity of religions. The idea is that religion is up to you. It's your responsibility. It's not our political responsibility. Act of Toleration. Now, this has then been to say that you are a moral agent, a free agent on all of the important things in your life. This is part of a development that has occurred over the course of the 1600s. Now, we're focusing a lot on England here, but I want to just give a taste of some other important intellectuals in the 1600s as this has developed along, because this is a broadly European intellectual movement.
- 1.33** Why would we tolerate people believing all kinds of weird and sometimes bizarre, in some cases, what we think are immoral things, in their religion? How can we possibly

do this? Why do we want to say toleration is such an important feature? Here's Galileo arguing, saying, well, "I do not feel obliged to believe that the same God who has endowed us with senses, reason, and intellect has intended us to forego their use." We'll pause right there. This is Galileo in the early part of the 16th century, rather, saying in contradiction to those who say, look, there is one religious truth, and there is one established religious institution, the Church, that knows what that truth is, and it is responsible for all of our souls collectively, to instruct us and then to make us sure that we are following the proper religion.

- 1.34** And so you should have faith. Notice that word faith in the authority of the Church, and you should follow the traditional ways that have been worked out, say, by the Church over the course of many smart, better-than-you people over the course of many centuries. And Galileo was pointing out in a very modern way, no, not faith, not authority, not traditions. God made each and every one of us. But how did he make us? He made us as beings with our own senses, with our own reason, with our own intellect. We can observe the world, we can think about it, we can figure out in a responsible way what the truths are, including what moral truths are.
- 1.35** God does not want us to turn off this most important set of faculties that he's given us, our own mind, and just trust on faith, other people, particularly people in authority. That's radical in the early modern world. But that then is to say, though, that saying that religion should be reasonable is not an irreligious or anti-religious view, saying that most religious people are going to be those who take on the responsibility of using their own minds and thinking through these important matters for themselves. That's in Italy. Of course, Galileo got into hot water and lots of trouble for arguing that way.
- 1.36** A few years later, Rene Descartes in France, getting away from the idea of saying, well, there's all of these traditions and truths that are captured in the old languages, and only an elite number of people who have been trained in Greek and Latin and so forth should be authorized to read and interpret these important books. Descartes suggests, no, I'm going to start writing my books in the vernacular language, the language of my country, in this case, French. We start to see many thinkers from many countries starting to write in English, in Spanish, in German, in Dutch, and so forth.
- 1.37** The idea here is, as he puts it here, it is because, why am I doing this? "I expect that those who use only their pure natural reason will judge better of my opinions." Everybody has their reason, their natural reason, and they should be able to use it. The way we learn is not by listening to authorities and accepting what they say on faith, but by becoming literate, reading, and thinking for ourselves, and this confidence that the vast majority of people, if they have basic education and literacy, they should be able to do this.
- 1.38** John Milton, to come back to England. "If men would within themselves be governed by reason, and not generally give up their understanding to a double tyranny of custom from without," that is to say, how things customarily are done from outside all of these

social and institutional pressures, this is how you're supposed to think and what you are supposed to do. No, consult your own reason inside. Resist that social, perhaps, and political tyranny. Think for yourself.

1.39 Then, the double tyranny is "blind affections within," your own emotions and passions and various instincts, we might say, being just governed by them. No, reason about yourself and what's going on inside yourself and make your own best judgment about whether you should stifle a passion or act on the basis of that passion. Be a rational being. Now, you notice what all of these have in common is the idea that you should be rational, you should reason, and that everybody naturally has the capacity for this. This is modern.

1.40 I want to jump to Isaac Newton, who's publishing the great foundational work, or integrating work in 1687, if you can read that, just before the Glorious Revolution, and founding what we now think of science of physics and a co-discoverer of calculus. So, using him as representative of what's going on in the modern sciences as well. But he says the sciences are in part a moral endeavor, how we use our minds, how we think about things. "I have hitherto not been able to discover the cause of those properties of gravity from phenomena." What he is saying is, all right, I've done this wonderful physics system, and I've got these laws that I'm going to present to you, and law of gravitational attraction, for example, is one.

1.41 This is how far my science and my thinking has taken me. I haven't been able to get behind gravity yet to figure out what's going on there. Now, what has been customary for intellectuals for centuries, when they get to something that they don't know the answer to, or that they can't derive it from the experiments, from observations, from logical reasoning, is they start to speculate. They just basically make stuff up. But of course, as intellectuals, they want to say, what they made up is the absolute truth. And so we get into all of these fruitless arguments.

1.42 What Newton is signaling here is that reason is not only a matter with respect to religion, with respect to politics, but also with respect to science. A scientist is a moral individual if he uses his mind the right way. Don't pretend that you know what you don't know. Down toward the bottom, various sorts of hypotheses, that is to say, ones that you don't have any experimental evidence for, whether metaphysical or physical, "have no place in experimental philosophy." Now, this is a movement of intellectuals across many countries, and John Locke is, in some ways, an inheritor, a deepener, a broadener of this philosophical approach that's very modern.

1.43 Now, what I want to do is turn to his most substantial work. The Essay Concerning Human Understanding went through multiple printings in England, extraordinarily influential in early America, where we are now. Multiple printings, multiple editions. It was, in effect, the Bible, philosophically, of the emerging modern world. Now, what I want to do in this course, we're going to look at several philosophers. I, of course, can say, here are some important quotations and here are some historical context, but an

important methodological principle is always to go to the text itself. Read the person in his or her own words.

- 1.44 One thing that you can do is let yourself go a little bit and get into the spirit of the person's way of thinking about things. Set aside just for a few moments your automatic reactions when you come across something that seems just completely wrong or crazy or immoral. We'll have quite a bit of that over the course of this eight-session course. First time you read a philosopher, you understand half of what they're saying. That's fine. That's natural. The second time you look, you get up to 75%, 80% or so, but it's a process of training yourself to work through.
- 1.45 In many cases, I read this person, and this person, who I also read, contradicts them. That forces you to think through for yourself who has the better argument. But the only way you can really do that is to make sure that you've engaged with the argument in the philosopher's own words in the first place. This is from Locke, and I'm going to excerpt some sections on his understanding of morality and the foundations of morality. From the very first book. "Morality capable of demonstration." And already that's fighting words. "Upon this ground, it is that I am bold to think that morality is capable of demonstration, as well as mathematics." Let's pause there.
- 1.46 Now, think about how revolutionary this is in the 1600s. Where do we get morality from? Not so much what is moral, but where do we get it from? How do I know that what I think is moral, what is good, right, wrong, etc, is correct? We contrast that to the traditional answers, which is to say, well, you trust your parents, and your parents just said these are the right things to do, and these are the wrong things to do. So it's an authority, appeal to authority.
- 1.47 Then the moderns, of course, they're going to say, "Your parents? Are they perfect with authorities, with respect to morality?" Then the answer, well, is no, they got it from their parents, and they got it from their parents, and so forth. If we just have a whole bunch of parents, if we can use the pejorative, indoctrinating their kids into morality over the—that's not really what morality is about. Is it a matter of faith in established institutions? There is not indoctrination from your parents, faith. I'm just going to trust in some sense, my priest.
- 1.48 Another common answer prior to the modern world had been to say, well, maybe you are one of those special individuals to whom God speaks directly. You have mystical experiences that other people don't have access to. And so you cultivate some non-rational mystical experience, and you just know what's right or wrong. Much of the history of morality had been to say, well, we learn it from our parents, or we just have faith in higher authority, or you should try to cultivate mystical insight and just trust whatever you think that is, ultimately.
- 1.49 Locke is saying, no, it's a matter of demonstration, just like in mathematics. He's going to then go on to argue, just like in experimental philosophy, we learn it from

experience and reason. That is fundamental. "When we say that man is subject to law," moral laws, in this case, "we mean nothing by man but a corporeal rational creature." If we're going to figure out what's good for us, what's the right way for us to live, then first we have to understand ourselves. What is it to be a human being? In part, I am a corporeal being. That is to say, I have a body. So there are going to be some things that are good for me as a physical being, and we can figure those out, by experience and reason.

1.50 But also, I am a rational being. That's the most important part Locke is suggesting of our psychology or our psyche or our mind, our capacity for thinking rationally, logically, about the world. "A sound mind in a sound body," then, the science of morality is going to take into account proper understanding of the human mind, proper understanding of the human body, and integrate those, and it will be a demonstrable science in the modern world.

1.51 Now, if we start to do this, what do we discover? "It is appropriate for us, as rational creatures, to employ our faculties on what they are best adapted to, and follow the direction of nature." Where do we start? Nature. The contrast is here, we don't start with a supernatural dimension. Traditional morality, where do you start? You try to get away from the world of nature and you go to a supernatural natural dimension, where God is, and you try to understand what God wants, and then you might apply that to yourself; you might apply that to the natural world. Locke is saying we start with nature. We will use our senses, and then we will think about what we learn and we will develop our morality there.

1.52 "For it is reasonable to conclude that we ought to pursue the sort of knowledge that is most suited to our natural capacities, from which I conclude that morality is the proper science and business of mankind in general." Those are very modern words. It's a science. Now, we'll come back to religion in just a minute. It's our business, not business necessarily in the strictly economic sense. That's what we busy ourselves with, figuring out what we ought to do with our lives and then doing that. That's what morality is about.

1.53 "For the special talents of particular men, for survival in this world." Why are we learning about morality? Because we want to survive and survive better in this world. Again, the contrast, which is to say, traditionally, much of morality had been said, this world doesn't matter very much. It's the afterworld, the afterlife. That's what it's all about. You don't learn your morality from this world and apply it to making your life better in this world. Rather, you ignore, or perhaps, for now, set aside this world and focus on a higher world and follow its commands in order to prepare your self when, hopefully, you enter into that higher world after you die. It's a very strong contrast in our approach to moral philosophy.

1.54 Now, religion. Am I being irreligious here? I, being John Locke. "Don't think that I want to discourage the study of nature. I readily agree that contemplating God's work can

lead us to admire, revere, and glorify him. The point here he is making, he says, this is not an irreligious doctrine, if we remember that God made nature. Why did God make nature? Because he wants us to study it and thereby come to know him. This is his work. This is his project. By being rational and studying nature, including human nature and the way things work and what the conditions of good survival are in this world, we are doing what God intends for us.

- 1.55** We are using the capacities, the capacities for sensing, for reasoning, for doing mathematics and science that God gave to us, that he wants us to use. The most religious person, rather, on the proper understanding of religion, is going to be someone who is admiring the natural world and wanting to develop his, and increasingly her, best capacities to be the best person you can be and survive well in that world. This is practical work.
- 1.56** "He who first invented printing, discovered the use of the compass, or made public the powers of quinine and the right to use it, did more to propagate knowledge, to supply and increase useful commodities, and to save people from the grave." Who should we really admire? Again, he's making a contrast here that's striking. "Than those who build colleges, workhouses, and hospitals." So people who look after the poor and the sick. Of course, that's important. But who are the real benefactors of mankind? Those who discover new knowledge that is practical knowledge, who are studying the natural world.
- 1.57** Now, in order for us to do this, there is an ethics that— I think I did the same thing again. Just give me a moment here. OK, good. Now, how do we do this? There's an ethics then associated with using our God-given faculties appropriately. Here he goes on the attack against a certain traditional religion. "My point is that we shouldn't be too confident in claiming to have knowledge, and that we shouldn't take doubtful systems to be complete sciences, or unintelligible notions to be disciplined demonstrations."
- 1.58** We know what we know, we know what the evidence is, we know how much thinking we've done about a subject, we know how many experiments are done. A moral person using their mind will not claim more knowledge than they actually have. One of the great problems we have individually and socially is people pretending to know more than they do. I'm enthusiastic, and this is the word that Locke is going to do, about my political beliefs, enthusiastic about my religious beliefs or whatever it is. But in my mind, I know that I have not really thought and investigated this. I just really want this to be true. That's a deep immorality.
- 1.59** We know that has social consequences because people who act that way are often the most authoritarian, dictatorial people in social contexts. They know that they can't change your mind through reason, by "here's the evidence, here's the experiments, here's the logical demonstration," as a rational person would do, as a decent person would do. Respect other people's minds, that they have to think things through for themselves and come to their own conclusions and work with them on that process.

- 1.60 Someone who wants to short-circuit or override that process. "Trust me, I know better," or "I have certain kinds of authority, and you better be afraid that if you come up with the wrong answer, my authority will be used to your detriment." All of those are subverting people's moral responsibility to think for themselves. Those are immoral people. The consequences of reason are fundamental.
- 1.61 OK, here's his word for that. Enthusiasm. By what he means here is the common problem of, as we put it, intense fanatical approaches to using your mind. People who want to either have positions of social authority, they are intellectually lazy, they don't want to have to do the hard work or, for various other psychological reasons, are subverting themselves and thereby going to be subverting your process and undermining the social fabric. What we want is people who are their own lives, they're rational, who are thinking through various things, and who are dealing with other individuals as rational individuals.
- 1.62 That means a strong amount of tolerance, because we know, when people start to think for themselves, they're going to make lots of mistakes. They're going to be at various partial stages along the way. You have to be willing to work through that process if we're going to have a moral society all through. This is all very modern. Now, I want to go back here. This has political implications, and I want to just put the word revolution out there. I've used it already a few times, but revolution more pointedly in a political context. With this new understanding of what morality is and where it comes from, there are important political implications.
- 1.63 When we are doing politics, we're talking about force. When, of course, the tradition has been, "I'm just more powerful so I can just make you do," or "I will claim that God chose me to be your ruler, so again, I can make you do what I want you to do." Locke and the early moderns are inverting that, say no. It starts with every human being who has their own capacity for reasoning, self-responsibility, and self-governance. We form social organizations from the bottom up, and they only have authority as delegated by those bottom-up forces, including political authorities.
- 1.64 When those political authorities forget that, as all of history teaches us that they will do, within a generation or two, we should never forget that the original authority, moral authority for their power, resides with the people. When they get too far out of bounds, we have the right to rebel, to take away the power from them and restore it to its proper place, which is in the people at large.
- 1.65 By the time we get to the end of the 1600s, to the opposite of where we began in 1603 with King James, who was saying, "The King is chosen by God. Who are you to question God? Who are you to question me? You will obey. You will know your place," to Locke, speaking for many of the early moderns, saying, "No, it's the exact opposite. You are a man, and you have your reason, but so do I, so do we all. Your authority, to the extent that you are a political authority, is because we chose you, and we can unchoose you. If

you get out of line, then we're to start treating you the way we start treating savage animals. We use physical coercion to deal with them."

- 1.66** Quick summary. There's a lot of words, but there's a judgment call here. What's essential in Locke. Morality is demonstrable. Human beings are rational. We're individuals. We each have their own capacity for thinking and self-governance. We should be free agents. Socially, we need to be tolerant of other people's thinking with respect to their own lives and how they are acting. We have rights, including the right to political revolution. The goal of life is to achieve happiness. We organize our moral philosophy around those concepts. Time marches on.
- 1.67** In this first lecture, to say that getting rid of the old hierarchical understanding of what it is to be moral and replacing it with a liberty-oriented, was not the only move that was made by early modern. As we quickly got into the modern world, there's a lot of social and political revolutions going on. Monarchies and old aristocracies are being weakened all over Europe. What are we going to replace them with? Liberty is one of those answers. But another prominent answer that came that was argued on moral grounds was by this gentleman, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, a Frenchman who was born in the generation after John Locke, and spent much of his career in France. He was originally a citizen of Geneva. But he wrote in the French language.
- 1.68** I think the best way to think about him is, he is the anti-Locke. Everything I said about Locke, Rousseau is going to contest and contest fundamentally. This is a title of his perhaps most famous work, *The Discourse on the Origin of Inequality*. As the title suggests, what Rousseau now is going to suggest is hierarchy, that old-fashioned way of doing things, is wrong. But what's wrong with it is not that people were expected to be obedient and know their place in the hierarchy. That is to say, we didn't respect their freedoms and their liberties. The problem with hierarchy was that people were unequal in their rights and responsibilities. It's going to be inequality that is the bad concept fundamentally, and a kind of equality that is going to be substituted. Let's see a little bit how this works out.
- 1.69** Rousseau asks us to consider all of the inequalities that we see in our society now. Now, this is mid-1700s France. It's still a monarchy. One of the many Louises is still the king. There's a wide range of aristocrats who have a significant amount of power, although the monarchy has the highest amount of power. There's a whole hierarchical Catholic Church that has been quite ruthless with respect to its religious minorities in order to keep its position in the French establishment. But at the same time, France is starting to become a modern world, and it has opened itself up to markets around the world, opened itself up to some ideas.
- 1.70** There's all of these different ideas floating around, and people have been exploring, because of the influence of all of these modern ideas, different ways of living their lives. Some have succeeded and become rich and successful. Others have failed terribly. What we have is a society that is socially hierarchical, economically hierarchical,

religiously hierarchical. There are just inequalities along every social dimension. Rousseau is horrified by this, and he asked, where did all of this come from? "How shall we know the source of inequality between men, if we do not begin by knowing mankind?"

- 1.71** Now, again, we're going to do morality and we're going to start by studying mankind. We're not going to turn to God and religion and religious institutions. We're signaling that we are modern. We're going to start by the study of mankind in the natural world. The most important concept is this concept of inequality. But we have a problem here because, when we look at people in now-modern times, it's very hard to figure out what human nature is because human nature has been developing over the course of many centuries with all kinds of social pressures and modifications and so forth, so that we have overlain our natural cells with all sorts of artificial things, including the clothes that we wear, or various pieces of technologies, the way we organize our society.
- 1.72** How do we look at actual human beings and sort out what's natural and what's artificial? That's a very hard problem, particularly by the time we become adults and we have been systematically taught certain things are just right about being a human being. Certain things are "natural" to human beings. The problem then is, "the human soul, altered in society by a thousand causes perpetually recurring, has, so to speak, changed in appearance, so as to be hardly recognizable." We don't see natural human beings when we look around. We see nature hidden under all of these artificial layers that have developed over the course of many, many centuries.
- 1.73** A suggestion that we aren't going to approach this intellectually or scientifically. "Throwing aside, therefore, all those scientific books," a little bit of sarcastic language here, "which teaches only to see men such as they have been made themselves, and contemplating the first and most simple operations of the human soul." So a suggestion here, we're not going to follow a scientific route in doing so. Science is now going to be a bit of a bad word. Prior to our allegedly scientific accumulations, "I can perceive in it," that is to say, inside the human soul, "two principles prior to reason." Prior to reason. Pausing also here.
- 1.74** We're not going to say that what is fundamental to human beings, unlike John Locke, is that we are rational animals. That's not fundamental to us. Prior to that are other things. "One of them deeply interesting us in our own welfare and preservation," what we might call an instinct, although that's a word that has lots of baggage, an instinct for self-preservation. Perhaps that is more fundamental than reason. "And the other exciting a natural repugnance at seeing any other sensible being, and particularly any of our own species, suffer pain or death." Another, perhaps, instinct that automatically makes us, seeing ourselves or someone else experiencing pain or suffering, a compassion that we don't like that.
- 1.75** The suggestion is that, perhaps first and foremost, when we're looking at human nature, which is where we want to start, human beings are not first and foremost

rational beings, and that our moral responsibility is to cultivate our rationality and become more scientific. But rather, prior to that, to go to certain passions or feelings or instincts, an instinct for self-preservation and a pity or compassion that we feel toward those who are suffering. That's more fundamental to human nature.

- 1.76** With that suggestion, we turn to inequality in particular. How do we diagnose the inequalities? Rousseau wants to say, well, there's two kinds of inequalities. There's physical inequalities. Some people are this big, this small, this fast, this slow, etc. So there are all these physical differences. Those are just natural. That's where those ones come from. But also, we have moral or political inequalities. Here, an important concept that redounds through the ages, that if it's not a natural physical inequality, it is a privilege. There are privileges that are socially granted to some human beings and not to others. As he puts it here, all privileges are ones "which some men enjoy to the prejudice of others."
- 1.77** What we decide socially, and have decided over the course of centuries, is some people get certain advantages and others don't. That's a privilege because it is socially granted, it's not physically natural. What we have then is a combination of human beings that have, of course, some natural or physical differences from each other, but a large number of privileges that have been built up to the advantage of some people and at the expense of other people, along lots of different social dimensions. The examples, some people are more rich, some people are more honored, some people are more powerful, and it's on the basis of all of those social privileges that they then are able to make other people obey them.
- 1.78** Obedience is not natural. It is socially generated through all of the privileges that have accumulated over the course of the centuries. A suggestion here that we don't want to be too intellectual in this project. If we're going to start again, "O man, of whatever country you are, and whatever your opinions may be, behold your history, such as I have thought to read it, not in books." Don't read books to figure these things out. That is just going to be all of the so-called philosophers and theologians and political apologists who are trying to tell you what they want to do. Rather, look to nature. Nature never lies. All of the authorities who have written those books, they are, as he puts it here, liars.
- 1.79** Things that come from nature are true. Things that come from social sources are, at best, suspect. Set those ones aside. Then he says, look at how we are, how we live in this modern world, "discontented with your present state." Everybody's unhappy. Everybody's whiny and complaining and nervous and worried about this, that, and the other thing, "for reasons which still threaten your unfortunate descendants with still greater discontent." Then a suggestion, "You will perhaps wish it were in your power to go back." Right now, we have all of these inequalities and we're all so unhappy. Don't we just want to go back to a simpler time, a more natural time?

- 1.80 We're not going to necessarily go forward into this scientific, technological world that John Locke perhaps is painting for us. Don't we want to go back to an earlier time? In that earlier time, all of these social privileges that have made us so unequal and miserable will be much less, and we will then be happier. So, our project then is, as we say here, "to strip this being," that is to say us, "of all of the supernatural gifts he may have received and all of the artificial faculties he can have acquired," to go back to the earliest human beings. What were we like in those simpler times?
- 1.81 Well, "I see him satisfying his hunger at the first oak, and slaking his thirst at the first brook, finding his bed at the foot of the tree which afforded him a repast." He was living in a natural world that, as he suggests here, was never mutilated by the ax, all these tools and technologies, which are, of course, products of reason, but they enable some people to get richer and more powerful than other people and therefore make us more miserable. Back to the earliest days when we were living a simple life, more in harmony with our own instincts and in harmony with nature, that was a better circumstance for human beings.
- 1.82 Now, I want to jump ahead here. In that natural state, Rousseau wants to argue, our reason had not yet been awakened. Now, just to think by analogy to religious times and religious tracts that say, if we go back to the earliest human beings, we had simple human beings in the Garden of Eden, and everything was wonderful and beautiful, and human beings were not yet rationally awakened. Rousseau was offering a somewhat secularized version of that. Go back to primitive human beings in unspoiled nature, and reason has not yet been awakened.
- 1.83 Human beings, of course, had instincts that led them to drink and to eat as necessary, but they were eating natural foods, not all this artificial stuff that makes us sick. They were tough, they were hardy because they had to work and they had to fight off some animals and so forth in order to stay alive. Not only were they not eating unhealthy foods, but they were reliant on their bodies for getting what they needed. They didn't have all these tools and technologies that make us weak because we don't use our muscles anymore. And so we didn't need doctors and all that modern medicine stuff. Often doctors just make things worse for us rather than curing us. This is 1700s medicine, to keep that in mind.
- 1.84 Compassion was stronger among human beings. What he's going to argue then is, just as in religious texts, Eve taking the fruit from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Think about that phrase. That's a sin. Human beings becoming knowledgeable, rational. Secularize that. Human beings, compassionate and natural living, prior to the awakening of reason and technology and all of that stuff, that was better. But the big problem had occurred. "It is plain that such identification must have been more perfect in a state of nature than it is in a state of reason." Somehow, though, in human beings, reason was awakened.

- 1.85** We're not going to give a religious explanation because we are Rousseau. We're not a religious thinker. We are a modern thinker. But reason is still, if we can use this language, the original sin. It's the bad boy. "It is plain that such an identification must have been more perfect in a state of nature than it is in a state of reason. It is reason that engenders self-respect." If you start to be rational, you start to say, "Hey, I'm special. I'm important. I respect myself. And maybe I respect myself more than I respect you. Me versus you now."
- 1.86** And on reflection, it confirms that "it is reason which turns man's mind back upon itself, and divides him from everything that could possibly disturb or afflict him. It is philosophy," that is to say, rational reflection about your place in the universe, "that isolates him and bids him say, at sight of the misfortunes of others, 'Perish, if you will, I am secure.'" What Rousseau is saying is somehow human beings started to become rational. They started then to become self-responsible. They started to take charge of their own lives, and some of us became successful in our own lives.
- 1.87** Becoming successful in our own lives is, "I don't need the rest of you. I've got my stuff, and I feel good about myself because of what I did in my life." All of this then means I distance myself from you, I stop caring about the rest of you very much, and I turn in on myself, and I start to think of myself as better than you are. Of course, you're all doing the same thing. We start to become unequal, unequal rather, and isolated.
- 1.88** Sex. What happens to the physical part? It's not only that we start to become concerned with riches and being richer than our neighbors. We start to change our natural instinct of sexuality, which says it's physical, it's natural, brings man and woman together for momentary pleasures, propagates the species. But then what happens when we become rational? We start to become alert to differences among human beings. We start to have our own rational preferences, and we start to have imaginations. We start to prefer some people on the basis of all of their physical identifications that we are much more scientific about analyzing, but also their social status, and whom I can have sex with, and whom I will let have sex with me, then becomes this very complicated social, civilized process.
- 1.89** Whereas earlier, as he puts it, in the state of nature, well, you just followed your instincts. "He follows solely the character nature has implanted in him, and not tastes which he could have never acquired, so that every woman equally answers his purpose." So men need sex, but in the early stages, just basically any woman would do. But how does it happen now? Well, now we are rational. We're attending to all of these other dimensions of social difference and physical difference, and we think we are civilized, and it becomes extraordinarily complicated. But what happens in our love lives? It's a disaster.
- 1.90** "The imagination," a rationally awakened imagination, "which causes such ravages among us. It is therefore incontestable that love, as well as all of the other passions, which must have been acquired in societies that glowing impetuosity, which makes it

so often fatal to mankind." Fatal to mankind. Now, notice how we do love in the modern world. Jealousy, vengeance. Think of all of the cheating that goes on. "Duels, murders, and worse crimes." We're supposed to say rationally, be eternally committed to each other and faithful. But of course, we are not. Adultery. "The very laws of honor and continence" are necessarily making us do the opposite. We become more debauched, that is to say, perverted in our sex and love lives, and leading to the multiplication of abortions.

- 1.91** Terrible, terrible stuff happens because we got away from our simple, natural, more instinctual life and developed our reason, our standards, our extraordinarily complicated civilization, and everything is a mess. All right. "How greatly then the natural inequality of mankind," which was relatively limited, "is increased by social inequality." All of the problems that we have, the economic problems, the political problems, the religious intolerances, how we conduct our sex lives, and so forth, is because we got away from our original natural condition.
- 1.92** Now, if we could go back to the beginning of time, that would be great, but we can't. The genie is out of the bottle, so to speak. The cat is out of the bag, whatever metaphor you want to call it. The best that we can do going forward, and we have to go forward, Rousseau is not going to be a conservative that says we just need to go back to the Middle Ages or to some prior existence. What we need to do, though, is say, here we are in a modern civilization that is incredibly unhappy and unequal. We can contrast that to our original natural condition, where everyone was pretty equal and life was simple. Then recognize that somewhere in the middle is probably the best that we can do.
- 1.93** If we can go back to when human beings were organized in a more tribal fashion, smaller groups of 100, 200, perhaps 500 people, there, we were more rational. Things were a little bit more complicated. There were some inequalities, but nothing on the scale of what has happened in modern civilization. What we will find Rousseau arguing for, "This period of expansion of the human faculties," and just think about human tribes and human organizations, say, prior to when Columbus crossed the ocean. The way human beings lived then in most parts of the world. "This period of expansion of the human faculty, keeping a just mean," a middle state, "between the indolence of the primitive state," the earliest times, "and the petulant activity of our egoism must have been the happiest and most stable of epochs."
- 1.94** That was when human beings had the best that they could realize in human history. So that should be the moral standard that organizes us now. Simpler times, more natural, more equal. Reason and freedom lead to disaster, the disaster being our current circumstance. Quick summary of key points from Rousseau. We'll try to do this at the end of each major philosopher. A lot of concepts, but we don't want to be too rational and too civilized. These are not good fundamental concepts. They lead to problems.

- 1.95 Human beings are naturally passionate creatures. Passions are more fundamental, particularly the passion for self-preservation and compassion with respect to other people. We want to have equality across as many social dimensions as we possibly can because that keeps all of the social discord within more manageable bounds. Probably the best level of organization is not just isolated people going around doing their own individual things, certainly not complicated modern civilization, but human tribal-level organization.
- 1.96 Then Rousseau is going to argue that, since we have gotten so far away from natural inequality, and it's created so many pathologies that are obvious in modern society, we need a revolution to destroy the current levels of civilization, take things back to the earliest stage we possibly can, and rebuild society, but keeping it within the bounds of equality.

Lecture 2: Kant

At a glance — Kant.

- 2.1 Let's start with 1788, exactly one century after the Glorious Revolution in England. Not only all of England, but all of Europe has been transformed significantly in the 1700s. The philosopher we're most going to focus on in this session is Immanuel Kant. If you Google or otherwise search for the most important philosophers of the modern era, perhaps even of all time, most philosophers, whether they agree with him or disagree with him strongly or violently, will put Kant at the very top of their list.
- 2.2 The era of the long 1700s, from basically the time of John Locke, say, through 1790, 1800, on into the Napoleonic era, as we sometimes think in political history, is the age of the Enlightenment. The age of the Enlightenment is a self-descriptive label the intellectuals of the 1700s came up with when they realized how the modern world had changed and the intellectual framework, especially, within which we think about our place in the world. Clearly, we are doing religion and art on a very different basis and in a different way, much more naturalistic. The modern sciences that we will now recognize, physics, mathematics, chemistry, even biology, have been formulated.
- 2.3 By the time we get to 1788, for the first time in human history, anti-slavery societies have come into existence. Not just a few isolated voices saying maybe there's something wrong with slavery, but large numbers of people saying that slavery is a moral abomination, a violation of human rights. Every individual should be free and perhaps equal in important respects. We should do something about it. The first, what we might call feminist approaches, that women, too, are rational and capable of self-governance and getting a good education and should be free and at least politically equal individuals.
- 2.4 All of this is going on in the 1700s, and the Age of the Enlightenment then is a stepping back and saying, in all of these areas, art and science and religion and politics and the economics and issues of slavery and women and so forth, we have transformed ourselves intellectually into modern thinkers, and we're increasingly trying to do the same thing, put those ideas into practice in society, transforming social and political institutions. That's the Enlightenment.
- 2.5 The Counter-Enlightenment was a movement that immediately began, even at the height of the Enlightenment. Rousseau is a part of that, saying modernity and rationality and all of this freedom and science and technology is suspect and perhaps even bad. The fundamentals, we need to reject this new way of doing things that the Enlightenment recommends, and perhaps go back to the good old days, as conservatives will argue, philosophical conservatives now, or we should go perhaps forward, not in the old ways, but not in this modern Enlightenment way. So the intellectual framework becomes complicated.

- 2.6 Immanuel Kant is going to be a thinker who has a foot in both worlds, in his reputation since his major writings of the 1780s, 1790s. He died in early 1800s. There's a great debate about whether Kant fundamentally should be classified as an Enlightenment thinker or as a Counter-Enlightenment thinker. Sometimes it depends on whether one is talking about his epistemological views about knowledge, his understanding of human nature, his moral theory, his political theory. He was a deep, systematic, comprehensive philosopher. His legacy is accordingly complicated. My view is that Kant has elements of both. The proper weighting of each, let's set that aside for now. We can come back to that possibly later, and you can make up your own minds about Kant's proper position.
- 2.7 But 1788, Kant is recognized as the leading philosopher of Germany, or at least the German states. There's not a modern German country, rather. There's a collection of principalities, but there is a king in Prussia, and Kant is teaching at a university in Prussia, then called Königsberg. There is King Frederick William II. He is very concerned with what has happened to religion over the course of the Enlightenment. All of this free thinking, all of this religious toleration, all of this idea that people should be naturalistic and be individualistic and do their own thing and be self-governing in their lives, including their religious lives. What that has led to is, not only a whole variety of different views on religion, but challenges to the proper authority of the king when it comes to matters of religion.
- 2.8 The Enlightenment also has been an era of reason that we need to think through everything and give good arguments for all of our beliefs and not pretend to know more than we think we know. That has led to a widespread undermining of traditional faith. People are saying, "I'm just not sure if religion is correct, particularly my religion. I don't know if I can give a really good argument for the existence of God and the truth of all of my religion's particular doctrines" and so forth, including many of the intellectuals starting to say, well, not only do we need to separate church and state, but maybe we don't need this religion hypothesis to explain the world. We can be thoroughly naturalistic, thoroughly scientific, and perhaps, with enough work, natural philosophy and science can explain all of the important questions of life.
- 2.9 This is horrifying to Frederick William II, the king of Prussia. He asks his minister, speaking in his name, to issue a proclamation. The proclamation boils down to saying, you know, this free thinking and free press and free speech has gotten out of hand. At least in Prussia, we're going to rein things in. It's worth attending to this passage from the proclamation in the King's name. "Many pastors," that is to say, even official representatives of religion in Prussia, which is largely Protestant at this point, "allow themselves unbridled liberty." There's that liberty word. This is what's happened over the course. And unbridled—a bridle is an instrument you put on a horse to control its motion, and the horse should have a rider. We're going to take people's bridles off. This is a bad thing.

- 2.10** "In the treatment of the dogma of their confession, they repudiate several essential parts and basic truths of the Protestant Church and indeed of the Christian religion. They are not ashamed." They should be ashamed, but they're not. They have too much egoism and self-respect and think, "Hey, this is my decision to make." Shameful. "To warm up the miserable, long refuted errors of—" and then we get a list. "Socinians, deists, naturalists, and other sectarians." Just pausing on each of these for a moment.
- 2.11** Socinians, this is a heresy from an Orthodox Christian perspective, that says God is all-important, and we believe absolutely in the existence of God and Christianity. We think Jesus is very important, and we should follow Jesus' word, but we're not sure that Jesus is God. Prophet, great moral teacher, important guy, but a human being, not necessarily a god. He was physical, not spiritual. He existed in time, not eternal, out of time. We are monotheistic. We're not going to start messing around by introducing semi-divine beings. But this is a heresy, and Frederick William will have none of it.
- 2.12** Deists who tend to argue that God made the world, but he made the world the way a scientist-architect would make the world. He has a plan. It's a beautiful, well-thought-out mathematical plan. Everything fits together, according to all of these cause-and-effect laws. God made the world and imposed his laws upon it like a giant clockwork. But then the clock runs of itself. We don't have then a god who is intervening on a daily basis to nudge things in a certain direction. There are no miracles. God made the natural world of cause-and-effect. It's the world that the scientists study. Yes, behind that is God, but we don't need to say, "Oh, God is intervening here," and we're not necessarily going to pray to God. We're on our own in the world that God had made. Deism.
- 2.13** Naturalists, some of them saying, well, maybe we should say God and nature are the same thing. Everything is God, but God is the natural world. It's not that there's a separate other dimension. That's the unnatural world or the supernatural world. There's these two realities that obey different laws. No, everything is integrated and everything is ultimately God working itself out, and we just call it nature, sometimes Nature with a capital N, and so on. All of these other variations, philosophically and religiously, on Christianity. They should be ashamed, and this is what the Enlightenment has brought to us. We are not going to have anything of it.
- 2.14** "The impertinent impudence under the much abused banner of Enlightenment." So we're going to inaugurate some censorship, to rein things in, put the bridles back on, get people on the proper understanding of true religion and true religion under the authority of the king. Kant, as a philosopher, is then a man in the middle. On the one hand, he is a loyal subject of the king, and he's sympathetic to many of the arguments that the king is worried about and many of the Counter-Enlightenment philosophers are worried about.
- 2.15** At the same time, and here we have a slightly later painting representing the French Revolution and the move of modernity toward liberty and freedom, Kant is also

attracted to many of the ideals of the Enlightenment. So what way am I going to go? Am I going to follow my Enlightenment roots and insist upon freedom of thought, freedom of conscience, particularly as a philosopher, speaking to the public? I will speak my mind. Or will I listen to the king and follow the censorship edicts?

- 2.16** Is there perhaps then a way to form a compromise, philosophically, between these two? Traditional Christianity, most philosophers will say there are problems there. There are issues there. We can't simply go back to unthinking faith. Can we modernize the good parts, the important parts, the true parts in traditional Christianity or generalizing traditional religion to make it work in the modern world? This is going to be our project.
- 2.17** Now, so far, in the first session, I outlined three values. These are three ways of possibly organizing one's thinking and one's society. We should organize everything hierarchically. We could say human beings are free agents and should be treated as free agents and organize ourselves socially around the concept of liberty. Or we can take the concept of equality. The fundamental thing is the equality of all human beings, and any other value concept has to give way or be subordinate or work within a broadly equal framework. What should our top organizing value be? We have so far a three-way debate.
- 2.18** I want to be a little analytic for a few minutes before we go back to Kant's particular contributions to the debate and discussion and frame the course as a whole. This is an eight-lecture course. And already, in talking about the question of the meaning of life, what's the good life, the right life, the best life, and so forth, we've put a lot of assertions out there and different kinds of answers and different ways of even approaching those answers. What I want to do is suggest six organizing questions. This is the analytic philosopher part of my brain working now, providing some structure. Hopefully, this will be guiding for your postmortem on each lecture, thinking about them.
- 2.19** When we do ethics, ethics is complicated because not only do we often disagree about the content of ethics—should I always be honest or is it sometimes OK to lie? Some people say no, you should always be honest. Some people say it's all right. So is honesty a universal policy or not? But why should I be honest? Often we will give different answers to the question of why we should be honest. It's not only, what's the right answer, but how do I justify that answer, or why should I be honest?
- 2.20** If we work through the interrogatives, who, what, when, where, why, how, and so forth, there's a corresponding question, a fundamental question in ethics, that you need to answer before you have a complete system, so to speak, or a complete philosophy of ethics. Now, one of those questions is going to be this one, where do we get our ethics from? It's the where question. I have three possible answers. I don't want to say these are the only three, but three possible answers. You'll recognize them as to

say, well, as Locke and others will say, we look to nature. We get some guidance from nature. Some things are good and bad in nature, or good and bad in human nature.

2.21 Or we might say, no, if we want to get our answer from the good, where we need to look first is beyond nature to super, superior to nature, to God or a higher dimension. It provides the answers, and then we might apply them in the natural world. Another possible answer is to say, well, we don't rely on the gods. We don't rely on nature to tell us what's good or bad. Rather, we socially make up or construct the right and wrong answers. Do we get it from society? Do we get it from nature? Do we get it from supernatural. That's one important set of meta-ethical questions. This is not to say what the right answer is, just where are we supposed to start looking for answers to questions about ethics.

2.22 A second question is, what methods are we going to use, or how do we arrive at our knowledge of ethics? If we think that we're going to have knowledge That's a very strong concept, or at least beliefs about what's right and wrong. How do we get there? Do we use our reasoning? Do we use reasoning based on experience? Do we rely on faith, whatever we mean by faith? It's not necessarily rational. It's something different. Do we consult our feelings, our passions, our desires? Or is it, again, perhaps a matter of, our reason is conditioned by, say, social forces, or even our feelings are conditioned by social forces. So fundamentally, there's some social conditioning that happens, and that's how we acquire our ethics.

2.23 That's four answers possible. Again, I don't want to suggest those are the only four that are possible, but four to think about initially. These ethical standards or views about what's right and wrong, do we think that they apply to everybody? That position is universal. If something is good, it's good for everyone. The same standard of, say, honesty. Or is it the case that, collectively, sorry, individually, we have our own standards? And that what's good for you is not necessarily good for everyone, collectively.

2.24 Another way to slice this one is to say, when we are doing our ethics, are we first looking at individuals as individuals? We recognize that, yes, they are part, perhaps, of a species and share some things in common with all human beings, but they're also unique as individuals. Are we looking at individuals as individuals, or are we taking a more collective approach and saying, people as individuals are, say, part of a certain group? It's as part of a certain group that what is good or bad for them is appropriate.

2.25 So first and foremost, say, you're a member of a family collective and you have perhaps obligations as a member of the family, or you're a member of a certain ethnicity or a certain nation or a certain religion. As an individual, you are subordinate to or secondary to the collective, or we say no, individuals first and foremost are unique, separate, self-responsible, and we do our ethics there. So to whom? There was a closely related question about universality and relativism. Do our answers, when we

come up them, apply then universally? It doesn't matter what group you're a member of or who you are as an individual, there will be the same general standard of morality.

- 2.26** So if courage, however we've defined courage, is a good thing, a virtue for human beings to have, it's universal to all human beings. It doesn't matter who you are as an individual, and it also doesn't matter what groups you are a part of. Courage is a universal virtue of human beings. Or do we say that no, there is no such thing as a universal goodness. Maybe we disagree about absolutely everything, but rather, what's good is going to depend on perhaps time and place, and perhaps it's going to depend on what group you are a member of. There are no universal standards.
- 2.27** What exactly is the good? Where are we looking for this good? How are we thinking about it or deciding what's good? We're thinking of people as individuals or members of a collective. We think we're coming up with universal standards or relative standards. Well, what is this good that we have come up with, when we've looked in the right place, when we've been conditioned appropriately, or we've thought about it properly, or we've consulted the proper feelings? What exactly is this thing that is good?
- 2.28** One possible answer is to follow, again, possibly a more Lockean line and say, "Well, your life is yours. It's your self-responsibility, and your purpose in life is to become happy." So we have a egoistic approach to ethics. Or we might say, you're a member of a group and you have obligations to the group. And in fulfilling your obligations, you might not be happy all of the time or even at all. Maybe you need to sacrifice for the good of the group, which is more important than yours. So a more perhaps altruistic set of content to our ethics.
- 2.29** Or we might say it's neither of those. We could say, well, we're all in conflict with each other. Perhaps life is a jungle, and there's your good, and there's my good, and I am going to satisfy my good at your expense. But of course, you're trying to satisfy your good at my expense. And so there's no universal happy-ever-after; it's a contest of winners and losers. That's what's the good life. Another question. Well, why should I do the whatever I identify the good as being? Is it because, if I follow the good, it will lead to certain consequences? Those are what we are striving to achieve. Maybe flourishing, maybe salvation, maybe equality collectively. But there's some set of good results out there in the world that we want, or perhaps inside our souls or ourselves.
- 2.30** So all of the things that we identify as the good are things that we need to do because they're going to lead to that set of good consequences. Or is it the case that, when we are functioning as moral beings, we shouldn't be thinking about consequences? Some things are just right and some things are just wrong. When we identify things as, in principle, right or wrong, we have an obligation to do the right things and to avoid the wrong things, independently of how things work out in the world.

- 2.31** I might say, for example, honesty is a good policy, except sometimes white lies are OK, as we call them, because, if I tell a white lie, I'm going to avoid, say, hurting someone's feelings in a really bad way. So I want to avoid that bad consequence. That's why I might tell the white lie, even if my general policy for most of the time is to tell the truth. But then I might say, look, telling the truth is an obligation. It's a duty. It's an absolute duty. You should never lie, even if it leads to bad consequences. Morality is not about the consequences.
- 2.32** So what I want to suggest then is, we have six framing questions, and we need to think about each of those in developing our moral philosophy. What we will find then is, now putting these all on a table, obviously, there's different packages of answers that are possible to each of those. Each of those questions has a range of debate. Then people who are thoughtful about moral philosophy will choose different answers and then put them together into an overall package. So, think in terms of a chart. I might answer the moral philosophy questions this way.
- 2.33** Where do I look for the right answers? I look to God. How do I come to believe? I believe on faith. I think that God's word speaks to everyone, universally. We, as human beings, are a collective entity all to come together and worship God. But we all have obligations to serve other people in society, selflessly, sacrificially, so we should be altruistic. Why should I be good? Well, because it is my duty to be a good person. We put all of those together. That's a package, a moral philosophy.
- 2.34** I might, by contrast, though, say no. Maybe there's a god, I don't know, or maybe I don't think there is a god at all. Morality comes from society. We're all born into a society that has standards, right and wrong ways of doing things. We are conditioned to believe certain things as good or bad. That's how we acquire the beliefs that we have. Different societies have come up with really different answers. So there are no universal answers. Everything is relative. But you are first and foremost a part of a society. You have a role to serve in that collection or that collective of human beings.
- 2.35** I might also then say, well, your job is to serve others in society, play your role in that particular society. Our society has certain goals that it's trying to achieve, certain consequences that it wants to arrive at. That's my moral philosophy put together in a package. Then obviously, between those two positions, lots of debates that are possible. I might then say, no. I look at myself in nature. I don't first see myself as a fragment or an element of society. I have my own mind, my own life. I have my rational capacity. I should develop it, think it through.
- 2.36** But we're all human beings, so we're going to have the same general standards of what it is to be a rational human being. We should all be coming up with those ones. My goal is to function as an individual, taking responsibility for my own thoughts, my own character, my own actions. I want to achieve happiness in my life, so I have a broadly egoistic framework. And I, again, of course, I'm interested in consequences. I want to flourish. I want to survive and survive well. That's my moral framework.

- 2.37** Now, that's, so far, that's just three packages that are pushed together. There are others, as we go on over the course of these lectures, let me suggest the philosophers I have chosen in the eight lectures. We're actually going to touch on 11 philosophers altogether. Each of them represents different sets of answers to all of those questions. So you will have 11 competing moral philosophies to sort out in your mind and then do your own, of course, choices about where you think the truth lies.
- 2.38** So I say, partly I chose them because they represent the diversity of thinking of moral philosophy in the last several hundred years. It's one thing that's characteristic of the modern world, is that we have this diversity of moral thinking, and we expect the diversity of moral thinking, in contrast to much of premodern philosophy, where, by and large, people expected everybody to be more or less on the same page with respect to the important moral questions. All of that has gone away in the modern world.
- 2.39** I also want to suggest that the 11 that we're looking at not only represent different possible philosophy packagings on all of these ethics questions, but each of them is influential and famous and deservedly so. They made important, powerful arguments that convinced lots of other smart people to take them seriously, and, in many cases, to apply them. So these are all, so to speak, household names and deservedly so now, even in the 21st century.
- 2.40** Now, that said, I want to come back to Kant, who is a giant in the philosophical landscape, and suggests that, in addition to juggling and trying to forge a compromise between Enlightenment thinking and Counter-Enlightenment thinking, he does signal among earlier philosophies some respect, and in other cases, disrespect. There's one point that we can make here is that Kant thinks well of Rousseau. There's a famous passage in one of his writings where he says Rousseau taught him how to become a more moral human being. Before I read Rousseau, I was contemptuous of most people. I was somewhat cynical and elitist in my thinking. I despised the people who know nothing. Rousseau corrected me in this. This blinding prejudice disappeared; I learned to honor man.
- 2.41** So, so far in the modern world, Rousseau is going to be more on the right track. Locke, on the wrong track. I'm going to do a number of pairings of some quotations from Kant with earlier quotations from Locke. Here's on the moral status of human beings. One of the big debates is, are we born good, bad, or neutral? Or sometimes we call it *tabula rasa*, you're a blank slate or a white piece of paper. The Lockean position against many centuries of the predominance of a view that human beings are born bad, born sinful, that we spend our lives, so to speak, trying to correct our natural badness.
- 2.42** Locke starts from a position of neutrality. You're not born good, you're not born bad. You become good or bad depending on the thinking, the character that you acquire, the actions that you engage in. So you're born with a blank slate. "I considered, only as white paper or wax, to be molded and fashioned as one pleases." Human nature is

quite flexible, malleable. By the time we become mature human beings, "I may say that, of all the men we meet, nine parts of 10 are what they are, good or evil, useful or not, by their education." So crude philosophy math, 90% of who you are, you're not born with it. It depends on your education, and that includes your self-education, the choices that you make.

- 2.43** By contrast, Kant, in one of his major works on religion, one of the chapter headings, The Human Being Is By Nature Evil. We start as evil beings, and a large part of morality is trying to correct for or overcome the natural evil that we start with. That's a deep point of disagreement. As we saw earlier, John Locke is emphasizing freedom and play and the pursuit of happiness as organizing principles in life. He said, when we are educating ourselves and educating people, we should not make it as a business, the way people think about, oh, I have to get up and go to work and all these things that I have to do. It should be rather not that. It should be play, recreation. We're here to enjoy our lives in some fundamental.
- 2.44** The quotation we looked at in the first session, we love liberty and, I think, learning, and in fact, all of your life should be play and recreation. Of course, there are things that we have to do, but things that we have chosen that we have to do because ultimately, we think, this is the life that I want to do because I want to play in this area, or these are the kinds of things, ideally, I would do even if I wasn't being paid for. It's the kind of things I would do in my recreation. So this optimistic tabula rasa, freedom, play, happiness approach to life.
- 2.45** By contrast, thinking exactly about Locke here says, "One often hears it said that we should put everything before children in such a way that they shall do it from inclination." That is to say, we should find what children's natural inclinations are. What do they want to do? What choices do they make? What interests them? And so forth. And then organize as much as possible our education around that. Kant is saying no, no, no. In some cases, that's OK. But the more important concept here is, "We must place before them as duty." What children need to learn is some things are right, some things are wrong. This is what you are supposed to do, as a matter of duty, not because you are inclined to do it or you want to do it because you're supposed to do it. That's the proper, more fundamental.
- 2.46** He draws an analogy to adult life. In the paying of rates and taxes, you're an adult citizen; you have an obligation to pay your taxes. The work of the office, you have all of these duties and obligations that you are required to do. We must be led not by inclination, but by duty. Duty is more fundamental. Punishment. Should we have strict education? When we see the police as we're walking around, we worry about the police, for example, that they might catch me and punish me doing various things. Do I avoid punishment as an orientation in my life?
- 2.47** Now, on this issue, Locke had argued, we should really, when we're raising people, go light on punishment. "I'm very apt to think that great severity of punishment does but

very little good." Here he's talking about children. "Nay, great harm in education," raising kids. "I believe it when we found that, *ceteris paribus*," that is to say, keeping all other conditions equal, "those children who have been most chastised," that is to say, wagging fingers and punishment and admonishments, "seldom make the best men." So, go light on punishment, give children more slack, cut them some slack, and that will prepare them for a self-governing life, rather, which we aren't going to have the police and so forth, standing in as strict parents waiting for you to do something wrong so that you can be punished.

- 2.48** By contrast, with Kant, with the expectation that human beings are born evil, and that there's all of these duties that we need to teach children, to obey, that they naturally don't want to do. They are going to mess up on a fairly regular basis, and there's going to be a lot of punishment that is required to correct them, to keep them on the straight and narrow. "Every transgression in a child, and there will be lots of them, is a want of obedience." And obedience to doing one's duty, is the more fundamental concept, "and this brings punishment with it."
- 2.49** While in Locke's writings, you find not very much about punishment, much more in the case of Kant. Sound mind and a sound body, happiness, we saw that quotation. For Kant, by contrast, if we're talking about what it is to be a good person, a virtuous person, you're not going to be attending to the sensuous, the sensual, the physical, the materialistic, very much. It is a character, soul, or mind part of the side. There's more of a split between the mental side and the bodily side in Kant. "To behold virtue in her proper shape is nothing other than to show morality stripped of all admixture with the sensuous and of all of the spurious adornments of reward or self-love."
- 2.50** You're not doing things to become a better person for yourself so you can like yourself, so you can act successfully in the world and achieve your happiness goals, and perhaps they become rich and have a great sex life and all of that stuff. Rather, virtue is separate. Moral character is separate from. It's stripped from admixture with any of that. It is something that is pure and good in itself. Now, the concept of obedience, closely related to the concept of duty—if we're going to do morality correctly, we need to identify duties and get people initially to be obedient to duties.
- 2.51** Why? Not because we think we're going to get some rewards if we are good little boys and good little girls, but we're going to obey what is dutiful because we have recognized it as correct and we have decided to obey it for its own sake. Now here, what Kant wants to argue is that traditional religion has been on the right track with this emphasis on duties and commands and being obedient. There's lots of punishment that has happened in traditional religious scriptures, but that that needs to be purified and improved in the modern world in a certain way.
- 2.52** I want to suggest that we can go back to the Old Testament or Hebrew scriptures and focus on one passage that Kant wants to suggest takes us in the right direction initially. We'll see where that goes. This is a story from Samuel, where, for various reasons,

Hebrews wanted to move the Ark of the Covenant, which is their most important collection of religious documents, from one place to another. But there is a rule that no one is allowed to touch the actual Ark of the Covenant. In very careful ways, without actually touching it, they get it loaded up onto a wagon and they transport it to this new, safer place, away from whoever's going to possibly damage it.

- 2.53** And Uzzah is one of the men charged with moving the ark and shepherding it along its way. That's the context for the story. "And they carried the Ark on a new cart," and brought it out of this place and took it to this new place. "When they came to the threshing floor of Nacon, Uzzah put his hand out to the Ark of God and took hold of it, for the oxen stumbled." So one of the ox stumbled. The cart went this way. The Ark, it looked like it was going to tumble out, crash to the ground and be damaged in some way. So Uzzah puts his hand out to steady it. Good thing, bad thing. "And the anger of the Lord was kindled against Uzzah, and God struck him down there because of his error, and he died there beside the Ark of God."
- 2.54** This is one of those stories where you say, whoa. It forces on us then to make a distinction. What was Uzzah's error? He disobeyed a command. The command was, "You do not touch the Ark." It's not that you make exceptions to that, if you, in your own thinking, judge that there will be better consequences. It's not your decision. It's not about consequences. You have been issued a command, you follow the command. You broke that command, and that brings punishment instantly.
- 2.55** Now, here we have a certain conception of morality. That is, there are duties that come to us in the form of commands. Those commands are absolute and universal. They hold for all circumstances. You accept them on trust or faith, whatever word we want to put in there, and you don't worry about the consequences. Uzzah made a mistake. That's his mistake in moral thinking. And the punishment then was immediate.
- 2.56** Now, we have a similar story that happens earlier, the story of Eve and Adam. Eve picked the apple, took a bite, passes it off to Adam, so he is then complicit in the sin as well. Again, it was disobedience. There was a command. "Don't eat the fruit of this tree." It's not a matter of if you think it looks tasty and it will gratify your desires, in some respect, lead to good consequences. It's an absolute command. You do not. She disobeyed. Adam was complicit. So then immediately, punishment happens to them, sent out of the Garden of Eden and various other things are to happen. So we have this structure.
- 2.57** But what Kant and some of the early moderns start to notice is that, as religious history develops, particularly the Judeo-Christian tradition, the time horizon changes. And toward the end of the Hebrew scriptures, and on into the New Testament, it's not so much that God is going to punish each and every transgression in the here and now, but rather there's a notion of an afterlife, and good or bad ultimately is going to happen to you in that afterlife. Now, it's the same structure of morality. Absolute commands

that you have a duty to follow, but it's because you will avoid punishment in the afterlife or you will get certain rewards in the afterlife.

- 2.58** This is an improvement because now we are thinking more long-range as human beings. We're thinking more in principle, and we're not in the here and now and focusing on just the short-range, what's going to happen to me in the next few seconds or so. What Kant is wanting to argue is that this kernel needs to be extracted and separated from the idea of rewards and punishments at all. It's not that you do the right thing because you fear being punished now. It's not that you do the right thing because you fear going to hell when you die some many years in the future. It's that you do the right thing because it's the right thing and you recognize it as such, independently of any punishments. That is a modernized, purified understanding of duty.
- 2.59** Now, Kant, as a modern, though, wants to say, we give credit to religious history where due. But as moderns, we cannot go back to just old, simple-minded religion. As moderns, I am a product of the Enlightenment, and I agree that the existence of God cannot be proven. This was, by and large, not quite a consensus, but a significant majority of intellectuals in the Age of Enlightenment who looked at all of the standard arguments for the existence of God and the arguments against, say, "We can't prove it." Kant wants to argue on principle, the existence of God cannot be proven. There are limits to what we can do.
- 2.60** Another problem that we have, though, as moderns, we are much more naturalistic, we're much more physicalistic. We've been doing all of this physics and chemistry and early biology, and we study the human being, and it doesn't seem like we have any room for free will in our mechanistic cause-and-effect, scientific understanding of what the human beings are. We are perhaps, from that perspective, just complicated animals. We don't think that animals have free will, or mechanical devices have free will, or that plants have free will, and so forth. It doesn't seem like we can even establish that we have free will.
- 2.61** Also, this idea about what happens to us after we die, that there's this thing called a soul, and it separates from our body, and it goes to this other place and it has an ultimate destiny and so on. We can't prove that either, on principle. So, if we think about how traditional religious morality has approached the idea of commands and duties without consequences that are absolute, yes. But the traditional meta-ethics and the rest of the philosophy that goes along with that to justify it, that's because we know that there's a God, and we know that we have free will, a soul that can make its own choices, and that we have this immortal destiny. We can't rely on that anymore if we are honest, informed, modern philosophers.
- 2.62** How are we, and then this is Kant's question, going to justify the proper conception of morality? Absolute duties that we follow because they are right in themselves, without that traditional basis. Now, Kant's writing that we're going to turn in a few minutes on

the Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals, a big fancy name for his fundamental approach to philosophy, published in 1785, but it's based, very importantly, on his earlier and most important work, The Critique of Pure Reason, the first edition, which was published in 1781.

- 2.63** I wanted to suggest, if you want to do serious thinking about moral philosophy, and particularly Kantian moral philosophy, you can't just look at it on its own. You have to have some familiarity with his more fundamental philosophy. In another course in this series of lectures on modern philosophy, we have a whole lecture on Kant's Critique of Pure Reason, so I would recommend that. But there are other good sources on Kant's fundamental philosophy as well.
- 2.64** What Kant wants to argue is that human beings, in their cognitive faculties, are not able to know reality as it really is, but rather we have these inbuilt structuring devices that are built into the human mind, certain forms of sensibility, as he calls them, certain categories. Whatever is out there in the real world, what he calls the noumenal world, that data comes in, but it gets structured by our unconscious minds in certain ways, and then that gets presented to our conscious minds. All we are ever able to be aware of is a structured reality as our minds have presented it to us. He calls that the phenomenal world, and that's all of this. This is the phenomenal world, the world as it appears to me.
- 2.65** But it appears to me because of these structures that are inbuilt in my mind. It's impossible for me to get outside of my own mind and to, so to speak, see or confront the world independently of all of my subjective constituting faculties. He wants to say, this is a very short, short summary here, is that it's impossible for us to say what really is out there in the world. All I can say is, this is how the world seems to me. And it does believe that we're all human beings, so we have all the same structuring capacities. We can say, this is how the world appears to us.
- 2.66** On the basis of that, perhaps we can have some shared experience of reality and our mathematics and our science is going to end up being the same, so we can do all of that project. But what we cannot ever do is speculate about what's really out there, that there really is a God out there, or that really when what seems to happen to old people's bodies as they break down and deteriorate, that there's some part of them, a soul, that nobody has ever seen or experienced that leaves their body and goes to some other place and has an immortal destiny. Can't know that. Can't know any of that. Impossible.
- 2.67** Now, on the basis of that, we cannot ever claim to know that there's a God, that we have free will, or anything about what's out there. Anything that we believe or want to posit is out there has to be a matter of faith in some sense or a matter of belief, but it's an ungrounded belief because there is no way to prove that whatever we believe is out there, really is out there. That sounds like a skeptical conclusion, which it is, but it's also one that opens the door because if you then say, I have a suspicion or I want to believe

that there is something out there that I can't prove, no one can prove that I'm wrong. And absent being proven wrong, this leaves open some wiggle room for me possibly to believe in it.

- 2.68** Our issue is going to be, we want to have a conception of morality about universal absolute commands that we recognize and we follow them, but we're not going to be able to base them on any metaphysical belief about God, immortality, free will, and so forth. So, let's turn now to his 1785 shorter work called *The Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*. That is to say, we take morals and we say, what's underlying morals, the metaphysics, or what is the fundamental principles that we are going to derive our morals from? This is a short book that he writes. He calls it a groundwork to a much longer project. I'm going to have us, as we like to do, look at some of the text.
- 2.69** "Isn't it utterly necessary to construct a pure moral philosophy that is completely freed from everything that may be only empirical and thus belong to anthropology?" All right, so there's some big words right off the bat. We want to do moral philosophy, but we want to have a pure moral philosophy, a pure set of principles. When we start talking about the language of pure, we want to say that there are certain things that, if we mix them in, are going to make it impure. Kant wants to suggest right off the bat that anything that is empirical or anything that comes from anthropology cannot be part of morality.
- 2.70** Now, what does that mean? What that means is, if we are going to get our morality, it's not because we are doing science in any fundamental sense, that we are observing the world empirically using our senses and drawing lessons about the world. We're not going to look out there and see good and bad, right and wrong. We're not going to be able to derive it from that. Equally so, anything that comes from anthropology, that is to say, from the study of human beings, that I look at me as a human being and I say, I have a certain kind of mind, or I have a certain body, or we have certain conventions and certain traditions that we follow—all of that is anthropology, and Kant is arguing that is irrelevant to ethics. That's not how we do ethics at all.
- 2.71** This is where traditional religious ethics was partly right because traditional religious ethics did not say, look out at the natural world and figure out what's good and bad by studying nature, or just derive it from your feelings and ideas that you happen to have in your head. You had to, so to speak, step away from the empirical world and step away from human nature to go somewhere else to get your ethics. That part is correct, but it's not going to be a god that we are stepping away to.
- 2.72** "There must be a philosophy is self-evident from the common idea of duty and moral laws." Then part of what he wants to argue here is that what makes something a duty is that it's going to be universalizable to all beings and recognizable by all beings who are rationally able to recognize anything. Take the principle, the command, you are not to lie. Be honest, be ruthlessly honest, be absolutely honest, never lie. That's the common idea of morality. There's going to be lots of empirical reasons that will tempt you to

want to lie. You have to ignore those. There might be lots of instincts and natural reactions where I really want to lie in this particular case and try to get away with it, if I possibly can't. You have to ignore all of that.

- 2.73** We recognize, as a moral principle, "don't lie" is an absolute duty, irrespective of any of those things. But Kant is then suggesting here that, yes, we are rational beings, and we, unlike perhaps other animals, are able to rationally recognize this as a moral principle that ought to apply in all cases. But we want to leave open the possibility that any being that is rational should be able to identify the same principles. Getting all science-fiction here for a moment, if there were aliens that were rational beings, if they were rational, they would recognize the same universal principles. Don't lie. That's where we want to go.
- 2.74** So these principles must be found a priori in the concepts of pure reason. So we're going to come out of pure reason. Now, what we're going to be arguing is that, as rational beings, what makes us moral agents is that we are able to universalize various principles like, don't lie, always be honest, and that we are going to be able, as rational beings, to recognize that there's a kind of internal contradiction to not following that principle.
- 2.75** I'll give you the example that Kant works out in greater detail coming up soon, that if I want to say, "You should be honest," as an absolute principle, and I consider the possibility of lying; if I ask you never to lie to me, but I'm going to be inconsistent and say, "Sometimes I'm going to lie to you if I think I can get away with it," what does my successful lying to you depend upon? Well, I can't lie to you successfully if you know that I'm lying. I can only lie to you successfully if you think that I am telling the truth in this case and that I am generally a truth-telling person.
- 2.76** What do I then have to do to be a liar? I have to want to contradict this principle of general lying in this particular case. I want you to believe that I generally am an honest person, but actually I'm not. I want a contradiction to come into existence or an inconsistency. But what is a fundamental principle of being a rational person? Not allowing contradictions, not being inconsistent. A liar is trying to get away with a contradiction in strong forms or in less extreme forms with inconsistencies. He wants the general principle to be in place, but then to subvert it. That's inconsistent with being a rational person.
- 2.77** What we then have is the idea of, we have these absolute duties that everyone should abide by, and they're not because some God has commanded them, but rather, we are now rational agents. As rational agencies, we can understand the idea of acting consistently on the basis of principle. That's what makes us rational beings. I can recognize that as correct. Same thing holds for various other things that we want to say, "I think that's a good general rule, but I would like to get away with it in some particular case."

- 2.78** If you ever find yourself in that situation, Kant says, you are able to recognize that you're acting immorally because you're acting inconsistently. That's to be irrational, but human beings are fundamentally rational beings. That's our strategy. "When we find the moral law in its purity," it's because we have done this rational identification of its universalizability and non-contradictory nature. That's why we are going to do it, because of that. What we have purified then is any thinking about consequences. "For something to be morally good, it isn't enough that it conforms to the moral law. It must be done because it conforms to the law. An action that isn't performed with that motive may happen to fit the moral law, but its conformity to the law will be chancy and unstable."
- 2.79** Here, Kant then is saying that you are recognizing the law as correct, and you're acting because it is correct, not because of the consequences that might emerge from it. We have purified those. Every time we are tempted to be doing something that we know is immoral, to steal something, instead of absolutely respecting property rights, to lie, instead of absolutely— it's because we're always thinking about the consequences. If I steal, there will be certain consequences. If I lie, there will be certain consequences. We have purified that out of our ethics.
- 2.80** Now, what makes a good will good? This is our motivation. Why are we doing things? We're doing things on a matter of duty, not because of results. "It isn't what it brings about, its usefulness in achieving some end." It isn't that. "Rather, a good will is good because of how it wills, that is, the good in itself." Now, suppose then we consider some examples because all this is very abstractly stated. What makes a person have a good will and when can we identify someone as actually having a good will? Let's try some examples.
- 2.81** "Suppose through bad luck or miserly endowment from step-motherly nature," suppose you just, nature has given you terrible stuff, or you've just had a lot of bad luck, "a person's will has no power at all to accomplish its purpose; not even the greatest effort on his part would enable it to achieve everything it aims at, but he still does have a good will." We imagine someone and we know his intentions are proper, his motivation is proper, but he's not at all competent to achieve his goals in the world. Do we think of him as good? Kant is saying, yes.
- 2.82** "The goodwill of this person would sparkle like a jewel all by itself, as something that had full worth in itself. Its value would not go up or down depending on how useful or how fruitless it was." Further examples. Let's go down to here. This is the concept of duty. I've identified the good and I'm doing it because it's the good, not because of the consequences. So next example, duty to preserve one's life. So you have an obligation, Kant wants to argue, to preserve your life.
- 2.83** Now, naturally, we all want to preserve our lives; we take care to preserve our lives, but why are we preserving our lives? In many cases, we will think, well, because here are the good consequences. I want to become richer, I want to have a happier, I want

to have a better love life, and so forth. So we think about consequences. Consequences —that's not where the moral worth of your preserving your life comes from. Rather, you have a duty to preserve your life, not to commit suicide. If you're doing it for that reason, that's what makes you moral.

- 2.84** "It is a duty to preserve one's life, and moreover, everyone directly wants to do so." They do it because of their passions and so forth. "But because of the power of that want, the often anxious care that most men have for their survival has no intrinsic worth; and the maxim, 'Preserve yourself,' has no moral worth. In these cases, men preserve their lives according to duty, but not from duty." This is the distinction that we need to pay attention to. How would we test this then? Say most people, they have an obligation to preserve their lives, and they want to preserve their lives. They act in a way to preserve their lives.
- 2.85** But in those cases, Kant says, if the reason you preserved your life was because you wanted to, that was your inclination, you don't get any moral credit for that. We want to find cases where people preserve their lives for the right motivation. Imagine this case. "Adversities and hopeless sorrow have completely taken away this unfortunate man's relish for life." You hate your life. "But his fate has not made him passively despondent or dejected. He is strong in soul, and is exasperated at how things have gone for him, and would like actively to do something about it. Specifically, he wishes for death." I just want to commit suicide. It's so awful.
- 2.86** Now, we know in this case, the guy does not want to live. So whatever he does, if he preserves his life, it's not because he wants to live. If, in that circumstance, he says, "Look, I have an obligation to preserve my life, and I take steps to preserve my life, even though I would rather die, then I know I'm acting according to my duty, not according to my inclinations." If he "preserves his life without loving it, not led by want or fear, but acting from duty, for this person, the maxim, 'Preserve yourself,' has moral content." Then and only then we can know he is acting morally.
- 2.87** Another example. "We have a duty to be charitably helpful when we can or where we can. And many people are so sympathetically constituted that, without any motive of vanity or selfishness, they find an inner satisfaction in spreading joy and take delight in the contentment of others if they have made it possible." So we see someone who is suffering. Our heart goes out to this person. I'm in a position to do something, and so I help this person out of charity, and I'm not expecting anything in return.
- 2.88** Am I a good person? Kant says, "We don't know," because you are acting on the basis of your inclinations. You happen to be a person who likes other people, who feels sorry for other people. You're doing it because of your emotions, your passions, your inclinations. But that's not what morality is about. It's not about satisfying your inclinations. It is about following your obligations. One of your obligations is to be charitable when you can. Again, how would we know if someone, when they are being charitable, they're not being flashy and showy, "Hey, look at me giving this money to

some poor people," they're not doing it out of that kind of vanity? How do we know that they are really doing it because they are following the duty to be moral?

- 2.89** Now consider a special case. "This person has been a friend to mankind, but since his mind has become clouded by a sorrow of his own, that has extinguished all feeling for how others are faring." So your life is so terrible that you're all depressed and all of your natural compassion has gone away. You just don't care about other people at all. So you see someone suffering, but it makes absolutely no impact on you because you are so absorbed in your own sorrows and difficulties. If, in that situation, you're able to carry yourself enough out of your own woes and recognize that you have an obligation to help someone else out, even though you don't care about that other person, and then you do it.
- 2.90** "But now he tears himself out of his dead insensibility and acts charitably purely from duty, without feeling any want or liking so to behave." Now, for the first time, his action has genuine moral worth. Now, notice the two cases. This is not about whether you love yourself or whether you love other people. It's not about whether you are egoistic or altruistic or compassionate, however we use those words. It's not about your inclinations or your desires or anything. Kant wants to say, to the extent that you have an obligation to preserve your life, you recognize that you have this duty, and you do so. And that's why you do it, not because you want to. That's irrelevant. That's acting out of duty, not out of egoism, in preserving your life.
- 2.91** If you recognize that you have a rational duty or obligation to help other people, then you do it, not because you like other people, that it bothers you to see them suffering, that you want everybody to be happy, you're a people person. If that's how you're doing it, that's not the moral motivation. That's acting on the basis of anthropology or something irrelevant. If you do it despite whatever you happen to feel about particular people as an obligation or as a duty, that's what makes it right. This is purified, recognizing duties as rational obligations and myself as a rational being, able to perform them. That is our moral code.
- 2.92** So much for the first proposition. We start to abstract here. "For an action to have genuine moral worth, it must be done from duty." That's the fundamental concept. And closely related as a corollary, "An action that is done from duty does not get its moral value from the purpose that is achieved, though, but from the maxim that it involves, giving the reason why the person acts thus." Third proposition as a corollary. "To have duty is to be required to act in a certain way out of respect for the law." There are moral laws, universal principles.
- 2.93** I, as a rational being, can recognize those purely, independently of my feelings, independently of my goals, independently of how things are going to actually play out in the world. My morality consists in revering those principles and acting accordingly. "I ought never to act in such a way that I couldn't also will that the maxim on which I act should be a universal law." Adding this component of universality that's built into

ordinary moral principles. There are no exceptions. Exceptions are a matter of going by your feelings or particular circumstances. That's not what morality is about. I, as a rational being, can abstract to universal principles that hold without condition. That's where morality holds.

- 2.94** If I find that I want to make an exception for myself or for other people, for Kant, that's always a sign of a mistake, a moral mistake. Here's the example of promises. Can I make promises? But five years later, I want to get out of my promise. No. If it's going to be a moral promise, it has to be unconditional. Otherwise, you're just contradicting yourself because then what you're saying is, yeah, I'm going to make a promise, which is an absolute commitment, unless, but secretly, there are all these exceptions. I'm going to contradict the promise, and so I'm going to stop being a moral agent. I want to sign the contract, but then ignore the contract. That's to engage myself in a contradiction.
- 2.95** Now, this is what Kant officially calls a categorical imperative. This is a term of art, a technical term, file it away. Anytime you think about Kant, categorical imperative. An imperative is a command. Do this. That's what traditional religious moralities got correct. Morality is a set of commands from God. A categorical imperative is one that holds for the entire category, so to speak, for all of us as human beings who are rational agents, rational moral agents. It holds universally for all of us in that category, all these commands.
- 2.96** Hypothetical imperatives, that's the contrast. These are always the ones that we need to be suspicious of. A hypothetical imperative is something like, if you want to achieve certain goals, then act a certain way. So hypothetically, here's your goal that you want to achieve, a certain set of consequences, then act a certain way. A hypothetical example would be, suppose I'm in business and I'm saying, should I be dishonest with my customers? If I think, well, if I'm dishonest with my customers, some of them might find out about it down the road, and that would be bad for my business, so those consequences I want to avoid, so I'm going to say, as a matter of policy, I will be honest with my customers.
- 2.97** But why am I doing that? It's because I want a certain set of consequences. Kant wants to argue, that's not the moral reason for treating your customers honestly. As a moral person, you say, I have an obligation as a human being when I'm dealing with other human beings to treat them honestly, not because it's going to be good for my business down the road. That's a categorical imperative, and that's what we need to strive for.
- 2.98** Now, we have a big problem. Kant has said, I'm a rational being. I can imagine these universal laws that hold without exception. I can distinguish them from my inclinations and my desire for certain consequences in the world. But I still haven't shown why I should follow these categorical imperatives. I've said I can be rational or I can follow my inclinations. I can be consistent or I can be inconsistent, according to circumstances. Why should I be rational and perfectly consistent? Why should I revere these duty

principles? Why not do what seems to work best in the world? Sometimes do this, sometimes do that.

- 2.99** Moral principles are a little more flexible, a little more rules of thumb. Why? We know the traditional answer has said, well, perhaps because there's a God and God commanded and God's got his eye on you. If you don't, stuff was going to happen to you. OK, I can understand that motivation. But Kant has said, that metaphysics of believing in the existence of God, I can't prove that that's right. I've also said that I'm supposed to be, say, a moral agent, that I have choices, that I can choose to go this way or I can choose to go that way. Perhaps as my dignity as a human being is always to choose this way. But in this mechanistic, scientific cause-and-effect world, can I even prove that I have free will, that I'm a moral agent? And Kant has said, no, I can't actually prove that I have free will.
- 2.100** So I have a problem here. "If there is such a law," these categorical imperatives, "it must already be a connection with the concept of a will of a rational being." OK. "But in order to discover this connection, we must, however, reluctantly, take a step into metaphysics." Kant has said, we can't do that. Metaphysics is a matter of saying, well, here's the physical world, and beyond, in some sense, there's a metaphysical realm. Maybe there's a God and immortality and various other sources. My philosophy has said, I cannot go there. That's his Critique of Pure Reason.
- 2.101** So, why should I do so? What Kant wants to argue is, that's an unanswerable question. "If anyone asked," by which he means a smart philosophy person at this point, "why do our actions have to be based on maxims that could be universally valid as laws? How does it come—" jump to the third one— "that a man who believes that it is only through this that he feels his own personal value? We couldn't give him any satisfactory answer." There is no way to answer this question.
- 2.102** He considers some options. One set of options, he says, well, we can do certain kinds of circular reasoning. But as rational philosophers, circular reasoning, begging the question, we are not allowed to do this. So all we can do is say, if we are going to be moral agents and moral beings, the way we commonly understand morality, as absolute set of universal principles, we have to accept, as a matter of faith, of a certain sort, that there is freedom of some sort, that we have capacity, that our rational side of our nature is, in some sense, tapping into something that is beyond our animalistic, here and now, make exceptions, do what I feel like approaches, and that it's possible for human beings to conduct themselves according to these volitionally chosen rational principles.
- 2.103** If there is such a thing as morality, but I can't prove that that is correct, and that is my problem. "All human reason," this is just before the conclusion of this work, "is wholly incompetent to explain this, and it is a waste of trouble and labor to try." If you want to try to find out where these categorical imperatives come from, we can articulate them,

we can understand what the conditions would be, but we can't go any farther than that. If you want to blame anything, as he suggests here, blame reason.

- 2.104** As far as we can get is this. This is the final close of the book. "We truly do not comprehend the unconditional practical necessity of the moral imperative." That is to say, we don't know why, practically, we should follow these moral imperatives. "But we do comprehend its incomprehensibility." This kind of formulation, philosophers just love. We comprehend its incomprehensibility. We know what we don't know, "which is all that we can be fairly demanded of a philosophy that, in its principles, forces its way to the boundaries of human reason."
- 2.105** I'm an Enlightenment thinker. Freedom of conscience, freedom of speech, human autonomy, governing my own principles—that's what it is to be a moral human being, according to the Enlightenment. There should be free speech, freedom of the press, separation of church and state. Nonetheless, I am in a regime under King William, who is enacting a censorship law, and that seems to be then one that's in contradiction. Even though we might say he has good intentions, from a certain perspective of trying to protect the true religion and its morality as a social foundation for the kingdom of Prussia. But nonetheless, what should I do?
- 2.106** Kant decides to comply with the King's censorship edicts and to start moderating his own voice and to agree with the moderation of various other dissenting voices in the society. And from the longer work, the *Metaphysics of Morals*, we just took a little bit from the *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, he offers his reasons. "The subjects of the state can have no right to disobey the supreme authority in a state, even if the commands are unjust." We have a suggestion here that your individual reasoning is to be subordinated to the reasoning or the thinking or the belief system of the whole, and he who is speaking for the state as a whole, and that is, in this case, the king.
- 2.107** Kant then says in his own words here, "The people," that is to say, any of us, "cannot and may not pass any judgment other than that which is willed by the current head of state." All of that philosophical reasoning that's to come out in the place of morality also then needs to be nested within a current political philosophy as well, that seems to place limitations on it.
- 2.108** Now, to wrap things up, the key concepts to take away from our discussion of Kant—obedience, initially, particularly when we are young, until we recognize, as mature beings, our rationality has developed enough, the rational consistency of the various duties that we were taught to obey. Then it becomes a duty that we are consenting to ourselves. The concept of selflessness, that you need to take yourself out of the equation when you are doing morality. It's not because you love yourself and you want to flourish, or even that you love other people and you want them to flourish. Duties don't involve the self in that way. They are impartial or they are impersonal, independent of whatever your personal constitution is.

- 2.109** We are rational beings, and we should be logical and strive for internal consistency in our thinking; and all of our principles, Kant argues, have that nature, but they're not empirically derived. They're not based on our observations of the world, scientific investigations, anthropological studies. We have this idea of a possible kingdom of ends, where we're all rational agents who are deliberating, and we should all come up with this concept with the same conclusions about what morality should be.
- 2.110** So Kant does think morality is ultimately universal, and the formulation of it will be categorical imperative. Those are the terminologies to take away. With that, we will leave, as an optional homework assignment, filling in the chart here, how Kant would answer all of these questions. All right, stop for now.

Lecture 3: Kierkegaard

At a glance — Kierkegaard.

- 3.1** In 1845, Søren Kierkegaard wrote a short story. The story centrally involved a man who visited a prostitute. Things happened, he went away, but it stayed with him, and it started to prey on his mind, this encounter he'd had with the prostitute. He wondered if he had become a father but not realized it, and that obviously she never told him about it. Now, what are the chances? Happens, most of the time not. But he went with a prostitute, and there's something not quite right about that.
- 3.2** There's a possible consequence that he never followed up on and he might never know about. That bothers him. He feels unclean. It's an uncleanness that he can't shake. There's a possible irresponsibility of various sorts in his life. Because of what he did, he has become a certain kind of person, and that bothers him. Now, this is an intensely moral, psychological inquiry, and Kierkegaard writes it as part of a fictional enterprise. But there's a question that scholars of Kierkegaard always ask about whether this was partly autobiographical. Søren Kierkegaard had been a young man; in previous decades, he'd done a certain amount of drinking and partying, things that students do.
- 3.3** The question is whether, in writing this story, some years later, he is, through a fictional device, revisiting some things that are on his mind. Now, partly, the autobiographical element becomes important because of the relationship that Kierkegaard had as a relatively young man with Regine Olsen. For a while, she was his girlfriend. He wasn't sure if he could commit to her, but they got engaged, and it was on again, off again, and eventually, he broke it off. And it seems strange from her perspective and everybody who knew them. Not that he was a little bit strange as an individual, but why would he break off this relationship with this perfectly lovely young woman?
- 3.4** Was it that he felt not able to make a commitment to her, a perfectly decent, honorable young woman in Copenhagen, that he was unworthy of an honorable estate and union with her, given the kind of man he was? Now, these are questions, and I'm emphasizing the autobiographical nature here because Kierkegaard is an intensely personal thinker in his philosophical approach and his philosophical style, in contrast to many philosophers who are very abstracted and writing in impersonal tones and writing essays in scientific treatises. Kierkegaard writes in narrative form, and he often uses fictional voices to explore various psychological, moral alternatives.
- 3.5** When you read, you find certain themes that are dominating Kierkegaard, and they're not themes about rationality and tabula rasa and being a reasonable civil person. Instead, these are intensely passionate, intensely emotional themes, and often negative emotional themes that he comes back to over and over again. A sense of sin, deep sin, is, "Having been taught by a revelation from God what sin is." So you know what sin is. But you're nonetheless "before God in despair not to want to be oneself."

Because you know what it is to be sinful, but you know who you are and what you are. You don't want to be yourself or in despair to want to be oneself.

- 3.6** You nonetheless want to be yourself. I want to do all of these sinful things, but I don't want to be sinful. I'm conflicted and I can't get outside of this. Dread, a feeling of that iron lump in your stomach that just permeates your being. You can't make it go away, even if you can't identify what is making you feel so deeply awful. "Dread is an alien power which takes hold of an individual, and yet one cannot extricate oneself from it. Does not wish to, because one is afraid, but one fears attracts one." You're afraid of something, you want it to go away, but nonetheless, it's got some attractive hold on you. You can't get it out of your system. "Dread renders the individual powerless."
- 3.7** There's this particular emotion, but there's a more general point about emotions controlling our thoughts, our actions, our feelings, my sense of who I am, and I can't rise above that. We talk about being rational, but rationality is weak and powerless in the face of these dominating, intensely personal emotions. Fear. "The whole of existence frightens me. From the smallest fly to the mystery of the incarnation, everything is unintelligible to me, most of all myself. The whole of existence is poisoned in my sight, particularly myself."
- 3.8** What we get from reading Kierkegaard is an individual who is intensely absorbed with who he is and how he is feeling and dominated by a certain set of emotions, often negative emotions, wrestling with them but not able to succeed in controlling them, dominating them, changing them. This is the core, he starts to suggest, of what it is to be a human being.
- 3.9** Now, side note, Kierkegaard is often identified in the history textbooks as the founder of existentialism as a philosophy, a philosophy that became prominent about a century later in the 20th century, for this emotionalist, brooding, intensely introspective starting point to doing not only moral philosophy, but all of philosophy and an emphasis on negative emotions that one must confront ruthlessly and honestly in oneself and go from there wherever that takes you.
- 3.10** Now, by the time we get to the 1800s, the Enlightenment has been an ongoing project, and the modern world has revolutionized seemingly everything. For a certain kind of person, particularly someone who is raised religiously, it seems like a difficult world to confront, particularly if you are intelligent and sensitive. You have to take seriously the possibility that God is dead. Now, a later thinker, Nietzsche, is more famous for using the death of God theme, but it was prominent already in Kierkegaard's generation, writing in the 1840s, and even earlier, in another philosopher, Georg Hegel, probed the issue of the death of God and what it might mean not only for us as individuals, but for us socially.
- 3.11** For thousands of years, we've been religious as individuals, often just obviously, religion and not questioning our religion, and it permeates every aspect of our culture.

Then in a very short period of time, along comes modern science and modern philosophy. We can't be simple-minded, faith people and just follow the traditions. We're supposed to think everything through, and then we start to think everything through. We start to consider some unpleasant possibilities. One of those big possibilities is, maybe there isn't a God.

- 3.12** How do I deal with that honestly, deeply? How does that make me feel? We're supposed to be rational in the modern world. Being rational then not only posed questions for God, the Father, who provides us guidance and is looking after us. It seems like the world becomes colder and emptier and all of these cause-and-effect mechanistic laws that we get pushed around by physical forces, scientific forces, all beyond our control. Is that what rationality leads us?
- 3.13** We're supposed to be happy, or taught, can one be happy in a godless world? If you're purely rational and logical? What about one's feelings? Then, of course, if you find yourself dominated by feelings of dread and fear and sinfulness, does happiness really seem like the purpose of life? Is it even possible? Maybe suffering is the more important part of life and finding meaning in the confrontation with one's personal suffering.
- 3.14** All of this is in the air, and Kierkegaard, as a sensitive, highly intelligent, highly unique thinker, grapples with and plunges into this philosophical world. Now, one of his important works is a work that came out in 1843. He published a number of short works in this same time period called *Either/Or*. *Enten-Eller*. This is the cover, published in Copenhagen. He spent also some time studying in Germany, so he was aware of Kantian philosophy, and post-Kantian philosophy, and then when he returned to Denmark, he mostly was isolated but working feverishly and intensively in a very personal way on his own writings.
- 3.15** And *Either/Or* is written in a narrative form and as a semi-fictional, how semi or not, that's the hard part to figure out when one reads Kierkegaard because he introduces it by means of a character named Victor Eremita, who is the editor of the work. He says, "I am publishing or presenting this work to the world, and I didn't write it. I just was rummaging around in this dwelling, and there was this old cupboard or an old desk, and we banged on it and a secret drawer popped out. In it, there was this manuscript. I read it through, and it seems very interesting. The world might want to know about this, so I'm publishing it, but don't think that I am the author of this."
- 3.16** Kierkegaard is then constructing a character who is an editor who is presenting the writings of some other people. Here we have Kierkegaard distancing himself from the authorship of it. Then as we read into *Either/Or*, as the name suggests, either this or that, there's an alternative. There's two alternatives. The book is divided into two parts, and each part is written by a different person. They are only identified initially as A, first letter of the alphabet, and in part 2, B. We never learn the identity of A. Character B, at

some point, we do learn his name. He identifies himself as Wilhelm or William, and that he's a judge.

- 3.17** We go back to the first part, part A. A is writing a whole bunch of letters, so it's in personal letter form, and he's writing these letters to B, and B is also then writing a series of letters that are sent to A. Partway through, A character includes this other short story in it, and he sends it off to B. That short story is not actually a story, it's a diary written by—it is called the diary of a seducer. The seducer is a young man who talks about his relationship with a young woman named Cordelia and how their relationship went.
- 3.18** And so, we have all of these characters then, the editor, A and B, and then the guy who wrote the diary of a seducer. Then there's one more right at the very end. B includes another letter that was written by a parson, giving certain moral advice toward the end. Now, rhetorically, all of these are first-person, writing letters or writing an editorial introduction to works written by other people, diaries that are included in various forms. All of those rhetorical forms enable one to get inside the head, so to speak, of the person who's writing the diary, writing the letter. It's a way of doing first-person philosophy.
- 3.19** In this rhetorical choice, Kierkegaard is obviously signaling, this is how philosophy should properly be done, not philosophers sitting on their mountaintops or in their cool offices or wherever, writing impersonal abstract treatises on the nature of the universe and abstracted moral principles. Philosophy is an intensely personal discipline, but we're all individuals and we're very different. The way perhaps we can best explore doing philosophy is by constructing all of these different personas and really getting inside their framework, their way of thinking and feeling about the world, and doing the compare and the contrast.
- 3.20** So Either/Or. Now, what are the either-ors? Here we can start doing some abstracting. A and B are representative of two types of human beings. What Kierkegaard is doing initially is suggesting that moral philosophy, as it has come down to his generation, has presented us with an either-or option. One sounds like an old-fashioned way of doing things, another like a more new-fashioned way of doing things. We might contrast the premodern to the modern. One sounds a little bit more physically oriented, one perhaps a little bit more spiritually oriented.
- 3.21** But what we get is A, representing a philosophy that is based on sensuality, on exploring the world of the senses, art, music, beauty, sex, love, seduction, power, all of these worldly things that we as human beings as part of the natural world might want to explore. He calls this the aesthetic life. Now, aesthetics here is coming from, originally from the senses. We explore the world sensorially, and we want to use all of our senses and enjoy all of our senses. This, of course, involves good food and good drink and good sex and going to theater and enjoying good music because we have all these senses and so forth.

- 3.22** What we find in A's letters are his personal explorations of everything that's going on in his life—how he loves the music of Mozart, for example, how he finds interestingly and appealing the stories of Don Juan, the great seducer of women, and the enjoyment, of course, of food and drink and so forth. The idea here is that the either, the first choice that we make, is we can make a life that is committed to enjoying all of the sensual and aesthetic and artistic pleasures that the world has to offer and to put together the most enjoyable package that we possibly can.
- 3.23** That all sounds, of course, nice and fine and attractive in some ways, but there is an introduction of a dark note in here where the very famous—this is why the book sold pretty well— section called diary of a seducer. You see that, you say, oh my, I need to buy this book. What we find is that the seducer is a young man. He seems like a perfectly ordinary young man, a decent guy in many ways, and of course, he wants all of the things that men want. But as he starts to court this woman, Cordelia, he starts to notice that not only does she have certain aesthetic and sensual charms to offer him, that he likes to play power games with her.
- 3.24** He likes to try to seduce her a little bit and try this out and see if she responds, and if she responds positively, then he has a certain amount of power over her. He enjoys having that amount of power to be able to manipulate her emotions as he wants. To play, "Oh, come here. Oh, now go away. I'm attracted to you. I'm a little bit indifferent to you." As a human being, he's enjoying his sense of power over this other human being and being able to watch voyeuristically how her demeanor, her feelings, and her behaviors change in response to his power over her.
- 3.25** He is then ultimately in the pursuit of these worldly powers, not only interested in art and music and sensual pleasures, but also power, which is a very naturalistic inclination that human beings have. The power over not nature, but power over other people, and the pleasures that can come from that can lead in, obviously, some dark places. Now, what we then get is this description of one possibility in life, and that's what A represents.
- 3.26** Lots of people, of course, in the history of human life, in the history of moral philosophy, have variations on that. That's ultimately what life is all about in various respects. Now, B, in his letters, is the or, and he represents what seems from the way Kierkegaard is presenting things as the other alternative that has come down to us in not only human history, but moral history. That is to say, the life of duty and obligation and commitment. It's not to say that you won't get your pleasures in life, but you will get the pleasures within the framework of leading a morally upstanding life, a life of principle, a life of commitment.
- 3.27** For example, instead of seducing women and enjoying your power over women and enjoying the various pleasures that women can offer you, you choose one woman, and you make a commitment to her, and you get married to her with all of the duties and obligations that come as part of that package because you are a decent man. You are a

moral man. You are making a principled commitment. Within that confine, and of course, there are lots of pleasures that one can enjoy, but only within that moral framework.

- 3.28** And that B, as his letters go on, he's trying to suggest to A, but then also reflecting on his own life, and say that the best kind of satisfactions in life, finding the proper meaning of life, is going to come from this ethically principled way of living. I understand the attractions of A's sort of life. I'm a man, too, but those are short-term, and ultimately, those are going to lead to emptiness. What is going to lead to proper fulfillment and commitment is this ethically principled life.
- 3.29** The problem, though, is that, of course, A, has responses to all of this, which is to say, well, that all counts kind of boring. One woman, forever? Duties and obligations? OK, maybe that works for you, but maybe not everybody is the same. Maybe that's not even the best possible life. How do you really know, given your commitments? You haven't really experienced what I have experienced. To let yourself go and follow your inclinations, to take you where art can take you, to take you where seduction and sexual power games can take you. How do we know which is the better life?
- 3.30** What we do know is that these two traditions have come down to us. There's lots of people who have tried more or less to live each of those lives. But here we are now, 1845. I am a human being. I might be Søren Kierkegaard, I might be anyone, and I need to make my own choices. How do I make a choice? Am I going to go with the A route or the B route? Am I going to go the aesthetic route or am I going to go the ethical route?
- 3.31** Now, this is a problem because we can say, there have been lots of people who've lived and they've all made their different choices, but I don't have the benefit of all of their life experience. If I just do what they tell me, then I'm just appealing to authority, but how do I know whom to trust? Maybe they didn't even make the right choices as well. There's no way that I am ever going to get, before I make my own choices and start living my own life, a definitive, right, thorough answer to the question of how I'm supposed to live my life.
- 3.32** I just have to start making my own commitments, my own choices, and see how things go. That's a bit of a problem. Now, this book, 1843, published in the early part of the year, was followed up by a book published later in the year. That's the one that we're going to focus on in this session, that wants to suggest there's a third alternative, that the either-or is a false either-or, and that both of them have their limitations because we might agree with A, that the ethical life seems boring and stale. It's not going to necessarily make me happy and complete.
- 3.33** We might also agree that the aesthetic life seems ultimately shallow, that it doesn't add up to anything permanent or even anything long-term. It's maybe ultimately just going from one set of momentary pleasures to the next set of momentary pleasures, and then you die. What does your life mean? Nothing. Kierkegaard then wants to suggest

that the tradition of moral philosophy, by forcing this either-or upon us, particularly in the modern world, is overlooking an ancient way of looking at morality that was more fundamentally onto something.

- 3.34** What he does in this later work—it's called *Fear and Trembling*, after *Either /Or*, also published in 1843, is to say, again, going back to an emotionalist starting point, fear and trembling, these are emotional, passionate states that we get into. This is something more fundamental. Now, that's abstractly put, and maybe you're not particularly feeling fear or trembling right now, so how can we get to where Kierkegaard wants us to go? The ancient story he wants us to take us back to is this one here, the story of Abraham and Isaac, right back to the very beginning of the Bible or the Hebrew scriptures, the Book of Genesis, where we learn about Abraham.
- 3.35** We read this absolutely riveting, absolutely terrifying story of Abraham in relation to God, Abraham in relation to his wife Sarah, Abraham in relationship to his son Isaac. What Kierkegaard wants to do is use this story as a way of getting us back on track to something fundamental that, already in the modern world, is being set aside and forced into the straitjackets of a certain either-or choice that he thinks is inappropriate.
- 3.36** Now, what's in the image here is the central figure, Abraham, the bearded guy with the knife in his hand. What he is ready to do with that knife is stick it into the body of Isaac, who is his son. So Abraham is about to kill his own son because he has, by his lights, been commanded by God to sacrifice his own son. At the last moment, the angel, also in the picture here, intervenes, and he stops Abraham just after the moment of commitment, from sacrificing Isaac and offers a substitute, and that's in the angel's left hand, a ram to be sacrificed instead of Isaac.
- 3.37** Now, this is absolutely a fundamental story. Abraham, one of the major figures in the Book of Genesis, throughout the centuries, he is the hero of a certain approach to morality, a morality that emphasizes faith as a concept. Now, faith, we've all heard this word. There are, of course, over the centuries, many shadings and meanings and controversies about what faith means. What Kierkegaard wants us to do is to wrestle with this original lesson about what faith means and not lose it; in fact, reincorporate it into our understanding of ethics in the modern world.
- 3.38** Abraham is the hero of faith in the entire Western religious traditions. That includes Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. He is there for a reason to illustrate a certain fundamental moral lesson. So let's go to *Fear and Trembling*. Before we plunge into that text, let's just go to Genesis itself and spend a little bit of time looking at the story as it develops. This is Genesis 17. Abraham was originally called Abram, but then he gets a name change. The story begins with Abram at age 99 years old. He's an old man.
- 3.39** He has had a son named Ishmael, but with a woman who was his slave, Hagar. But he and his legal wife, who is currently called Sarai, have not yet had any children. This has been a thing of sorrow for him and a thing of sorrow even more so for Sarai. But God

shows up and says to Abram, "This is my covenant with you." A covenant is a kind of agreement, a kind of contract, but one that has additional religious sacramental significance. "You will be the Father of many nations," by which he means that, through Abraham's seed or through Abraham's children, the Abrahamic line will multiply and there will be many nations.

- 3.40** He suggests a name change. "No longer will you be called Abram. Your name will be Abraham." Then I repeat, "I will establish my covenant as an everlasting covenant for all time." Name change for his wife. "As for Sarai, your wife, you're no longer to call her Sarai. Her name will be Sarah. I will bless her and will surely give you a son by her." So when God had said, "Through you, many nations will arise," Abraham was initially thinking, "Oh, this will be through Ishmael, my son with my slave woman." But God is saying, no, it will be with Sarai, Sarah now: "I will bless her and will surely give you a son by her. I will bless her so that she will become the mother of nations."
- 3.41** Now, Abraham outwardly falls face-down, but what's going on inside Abraham? "Yeah, right. I'm 99. Sarah is way up there. What are the chances that we two will have a child?" What about Ishmael? Well, you will have a son with Sarah. You're going to call him Isaac. Don't worry about Ishmael. We will look after him, but he will be just fine. Time goes on, Sarah gets pregnant, and Abraham is the father. Sarah is very happy. "God has brought me laughter." The sorrow of her ages has gone away. But now she has a son, and she knows about Ishmael and Abraham's other woman, and she's not happy about that.
- 3.42** She says to Abraham, "Get rid of that slave woman and her son, for that slave woman's son will never share in the inheritance with my son Isaac." Abraham agrees. God says, "Fine. Do what Sarah says." So Abraham sends the two of them away, but well provisioned. All right, so life is good. He has a son; son grows up to be a youth. Then some years later, God comes back. Then God said, "Take your son, your only son, Isaac, whom you love, and go to the region of Moriah. Sacrifice him there as a burnt offering on one of the mountains I will tell you about."
- 3.43** Now, this is Kierkegaard's text, and it's a fundamental text that obviously, through many centuries, people have commented on and lionized and turned Abraham into one of the great heroes of Hebrew scriptures or Old Testament for how he handled this situation. What Kierkegaard wants us to do is, in first personal way, put yourself in that situation. Put yourself in Abraham's sandals, so to speak. What would you do? Am I just hearing a voice? Some voice is telling me to take my son and kill him? Am I a crazy man? Maybe speaking in the same voice as God, but how do I know I didn't eat something off and I'm having a hallucination?
- 3.44** Or maybe I've spoken with God before. How do I know I'm remembering it correctly? Or could this be some impersonating spirit or divinity that's messing with me? You're a human being, and yes, you believe in God, but you're also a creature with reason, and certain questions are going to come about this being that's telling you about you

yourself, can you trust yourself, and about what you are being asked to do. So what do you do in that situation?

- 3.45** "A panegyric upon Abraham." Now, a panegyric is a story, but it's a good-news story, a celebratory story, about whatever. At a funeral, if you were invited to speak on behalf of the person who has died, you might offer a panegyric. "If there were no eternal consciousness in man," that's to say, if man did not have an eternal soul, something that's immortal, that's to say, if we really were only mortal beings, "if at the foundation of all there lay only a wildly seething power which is writhing with obscure passions, produced everything that is great and everything that is insignificant," a description of human life. We're all just wrestling with all these passions and desires and things that we want to accomplish.
- 3.46** "If a bottomless void never satiated lay hidden beneath it all," that is to say, if when we die, it's just nothingness, we just sink into obscurity, "what then would life be but despair?" If we're not going to despair, there has to be something eternal. There has to be something beyond this life, because this life all by itself is just a seething, writhing mess that doesn't add up to anything.
- 3.47** "If," carrying on, "one generation arose after another like the leafage in the forest," interesting metaphor, right? So the young trees, green leaves flowering in many cases. It's all beautiful and lovely for a few short months. Then they all turn yellow and brown and die and fall, and they become mulch, forgotten. Then the next generation comes up, and it's just on and on and on, and we're just one more.
- 3.48** "If the human race passed through the world as a ship goes through the sea, like the wind through the desert, a thoughtless and fruitless activity, if an eternal oblivion were awaiting us—how empty then and comfortless life would be. But therefore it is not thus." It can't be. It can't be. "But as God created man and woman, so he too fashioned the hero and the poet or orator."
- 3.49** So there's a story, and it's not just a meaningless succession of events. It's a story with a plot, and plots have heroes and meaning and significance and themes. We have the potential then to be the hero in our stories. It has to be. Otherwise, total despair. That might be the real either-or that we face. What is it to be a hero? Well, Kierkegaard suggests there's lots of different ways. "Each was great in his own way, and each in proportion to the greatness of that which he loved."
- 3.50** If we are full of self-knowledge and self-reflection, and we have obviously lots of things that we like and dislike, things that we are passionate about, and we have that small critical reflection on the things that really matter to us. These are the things that I love, highest of the high, whatever that small set of things are, and I'm going to commit myself to those. What are those things? Again, there are possibilities. "For he who loved himself became great by himself." Some people, they make themselves a project

and they become awesome human beings, developing their athletic skills or their artistic skills or whatever they are.

- 3.51** "He who loved other men became great by his selfless devotion." So another possibility is, devote yourself not to your own personal project; devote yourself to other people. "But he who loved God became greater than all." Now, the first two, he who loved himself, that might make us think about A, back in Either/Or, who devoted himself to a life of aesthetic pursuits. Maybe he didn't do it stupidly. He pursued the great arts, the great literature, the great everything that's possible. He who loved others might be B, the man who made a commitment to his wife, his career as a judge, bringing goodness and justice to whatever region, his court. He devoted himself to other people.
- 3.52** But God is the other option. You become a hero by striving. Heroes do something above and beyond the ordinary. It's not just that you make a commitment and you make it work and you muddle through. A hero is someone who overcomes great odds and achieves something beyond the ordinary, whatever that is. What is the greatest thing you can possibly strive for or struggle with that will present obstacles to you to overcome?
- 3.53** "But he who strove with God became greater than all." Now, this is a bit of an oddity, because in some way, to strive against God sounds nonsensical, because how can you fight against God, given what you know, given what your powers are, and so forth? We have this what seems to be a paradoxical formulation, Kierkegaard. Let me start tracking here. "There was one who is great by reason of his power." We can think of various powerful beings and individuals across history. Alexander the Great, Julius Caesar. OK, these were formidable men.
- 3.54** "One who was great by reason of his wisdom." Socrates, whoever your other favorite wise thinkers and philosophers are. "One who was great by reason of his hope, one who was great by reason of his love. But Abraham was greater than all." And here's the paradoxical formulation, because he strove to become a hero. "great by reason of his power, whose strength is impotence; great by reason of his wisdom, whose secret is foolishness; great by reason of his hope, whose form is madness; great by reason of the love, which is hatred of oneself."
- 3.55** Now we are entering into paradox territory. I'll say a little side note. Early 19th-century philosophy is an era in which dialectical thinking, Hegel, Karl Marx, dialectical materialism, dialectical solutions to the problem of evil in Hegel and other, that the world is this struggle of contradictory forces that enter into collision with each other, and out of that comes a kind of synthesis that goes forward, whatever that is. That Kierkegaard is offering a kind of religious form of that dialectic.
- 3.56** Your strength is impotence. Your wisdom is foolishness. Your hope is madness. Your love is hatred of oneself. Those sound like opposites. They sound like contradictions. But faith is a kind of contradiction. It's a kind of paradox, and that's what Kierkegaard is

pointing us toward. "By faith, Abraham went out from the land of his fathers." They went on their journey. "By faith, he was a stranger in the land of promise. By faith, Abraham received the promise that in his seed all the races of the world would be blessed."

- 3.57** When God came to Abraham earlier and said, "Yeah, you're going to have a son with Sarah," who in their right mind is going to believe that, of a 99-year-old man and a 90-plus-year-old woman? It doesn't make any sense. It contradicts all of your experience, whatever the state of biological reproductive knowledge is 3,000 years ago. It makes absolutely no sense. But he believed it. "Time passed, the possibility was there, Abraham believed. Time passed, it became unreasonable, Abraham still believed." So he believed, even though it wasn't reasonable. Why is he doing this? What is making it possible?
- 3.58** We follow his biography. He says here, "He did not mournfully count the days while time passed. He did not look at Sarah with a suspicious glance, wondering whether she was getting old." Come on, old woman. Why aren't you pregnant yet? None of that is going on. He didn't say, "Oh, I wish the sun would stand still, that time would go more slowly to give us more chances here." None of that is going on. He believed what God said. "Abraham became old, Sarah became a laughingstock in the land, and yet he was God's elect," et cetera, et cetera. He held fast.
- 3.59** Now, what if he had wavered? Because he's a human being. How can you possibly hold on to that faith for so long? Well, we wouldn't have blamed him, but he wouldn't be a hero, would he? If he had been reasonable and entertained all of those reasonable doubts and let them into his soul, OK, fine, that's human. But we would not be admiring him now. Why do we admire him now? He is the father of faith, and so we have to push further to figure out why. Then came the fullness of time, Sarah got pregnant, Isaac is born.
- 3.60** Joy. Is there any greater joy? Those who have been parents can speak to this. And your child grows up and you're feeling pride and all of the emotions that come along with it. But it was not to remain thus. "Still once more, Abraham was to be tried. And God tempted Abraham and said unto him, 'Take Isaac, thine only son, whom thou lovest, and get thee to the land of Moriah, and offer him there for a burnt offering on the mountain which I will show him.'" So not only is he to kill Isaac, he's supposed to burn the body. This is a place where, typically, sacrifices to gods are, or their god is offered.
- 3.61** Now, again, put yourself in Abraham's situation as a human being. What is natural, what is reasonable, what is almost unthinkable is that certain questions would come into your mind. And Kierkegaard puts one of them. "So the Lord was only making sport of Abraham." God's just playing with me. He made this covenant with me that, through Isaac, but Isaac is still young, he hasn't fathered any children yet himself. He's too young to do so. So he was just messing with my mind, building up my hopes, and now

all of that. Why? Because God has some sick sense of humor, he likes to mess around with people?

- 3.62** You have to think of that as a possibility, if you're not brain-dead, so to speak. "Who then is he that plucks away the old man's staff, who is it that requires that he himself shall break it?" Another aspect of this, not just the covenant part, but I'm a man and I'm becoming an old man; and what the old men look for as they get older, they want their young, strong sons to support them, to look after them in some ways. That's the staff metaphor. You're going to take away that from me.
- 3.63** Not only are you going to take it away from me, actually, you're asking me to be the instrument of taking it away. You're asking me to kill my son. What kind of a god would do that? We might have a sense of justice. "None for the innocent child," emphasizing the word innocent. This is to kill a human being. Isaac. Now, this is still the Old Testament. Perhaps we don't have issues with the death penalty, but we do not do the death penalty wantonly. And nothing that Isaac, as probably a normal boy, has done warrants death. This would be an injustice.
- 3.64** So is he just messing with me? Is he just being cruel to me as an old man, taking away my child, asking me to kill my child? Is he killing an innocent human being? That seems terribly unjust. When he made this promise, was it just a whim? He changed his mind? But what kind of being changes his mind on these important issues? What about Sarah, the mother? What am I going to say to Sarah? Why would you inflict this horrible agony upon Sarah, killing a mother's only child after all of the joy that he brought to her? "For what significance had it when Isaac was to be sacrificed?" Why?
- 3.65** You have to ask those questions, and you have to wrestle with those questions. The problem is, you don't have any answers to those questions. There's no way to get an answer to those questions. Part of the problem is going to be, suppose I say, I have all of these questions, and I'm going to ask God all of these questions that I have, and I say, listen, God, this is something you're asking me to do. Big issues. Explain yourself to me. Are you a liar? Are you a sadist? Are you an unjust killer of innocent children? Help me make sense of this because I can't. There's no rational way to square the circle, to make these pieces fit into a logical puzzle.
- 3.66** Now, it's a test, we know. Now, that's a little bit of after-the-fact knowledge that we can apply. But Abraham doesn't yet know that it's a test. Or he's not sure that it's a test. Maybe it's just a test. But am I supposed to start playing double-guessing mind games with God? Is he sincere or is he just messing around with me? If I start doing that, am I failing the test just by raising those kinds of questions? What is faith going to require of me in this context? "Yet Abraham believed and did not doubt." He believed, and he did not doubt. He might have entertained the questions. He might have wrestled with them. He might have felt all kinds of sick emotions, despairing emotions, but he did not doubt God.

- 3.67** "He believed the preposterous." This is perhaps the most important point in this passage in the context of Enlightenment and post-Enlightenment philosophy. Because what kind of person believes the preposterous? And what is the preposterous? Something that makes no sense, something that is illogical, something that is contradictory. If we are anything in the modern rational world, we know that believing absurdities, believing contradictions, is the great cognitive sin. You use your mind, you figure out what you think is best. If you have contradictions, you know you've made a mistake in your thinking; you rethink.
- 3.68** And on important issues, before you act, you make sure you have all of your questions answered, and the plan that you are embarking on makes sense and seems right to you. And Kierkegaard's point is, Abraham did none of that. He believed in something he thought was preposterous. He has no answers to those questions. Further, he does not question God. He doesn't say to God, "I have all of these questions, that you have an obligation to explain yourself to me." God can do anything. He can say anything. "I will believe it, no matter how preposterous. Whatever he asks me to do, no matter how seemingly evil it is, I will do it." That's faith, believing the preposterous.
- 3.69** Now, Kierkegaard has sharp words for people who confront the story of faith, particularly modern people, and what they will say is, no, no, no, no. Faith is something a lot softer than that because, and then we might say, well, God has a pretty good track record with Abraham, right? God provided this, that, and the other thing. God said that he would look after Ishmael, and that seems to be happening. He said when we were old, that Sarah would get pregnant, and that didn't really make sense to me, but it happened.
- 3.70** So if I rationally consider all of the things that God has done, I don't need to be worried in this case. I can be calm and cool and collected. This is just one more thing that seems a little bit odd to me right now, but I rationally can believe that God is on the right track, and it will all make sense eventually. And Kierkegaard said that is exactly the wrong way to understand the message. It's not about Abraham being a reasonable man, a man of wise experience. Now, we've subjected God to a series of tests, and God has passed the test so we can trust him now. It is not that.
- 3.71** It's that God is asking sometimes of us to do things that seem beyond reason, preposterous, absurd, irrational, that violate everything that we think is rational, everything that we think is decent, everything that we think is moral. But nonetheless, if we are people of faith, we are committed to God above all, beyond our own reason. Abraham believed. He also did not take the cheap way out. What you might have done, he suggests here, is rather than having to kill your own child, kill yourself. It's just, I can't do this. I'll take myself out of the equation because what I'm being asked to do is too difficult. He did not take that easy way out.
- 3.72** "He would have plunged his knife into his own breast." No, he did not do. He believed. "God tempted Abraham. Where are you?" When the time is approaching, Abraham

doesn't hide, doesn't try to get away from his responsibility. He knows what God has commanded. When God speaks, he stands up in a confident voice, loud voice, says "Here I am." Then on the morning, "Abraham rose early in the morning, as though it were to a festival. And so he hastened early in the morning. He had come to the place spoken of, to Mount Moriah."

3.73 Interestingly, he said nothing to Sarah, his wife. What could he say to Sarah? "What's on the agenda for today, dear?" What could you say? Nothing to Eleazar, that's a house servant. Who could understand him? Nobody could understand him, what he's about to do. There's no way to explain this, to make it makes sense. "He cleft the wood. He bound Isaac," tied up his child. "He lit the pyre," the corpse is going to be burned upon. "He drew the knife. My hearer, there was many a man who believed that with his son he lost everything that was nearest to him in the world, that he was deprived of every hope for the future." Think in this moment how any father or parent who has lost a child feels.

3.74 He's got the knife. He's ready. "Not so with Abraham. For him was reserved a harder trial. He knew that it was God the Almighty who was trying him. He knew it was the hardest sacrifice that could be required of him. He knew also that no sacrifice was too hard when God required it, and he drew the knife." Imagine the most difficult thing that God could ask you to do, whatever that is for you, you will do it. What gave strength to his arm? Well, we know. Then we jump to the post-fact. He makes a commitment, angel stops him, offers the ram as a substitute, so kill the ram, burn the ram. Unbind Isaac. Abraham passed the test, the test of faith, and therefore he is a hero.

3.75 "In marching home from Mount Moriah, thou hadst no need of a panegyric which might console thee for thy loss, for thou didst gain all and didst retain Isaac. Venerable Father Abraham!" Now he is the great hero, the one we should respect and admire. "Thou who first didst know that highest passion," that highest passion, it's a passion that we are striving for, a highest passion of all of the other passions, "the holy, pure, and humble expression of the divine madness." It has to be a kind of madness. Madness is the opposite of rationality, logicity, but it's a divine madness. That is faith, the divine madness.

3.76 A little bit later, in *Fear and Trembling*, Kierkegaard has this memorable formulation, and it's one that's definitely worth memorizing. When we are talking about faith, the formula is, it's the teleological suspension of the ethical. To be a faithful person is not to be a moral person. We have to suspend morality. We have to suspend what it is to be ethical. Ethics would never allow you to break promises, kill innocent children, do sadistic things to your spouse with respect to their children. There's absolutely no way, when Abraham gets home, he can still explain to his wife or to anybody what he did and make it sound like a moral thing to do. It violates all moral convention.

- 3.77** But God is above morality, and morality then requires our willingness to suspend morality, and particularly what rationally we might come to think is moral. This is not the aesthetic life, the life of pleasure, art, music, love and sex, and so forth. This is a grim, dark life of meaning because God asks us to do, sometimes, perhaps frequently, all sorts of things that do not fill our lives with sensual and aesthetic wonder and pleasure.
- 3.78** It's not the ethical life, if we think what Abraham did is right. Ethics is about taking responsibility for knowing what you are doing and being justified in your own thinking that it's the right thing to do, and that you can explain it to other people, why it's the right thing to do. It meets standards of consistency. It doesn't involve breaking covenants and consistency with standards of justice, which do not involve killing innocent children. Any ethical principle that we want to lay out, we have to suspend those and go beyond. It's not either-or, it is something higher. But that requires fear and trembling at the heart of it, because to make that kind of commitment, it cannot be made rationally, coolly, and so forth.
- 3.79** There's the phrase once more. Stamp of Kierkegaard, honored in his home country of Denmark. To wrap up, a suggestion of some core takeaway concepts. Dread. Put yourself in Abraham's situation. Dreadful. Fear. Not knowing I'm making the right choice, making it anyway. But it is a choice. It's a choice that I have to make. It's not some impersonal duty, like Kantians might argue us for. To me, it makes no sense. It's absurd what I am being asked to do, but being willing to take the leap. We use this language, a leap of faith. Then the teleological suspension of the ethical.
- 3.80** Now, so far in this course, already in one day, marching through the modern world, we have a number of fundamentally competing candidates. Hierarchy was a dominant value to organize everything around in the pre-modern world. But is it, if not hierarchy, is it equality? We should strive to make everyone equal across all social dimensions. Is it that we abandon hierarchy, but we leave individuals free to make their own choices and go their own ways, recognizing that's also going to include lots of inequalities? So hierarchy, equality, liberty.
- 3.81** Is it duty, recognizing universal, rationally consistent principles and following them without regard to consequences? Is it none of those, that what we're trying to do is be too rational and consistent and this-worldly in our approach to ethics? What we need to do is to go back to the beginning, back to Genesis, and reinvigorate that old and fundamental notion of faith as fundamental and build everything around faith.

Lecture 4: Schopenhauer & Comte

At a glance — Schopenhauer and Comte.

- 4.1 All right, let's begin in 1848 in Germany. More specifically, in Frankfurt, Germany, where Arthur Schopenhauer, our first moral philosopher of today, was living. And murder on the very street on which Schopenhauer was living. All over Europe, unrest, political unrest, social unrest, some of it turning to violence. In Frankfurt, a general and a prince, a representative of the old order or the established order, were killed. This, to Arthur Schopenhauer, living his philosopher's life on a quiet street in Frankfurt, brought the unrest all over Europe home to him, so to speak, and it deeply distressed him.
- 4.2 Now, more broadly, all over Europe in 1848, there's rough stuff going on. It seems anarchy is on the verge of breaking out, but an instilled anarchy and factions political and social of many sorts contesting. If we go to France, there are riots on the streets in Paris, primarily republicans trying to force the monarchy to go away so that its form of republicanism, if we go to the south, it's more liberal democrats who are resisting the old order and forcing out the then-Bourbon family king from its position of power. If you go further to the east, it's less republican, less liberal, less democrat, but more nationalistic in its orientation, an uprising against the imperium in power at that point.
- 4.3 Then, of course, famously in 1848, two Germans, Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels, published the Communist Manifesto. The situation then in the middle part of the 1800s, clearly, we are into the modern world. We do not have a unified political structure, a unified social structure, a unified religious framework. We have all of these contesting factions, all of which, to put it bluntly, hate each other and are acting with respect to each other, nastily, violently, literally taking it to the streets and killing each other.
- 4.4 Schopenhauer, now living in Frankfurt, born in Gdańsk, Poland, on the Baltic Sea—it was then a German state at that time—to a prosperous merchant family, spent some time in Berlin, more or less unsuccessfully as a professor of philosophy. At that point, Georg Hegel was the dominant philosophy in Germany. Schopenhauer hated Hegel, and philosophically was the opposite, and the feelings were reciprocated. So he essentially pursued an independent career as a philosopher and is now, two centuries later, recognized as one of the giant names in the history of philosophy.
- 4.5 He also has a rather negative reputation for the sometimes strangeness of his views to modern ears. I want to, to some extent, ask you to cut him some slack because many extraordinarily intelligent philosophers and others have seen philosopher Schopenhauer as one of the great, greatest of the great. One piece of evidence for that is Albert Einstein, and Schopenhauer was his favorite philosopher. Apparently, in his office in Berlin, [Einstein] had three portraits carefully selected on display, two of them giants in the world of physics, and one philosopher, and that philosopher was

Schopenhauer. He always argued reading Schopenhauer was decisive and critical for his own revolutionary thinking.

- 4.6 Let's plunge into Schopenhauer. So far in this course, we've, in the modern world, argued for four possible core values or most important values or most significant values around which we are going to organize everything. We should start by seeing ourselves as free agents, that I'm going to take ownership of that and live a free life as an individual. Or more socially, we should strive for a more equalitarian or egalitarian, where everybody is part of a collective group, perhaps at a tribal level of organization and everyone is more or less equal in their social status as best.
- 4.7 A notion of strict impersonal duties that you recognize as universally valid, that you commit to, that's what it to be a moral person. Or the argument that what we need is a resuscitation and a reinvigoration of a deep notion of faith to something that does not seem reasonable to you, but that your rationality and your understanding is not the important thing. There's something beyond you that requires certain things of you, and a commitment to that is the thing that gives life significance and meaning.
- 4.8 Then all of these are argued and have their advocates and, of course, there are representatives of the older order saying that we don't need to follow any of these hierarchy and the established ways of doing things. Those are what we need to resuscitate. But another option might be to say that, in fact, nothing is valuable. All of these are put forward, the earlier ones, as positive, as something to strive for, perhaps even as ideals. But what if we are just deluded in our belief or our hope that there is such a thing as positive value, positive goodness, something that's invaluable, meaningful, that we should commit to? What if, instead, we embrace a kind of extreme pessimism and negativity with respect to the possibility of value?
- 4.9 Schopenhauer is a representative in the modern world of this position. Here, from his most famous work, the one he published when he was still relatively young, earlier in his career. In 1818, *The World as Will and Representation*, and here's a significant quote. "We have not to be pleased, but rather sorry about the existence of the world, that its non-existence would be preferable to existence." It would be better if nothing existed. Why? Well, what kind of world do we live in? Well, it's a "world of constantly needy creatures who continue for a time merely by devouring one another, pass their existence in anxiety and want, and often endure terrible affliction, until they fall at last into the arms of death."
- 4.10 What about us, humans, confronting this kind of world? "Nothing else can be stated as the aim of our existence except the knowledge that it would be better for us not to exist." We can regard our life as a uselessly disturbing episode in the blissful repose of nothingness. Nihilism, or nihilism, from the Latin word for nothing. Then nothing-ism. What's of value, what's good, what's significant? Nothing of value. Then you add that -ism, which is always an upgrade to whatever thing it's attached to, saying this is significant. On principle, I recognize this as fundamental. So, a principled nothingism.

- 4.11 Now, Schopenhauer is a brilliant philosopher, well-read, well-educated, and author of also many penetrating critical works. One of the philosophers he comes back to regularly in his commentaries is Immanuel Kant. He's going to be harshly critical of Kant's ethics, but at the same time, he thinks that Kant, in his more fundamental philosophy, is absolutely right, that Kant is the philosopher who finally, after thousands of years of philosophizing, got it right. Now, he's referencing here *The Transcendental Aesthetic*, which is an early part of Kant's major work, *The Critique of Pure Reason*. We made a mention of it in our lecture on Kant.
- 4.12 What he wants to argue is that Kant is exactly right to say that the human mind is totally incompetent to know reality as it really is. What we are aware of is only a subjective, that our subject unconsciously structures an apparent, ultimately illusory reality. The illusory word is a word Schopenhauer is going to use, and that is then a barrier between us and knowing the way reality is out there, skeptical conclusion about the possibility of knowledge. We have to abandon the idea that we can do metaphysics or any sort of intellectual discipline that's going to lead us to knowledge of the way reality really is. We are trapped in a subjective reality.
- 4.13 He says here, "Its proofs are so convincing that I count its theorems among the incontrovertible truths." This is the first time in thousands of years where we have a genuine discovery with respect to metaphysics, and it's a negative conclusion. He's going to take that as granted, that Kant is right on that, but he's then going to disagree about what the implications of that are. What Kant then had wanted to argue is that we are rational beings, and we can do this philosophy and come to realize the limitations of our reason, but we should be content with working within the framework, this phenomenal reality that our reason and the forms of sensibility construct for us.
- 4.14 Schopenhauer is going to have none of that. If we are philosophers, genuine philosophers, we should be concerned with reality, not our subjective constructions with respect to what reality is. And any philosopher who says, I'm perfectly fine with my mind coming up with nice, tidy categorical structures inside my head and inside your heads and so forth, and just totally to abandon the way the world really is, that is, to put it bluntly, cowardice. A genuine philosopher wants to connect with reality. What Schopenhauer is going to argue is that what Kant has shown is not so much that reality is cut off, but rather that reality is cut off from reason. Reason cannot get us to reality.
- 4.15 But if somehow we can get past reason, go around reason, under reason, get behind reason, whatever metaphor we like here, we need to try to find some way of reconnecting with reality. That reason we need to see as a limiting function on us. The kind of person who wants things to be nice and neat and orderly, instead of opening themselves to the possibility that reality is messy and ugly and perhaps even brutal. So cowardliness leads us to retreat inside our own minds. What we need to do is get past that and confront reality as it really is.

- 4.16 The way he puts it here is, "Reason, as indeed the intellectual faculty as a whole, is secondary." It's not that important. It's secondary. It's further down the list. Instead, what we should look for is when we, particularly when we introspect, is there's something more fundamental, and that is will. It's Will with a capital W, that energy, commitment, or the thing that makes it possible for you to do whatever it is that you do. What we call our intellectual capacities are superficial, secondary, something along those order. "It is the Will in man which is his very self." You're primarily a willing being, not a rational being or a reasoning being.
- 4.17 Now, there's an interesting, just a little sidebar, rather. I want to just point this out for any further reading—what Schopenhauer is partly famous for is for his analysis of music. It's common to read Schopenhauer in Aesthetic Theory because he has an interpretation with respect to music that says that music is a metaphysical exercise that we engage in. That in some sense, if we notice what goes on in the experience of music, that we get an intimation of what reality can and should be like.
- 4.18 What happens when we are in music is that the music seems to operate on us. We've all had this experience. We might try to attach images to what's going on in the music, but everybody's images are different. We might try to say that the music is telling a story and we're trying to construct a more rational, logical narrative of what's going on. But all of that is derivative to what's really going on. It speaks to our will. It speaks to our passions. It speaks to our emotions. We use all of this vaguer language when we're doing that. It takes us to another place. It seems like our rationality, and oftentimes we'll even close our eyes just to block out the sensory world and so forth.
- 4.19 Schopenhauer's interpretation is that music might be one vehicle through which we can escape the confines of this apparent physical world, escape the confines of reason, and get a sense for what's really going on out there in reality. "Music," the way he puts it down at the bottom here, "is an unconscious exercise in metaphysics, in which the mind does not know it is philosophizing." That's where our conscious rational mind gets pushed to the background or even shut off, and where our will and our passions and the other unconscious elements of us are able to go forth.
- 4.20 Now, what does this imply for morality, with this kind of a philosophical framing? I want to turn to a work that Schopenhauer published first in 1841. The second edition came out shortly before he died in 1860, and in it, he is consciously focusing on the basis of morality, not so much the content of morality. He, by and large, takes it for granted that some sort of religious content to ethics has been on the right track, even if he doesn't believe in the metaphysics of Christianity. He's going to be harshly critical of Kantian approaches that we were somehow supposed to rationally derive these universal, consistent principles and so on. Kant and his followers are entirely on the wrong track.
- 4.21 So what is the real basis for morality? And let's go, as we like to do, to the text for a little while. Now, this is an essay that Schopenhauer submitted for a contest in

Denmark. Denmark, we might recall, is where Kierkegaard had been living. It's an essay that is now recognized as a classic by philosophers and by moral philosophers, but it was rejected by the judging board of the Danish Royal Society of Sciences as inappropriate, unprofessional, not up to intellectual standard. And so he was not awarded the prize. The kicker is that the Danish Royal Society only received one submission for the contest. It was Schopenhauer's, and their judgment was that this is so bad that we're just not going to award the prize to anybody so that we don't have to award it to this obviously dysfunctional purpose.

- 4.22 A few things here, though, from the beginning. When we think about morality, most people, the way he puts it, still, even in the modern world, adopt a theological or religious approach to ethics. "For the people," you have to have a little bit of condescension when you start talking about the people from most philosophers' perspective, "and is founded on theology as the express will of God." And then Schopenhauer then is pointing out, by the time we get into modern world, 19th century, "on the other hand, we see philosophers, with few exceptions, taking special pains to entirely exclude this kind of foundation."
- 4.23 So either they don't find the proofs convincing or they find that the content of traditional religious ethics, rooted in primitive people who didn't know much about science or whatever, is just not up to snuff by the time we get into the modern world. So very few philosophers are religious in their orientation, either in terms of the content or in terms of the methodology. Kant is important here. It was none other than Kant who destroyed the foundations of speculative theology. The argument here, he's saying, is that Kant's metaphysics and his epistemology make it impossible for us to think that we can get to God.
- 4.24 There's supposed to be a God out there in the real world or in some sort of a super-sensuous world. But we are now post-Kantian, trapped in a kind of subjective reality. If we find those proofs convincing, as Schopenhauer does, it means that it's impossible for us to know what is the nature of that reality out there. That means it's impossible for us to know that there's a God or anything out there. Therefore, whatever the content of your moral philosophy is going to be, you can't claim to base it properly on any sort of God.
- 4.25 He wants to then argue that Kant had largely conquered the intellectual world by the time of his death in 1804. Much of philosophy that is being done in Germany, which is now the rising superstar intellectual nation, especially for philosophy, but also for many of the sciences, it is Kantian and various forms of neo-Kantian philosophies that are dominant. But what Schopenhauer wants to do is, despite that metaphysics and those epistemological limitations, unless we are going to try to get to an ultimate reality, a metaphysical reality, just not through reason.
- 4.26 What's interesting and significant about Schopenhauer is that while many of the philosophers who still might have a kind of soft spot for traditional religious ethics,

perhaps for Judaism or Christianity in particular, what Schopenhauer and part of his breadth of reading, he wants to argue is that it is the Eastern philosophies, and more specifically, the Eastern religions, Hinduism and Buddhism, that he mentions the most, that have done a better job of getting some intimations about the right way to do philosophy and the right way to do religious philosophy. So some credit to the Western religious traditions, but they are on a developmental path, and already the Buddhists and the Hindus have gone further.

- 4.27 So we find here his recommendation of "the most ancient and widespread faiths, Brahmanism," which is another name for Hinduism, "and Buddhism, which, as far as time and space go, are the most important religious systems of mankind." That's worth making a note of. That said, with all kudos and respect for Kant's underlying metaphysical and epistemological philosophy, Schopenhauer wants to argue, when it comes to ethics, "my own position, which is in its essential points, diametrically opposed to Kant's."
- 4.28 Kant wants to say we are rational. Schopenhauer is going to argue we are fundamentally non-rational and perhaps should even be irrational. Kant has a nice, tidy, organized, logically consistent phenomenal world. He wants to have nice, tidy, consistent moral principles. Schopenhauer is going to argue, if we confront reality as it is, it is messy, it is ugly, it is ultimately perhaps even contradictory and inconsistent with itself. That is the direction that we want to go.
- 4.29 There's also this issue that Kant wants us to obey and be dutiful to some commands or principles that are more or less dictated to us, channeling in a more secular way, traditional religious ethic. Whereas for Schopenhauer, the idea that we're just going to submit ourselves to commands from some unknowable being or some unknowable dimension, that seems to him slavish. If you're going to be more authentic in some valorizable way, it has to be that you are making commitments based on something that's coming from your will, rather than turning your will off and submitting to the will of something higher or allegedly higher or something, something beyond.
- 4.30 So 2,000 years of doing philosophy. We're now in the 1800s, and everybody disagrees with each other. There's a pretty strong Kantian school dominating in Germany. But by and large, maybe what we should do is just throw our hands up and say that the philosophical, rational, logical approach, "ought we not perhaps to think that after all there is no natural morality, independent of human institution?" There is out there nothing that's moral or supernatural institutions. Maybe we're all just making it up, but because we have a whole bunch of people and we're all different, we just make up different kinds of systems, and then we want to claim and pretend that we are being rational and that ours is the universal truth.
- 4.31 "Shall we not conclude that all moral systems are nothing but artificial products, means invented for the better restraint of this selfish and wicked race of men." We all recognize that we are selfish in this pejorative sense or willing to screw over each other

and do nasty things with respect to each other. And truth be told, if we all introspect and are honest with ourselves, we are willing to do that sort of thing as well. What some of us do, of course, is just embrace that. That's the way life is. Go for it and try to achieve your values at the expense of other people.

- 4.32 But some people, philosophers, want to say, well, let's try to have some social living, and I'm just going to make up some artificial rules and try to get you to believe in these artificial rules. But my agenda really is to try to get you to be less selfish and wicked with respect to me. So I feel a little bit safer. And of course, you're trying to do the same thing if you are a philosopher. But we're just making these things up in order to try to avoid the true reality of the world.
- 4.33 "When we contemplate the moral depravity of the world, it is sufficiently clear that the stimulus for good cannot be very powerful." We've had all these religions inventing moral systems and how much good have they done in restraining people? Then we've got a lot of philosophers who say, well, we can dispense with God and try to make up more secular naturalistic rules, and if we can try to get people to agree to those, and we have police to enforce them, then we can— but how successful has all of this been? Instead, the fundamental truth is that we're all pretty wicked, and it's our wickedness that is the most powerful to us.
- 4.34 Now, Schopenhauer's name for this wickedness, this selfishness that is at the source of all of our problems, is egoism. The word ego comes from the Greek, the Greek word for I, and so it's a principled I -ism. Someone who is an egoist might sound in a good-news version like someone like John Locke, for example. I am a free agent. I am free, and I want to develop my own mind and be careful and coming to understand the world, and I'm going to take self-responsibility and be productive and respect people's property rights and so forth.
- 4.35 Then the cynical version is going to be that that's all really just a cover for something really darker among the egoists. How many egoists are actually going to be civilized, enlightened philosophers like John Locke? If you promulgate the doctrine of egoism, then the common lot of people and the average standard of civility and commitment to goodness and mutual peacefulness and so forth is pretty low. That doctrine really is just going to unleash a certain kind of dog-eat-dog world, and that is why we're in the terrible circumstances that we are, morally speaking.
- 4.36 Ultimately, according to Schopenhauer, egoism comes down to "all things for me, nothing for others." This is its maxim. "Egoism is so odious that no one wishes to see it, however much it is known to be there. Without these checks, considering the countless number of egoistic individuals," translating to Latin, "the war of all against all would be the order of the day." What we then have is, everybody is basically egoistic in their will and they want to achieve their own goals. They're quite willing to do so at the expense of others if they can get away with it. In social circumstances, of course, sometimes we pretend to be polite, or if we're in the presence of more powerful institutions like the

police, we will check ourselves so that we don't run into problems with the police and so forth.

4.37 But to the extent that egoism is dominating the world, it's not possible for us to be moral individuals or to have any sort of a peaceful society. "Egoism, then, is the first and principal, though not the only, power that the moral motive has to contend against." It's egoism versus morality. If we are concerned in this book with the basis of morality, what we're going to have to do is to say, how can we find some sort of principle that can contend with egoism, that might even be able to defeat egoism, so to have the possibility of morale?

4.38 Now, of course, it might be that this is completely impossible. This is just a pipe dream. I'm smoking something, and I would say, wouldn't it be nice if we could all get along with each other? But let's try and see what we can do. "We have to find a motive capable of making a man take up a line of conduct directly opposed to all those propensities which lie deeply ingrained in his nature." Our question then is going to be, how can we, given that everybody is egoistic and egoism acted on consistently means the war of all against all, find the possibility inside ourselves of something that will motivate us to stifle our egoism, and perhaps even genuinely consider the well-being of other people? That's what we are looking for.

4.39 "For this to be possible, I must in some way or rather be identified with him." That is to say that, in some sense, I know what it is for me to know myself and to know what I want and to care about what I want, that I have to have something that's going to enable me to know you, know what you want, and actually to care about what you want. If I have that, then I'm more likely to take that into account and maybe even act positively with respect to that, even though that's going to require me to act negatively with respect to myself, to be selfless in the literature, to put myself in a lesser position in order to elevate you or the other to a more important primary position in this circumstance here.

4.40 "That is the difference between myself and him, which is the precise reason for being of my egoism, must be removed." And Schopenhauer at this point wants to throw up his philosopher's hands and says, I have no clue how this is even possible. It just seems mysterious. "No doubt this operation is astonishing." Why on earth would I care about you? Why on earth would you care about me? "It is, in fact, the great mystery of Ethics," why anybody cares about anybody else. It seems totally overwhelming to Schopenhauer that we would always and only care about ourselves.

4.41 Now, it does seem that some religions have had some intimation of this idea that it's possible for me to care, maybe even to love someone else. They've tried in various ways to elevate these other-regarding elements and motivations in our self. He says Christianity certainly tries to do this. Perhaps the Hebrew scriptures or Old Testament are pretty rough and brutal in places. We saw the story of Abraham, for example, in the lecture on Kierkegaard. But there's a development. By the time we get into the New

Testament or Christianity, things are softened. Forgiveness, gentleness, et cetera, et cetera, starts to be valorized.

- 4.42 But then again, Schopenhauer wants to argue that it is the Eastern religions that have gone further down this road. "In Asia, a thousand years before, the boundless love of one's neighbor had been prescribed and taught," as mentioned in various Hindu and Buddhist texts. How are we going to do this? If we have some knowledge of what the Eastern religions are about, how do they go about it, and can we perhaps adapt that or update it for the modern West?
- 4.43 "This, however, presupposes that, to a certain extent, I have become identified with the other, and consequently, that the barrier between the ego and the non-ego is, for a moment, broken down." If that happens, then I can understand another person's needs, perhaps another person's pain, another person's distress, and feel in some sense motivated to do something for it. Now, again, this process, however it happens, is mysterious. There's no way that we're going to be able to give a reasonable or a rational account of it, for it is one of the reason, sorry, rather, "it is one which reason can give no direct count of, and its causes lie outside of the field of experience."
- 4.44 So whatever happens to break down my ego and makes me open up to you, it has to be happening from some mysterious source that I cannot know and I'm not going to be able to give an account of it. Just in passing, I will mention that Schopenhauer also thought well of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, whom we spoke about in the first lecture in this course. As with Kant, he is much preferring the Rousseauian modern tradition to the Lockean modern tradition, but we will pass over that for now.
- 4.45 This is where we incorporate now the insights of the Eastern religions, where all of that language about illusion and recognizing that the world, as we commonly take it, is an illusion. It's unreal. It is a veil of Maya, to use that word, a veil of illusion. Or the idea that myself, my ego, that I, as a being that exists, has its own identity, perhaps its own agency, that that too is an illusion.
- 4.46 If we can only find some way to get past the illusion that I exist, that I have a self that is something real and even something significant, and also get past my apparent illusory appearance that are all of these other individual things out there in this world that are what they are and act certain ways to achieve certain goals and so forth, if I can somehow get myself to feel that all of that is an illusion and those then allow me to transcend myself and this world, there will be some identification with the other that is possible.
- 4.47 "The relation subsisting between the ego and the non-ego is mistaken." It's a mistake to think that I and you are separate and different. It's an illusion. "It's due to an illusion. On the contrary, the real substratum of our whole phenomenal nature," that's to say, there's a strata, think of geological meshes of the sub, sub, sub all the way down. The real fundamental substrata is not all of the apparent separate things, this phenomenal

level of world. "Our innermost essence in itself, that which wills and perceives, is not accessible to us."

- 4.48 To our conscious rational minds, we don't see it in this particular phenomenal world, but with the right kind of philosophical insight, perhaps Eastern religious insight and experience, we can break out of all of that and have some intimation of the real substratum where everything is one. We will reach the conclusion that "all plurality," that is to say, the idea that there are plural, many, "all plurality is only apparent." It's only appearance that, "in the endless series of individuals, passing simultaneously and successively into and out of life, generation after generation, age after age, there is but one and the same entity really existing, which is present and identical in all alike."
- 4.49 We are one. If I can wrap my will around that or let that into my will in some sense, my will as an individual will dissolve. Your will as an individual will dissolve. My attachment to all of the particular things in this phenomenal illusory world will dissolve, and I will experience this oneness. Once again, recommending that we read Eastern philosophy, read Eastern, the Vedas, the Upanishads. "When we obliterate the distinction between the ego and the non-ego, we are not the sport of an illusion. Rather are we so, when we maintain the reality of individuality." When we think that there are individuals, that's all just illusory talk and illusory experience, and so forth.
- 4.50 Now, how convincing is this Schopenhauer's question? He recognizes, look, I'm talking to 19th-century Europeans, primarily, educated, and all of this just sounds weird to them. But it's either that or we accept that we are in a wicked, egoistic war of all-eat-all world, that we subject ourselves to thinking that our lives matter and therefore suffer the pain of the fear of death and all of that stuff. In fact, "if we probe the matter to the bottom," as I, Schopenhauer the philosopher, now at the bottom, it's still an enigma, and not only that, "a dark enigma, a piece of mysticism put into practice."
- 4.51 But this compassion, this ability to take seriously other people's significance, pain, and so forth, to try to forge a union with them, I want to believe in it, but it's still the great mystery. The only choice we have then is between egoism, as we've defined it, and altruism. Here we have another -ism, from the Latin word alter, the other. It's either me-ism or I-ism or other-ism. The doctrine of altruism, often used in soft form in popular discourse, but when philosophers use the word, it is a principled recognition and commitment to the value of others first.
- 4.52 What Schopenhauer wants to say is, I can perfectly understand why we're all egoists. I know that from my own self, and I can observe your behavior as well. But I want to believe that altruism is a possibility. That could be the only possible morality, something that's going to bring us together. It requires this dissolution of the illusion of individuality and attachment to individual things in the world. The best thing that we can do is see it as a mystery, but nonetheless, try to explore it.

- 4.53 All right, that is a taste of Schopenhauer. He certainly expands the range of possibilities in the ethical space that gets discussed and debated in the modern world. Here are a short list of key themes. That egoism is bad, that's an axiomatic moral principle. Compassion, for others, is the good. Selflessness, and again, philosophers use these terms literally, to see the self as less. You are less significant, less real, less important. That is, Eastern religions that have gone the farthest down the road of recognizing this possibility. But ultimately, it's either that, which still, of course, is a mystery, or we embrace a kind of nihilism.
- 4.54 I want to go back to the year 1848 and move westward from Germany into France, and then more specifically to Paris, to Auguste Comte, who was a giant in intellectual history. Comte also in 1848 of a more conservative, some people might say, slightly reactionary political disposition, and he is disgusted not only by the riots in Paris but also the widespread unrest and apparent oncoming anarchy all over Europe. The themes that he's going to emphasize are order. Society needs order, fundamentally.
- 4.55 But the reason why we're having all of this chaos is immorality, that somehow in the modern world, especially, we've unleashed all of these immoral forces. People are all over the map on their religion, all over the map on their political views, their moral views. They think as individuals that they can do whatever they want. That moral philosophy has become widespread, but clearly, the chaos has spread. We need to have a moral regeneration.
- 4.56 1848, a speech widely attended. "Until such time as the reconstruction of principles and morals furnishes a solid base for the re-forging of institutions, any attempt to organize a definitive regime can only arrive at retrograde tendencies resting on backward or worn-out doctrines." So, one of the things that Comte is pointing out as a philosopher is to say it's natural for most people to plunge into social activism and into political activism in order to solve what they perceive to be the problems of society. Comte, as a philosopher, is arguing, more fundamental to that are basic philosophical principles, specifically moral principles.
- 4.57 Politics, so to speak, is downstream from morality, that we have to get the morality right. In the modern world, too many degenerate and retrograde versions of morality have sprung up into existence. We need to get back to the right kind of morality. He, as part of his stature in the intellectual world, is the man who coined the words positivism. We'll say a little bit more about positivism. But it's a doctrine that wants to say we shouldn't be doing abstract, metaphysical speculations, that we should be scientific and rigorous and logical, and develop our systems in a systematic way.
- 4.58 In fact, one of the variants of positivism that became popular and significant in the 20th century was called logical positivism. A school, he is also the founder of the word and the coiner of the word sociology. One measure of Comte's influence is that many or most colleges and universities around the world now have sociology departments. Comte is the one who coined that word. Rather than focusing on individuals, instead,

what we should do is focus on social groupings and social units and try to develop social scientific laws to account for how societies develop and interact with each other. That's a general description of the concept of sociology.

- 4.59 He's also the coiner of the word altruism, which is now widely used in our language. He coined it about the same time that Schopenhauer was doing his writing and, in the later edition of Schopenhauer's *On the Basis of Morality*, he uses the word altruism. That's a sign of Comtean influence. Again, as a philosopher, he's saying, it's the other. If we're asking in morality, what is significant, fundamental? It's not you. It's not yourself. It's not your happiness, your goals, dreams, et cetera. It is other people, and one is a servant of other people. That's what it is to be moral.
- 4.60 So, Comte also systematically attacking the individualism and the egoism that he sees everywhere in the modern world. All these individuals concerned with their rights to life, liberty, pursuit of happiness, property rights, becoming rich and happy, right, and so forth. That's a moral degeneracy. You are, again, not an individual. It's going to be a linking theme here between Schopenhauer and Comte. "The only real life is the collective life of the race. Individual life has no existence except as an abstraction." You are part of a collective.
- 4.61 Now, what the correct collective is, that we need to delineate, but the negative point is strongly stated here. Individuals do not exist, except in the sense that we can abstract them from their social context. It is the social existence as a collective entity, unity, being in some sort, that is the real existence. That's the proper unit of philosophical analysis. Now, he's a positivist, and often positivism is associated most with a rigorously scientific, often empirically scientific approach, to reality. Often that comes out in the form of at least an agnosticism, and in most cases, an atheism with respect to traditional religion.
- 4.62 One of the things that is striking about Comte is that he wants to argue that religion and its development over the course of the centuries is but a stage as we get more into the modern world. Rather than rejecting the developmental stages that religion has achieved over the centuries, what we need to do simply is become more scientific, become more rigorous, become more empirical, and so forth, but incorporate the accomplishments that were often dressed up in religious language in a more secular, naturalistic, modernistic world.
- 4.63 One of the striking things about Comte is how much he uses the rhetoric of religion in describing his scientific program. One place where we find this is in the work that we're going to do a little bit of excerpting from, where he has this longish book, it's fairly substantial, a dialogue between a priest, so to speak, and a woman, where they are discussing Comte's new religion of humanity, as he calls it. The book that we're going to look at is called *The Catechism of Positive Religion*.

- 4.64 That's meant to be a somewhat arresting title because, if you know something about positivism, you will say not religious at all. But on the other hand, we're going to say that positivism is going to be a religion, and that means we're going to be reinterpreting in some way what religion means, even though we're going to be incorporating some things from it. Also, a catechism is meant to be an instruction manual, a kind of guide to how one lives one's religious life.
- 4.65 He's going to say, yes, I am a positivist. I don't believe in God. I believe in the religion of humanity. Humanity as a collective being is the new reality that we are going to celebrate, worship, and advance. But here I'm going to provide a catechism or a guide to how to do so. Now, let me then go here. This is a longish work, as I mentioned, where it's cast in dialogue form between a man and a woman. The man is a representative of this new religion of humanity, this positivist religion of humanity that Comte is advancing, and he calls the man a priest.
- 4.66 So even though the priest does not believe in any supernatural beings or any sort of a God, he nonetheless is serving the function inside this new humanistic religion that priests traditionally serve. They are leaders of their flock, so to speak, providing intellectual guidance, moral guidance, and in some cases, something a little bit more stern and physical to keep people on the right and narrow. Now, in Comte's Religion of Humanity, there's an important place for women. It's a different place for women than for men, but it's an important place. In choosing this dialogue between these two people, they are more or less equal, and that also is symbolic as we go through. It's a woman and a man.
- 4.67 Published 1852, right at the heart of the 19th century and Europe slowly coming out of the terrible years from Comte's perspective of 1848, 1849, and so forth. All right, what are we trying to do? Well, "we come forward then, to deliver the West from an anarchical democracy and from a retrograde aristocracy." So, Comte's analysis of the social and political situation is to say, well, in the modern world, obviously, individualism, and most prominently, Locke's forms of individualism, have come along and say, we need to be individualistic.
- 4.68 Every individual has rights to life, liberty, pursuit of happiness, lots of toleration. People can believe whatever it is that we want. The rest of us have to just put up with all of that stuff. Then we have to have an economy where people can choose their own careers and make their own investments. We have this, from Comte's perspective, more anarchistic, modern capitalist economy that is developing. Then, of course, politically, we start to talk only not about republican rights to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness and so on, but democratic political institutions.
- 4.69 We start to say things like, well, every individual should participate in the political process, and every person's opinion is going to count equally with everybody else's opinion. But look at most people and what their opinions are. They're not particularly informed, and they have all kinds of selfish interests at work and so forth. So

democracy and the whole movement of much of modern moral philosophizing, as it plays out politically, just leads to anarchy. We have various versions of anarchic democracy fighting with each other. But all of them, of course, are fighting against the old guard, the old way of doing things, the people who say we need to get back to hierarchy and people knowing their place.

- 4.70 Who are you to judge what's true and what's moral and what's better? You should believe in certain authoritative institutions, certain authoritative individuals as well. So, that's the retrograde, going back aristocracy. The idea of aristocracy is, who should have power is not the people, but the best people, the proper people, the "aristoi", going back to the Greek. We have right now a big battle going on between these two factions. What Comte is going to argue, that's a false alternative.
- 4.71 The third option, and the proper option, he is certainly one for making up new concepts, new words. What we need is a sociocracy. So the "kratos", the Greek word for power—who should have power? It's not going to be the old hereditarist aristocracy. It's not going to be those who claim that they are channeling God's insights and so forth, but rather it's going to be the sociologists. That is to say, those social, scientifically informed people who have proved their intellectual worth, proved their moral worth. Those are the people who will have power in society, and they will remake society along proper religion of humanity, sociocratic grounds.
- 4.72 "We sociocrats are no more democrats than aristocrats." The point is going to be, we have to think in terms of three options here. "The West can no longer submit its reason to the guidance of opinions which evidently admit of no demonstration; nay, which are radically chimerical, as are all opinions derived from theology." Up until the modern world, everybody basically was religious. One of the achievements of modern science and philosophy has been to explode the pretensions of theological doctrine. So ultimately, there is one world. It's the natural world. It's the world that science studies. If we're going to make any progress in morality, we have to recognize this.
- 4.73 Hume, mentioning of the philosophers who have been most influential on me, people who are in the positivist vein will almost always go back to David Hume, someone we are not covering in this course, except at a couple of points as an aside here. In our other course on modern philosophy, we do have a whole lecture devoted to Hume. He's absolutely important. From Comte's perspective, Comte wants to say Hume is the one who awakened him from his dogmatic slumber and took his philosophical enterprise in a different direction. Here we have Comte also saying, "Hume is my first and foremost philosopher."
- 4.74 Now, just a little sidebar here, what Hume is, is a kind of empiricist. Let's say we need to start with our sensory knowledge, not from speculative knowledge, not from stuff that's written in books, not from authoritative or allegedly authoritative institutions. Use your eyes, use your ears, use your five senses, and build up whatever knowledge you have from that empirical basis. And Hume and the other empiricists, especially the

more radical ones, will argue, if you approach that way, you will get science of some sort out of that, but you're never going to get ghosts and goblins and devils and gods and great battles that are going on, apparently in some supernatural dimension. All of that is not going to meet any empiricist criterion.

- 4.75 This is a signal that Comte is making, that that is the right fundamental approach here. Kant comes in as an accessory, and this is what I mean by my positivism now a couple of generations later. Our opponents are trying for some sort of an egoistic synthesis. I'm going to be arguing here for a kind of altruistic one. I am "founding the universal religion on true philosophy after I had extracted the latter from real science." This is what I am doing as a positivist. I am founding the universal religion.
- 4.76 This is going to be a religion, and much of what we mean by religion is going to be included in this, but on true philosophy, by which we mean empirical, positivistic scientific philosophy, after I had extracted the latter from real science. Good. So a merger, taking the good parts or the true parts from traditional religion, that it's more or less sort of grasped, but putting it on a true scientific basis. "I proceed to use in this catechism, the personal designations habitually used in religious instruction." We can talk about priests, we can talk about temples, we can talk about religion, and so forth. We'll use all of that language, but re-capture it.
- 4.77 Everything is very structured in Comte's religion of humanity, and there are strong hierarchical elements within it socially. Priests of humanity are going to be at the top, but you cannot become a priest of humanity until you are 42 years old. You have to go through a long period of training, both intellectually and morally, to demonstrate that you are worthy of becoming a priest of humanity. The priests will all be male. It's not to say that there isn't an important role for women in the religion of humanity. "In that world, the woman and the priest are, in fact, the two indispensable elements of the true moderating power, which is at once domestic and civic."
- 4.78 What we're suggesting here is a division between the household, the domestic household. That is going to be the woman's domain, and she is the chief power inside that domain. Outside of the household in the civic realm or the more public realm, that's where the priests of humanity will dominate. "During the last four years," that is, this is published in 1852, since 1848, "the reason of the people have suffered profoundly from the unfortunate exercise of universal suffrage." Suffrage is the idea that everybody should vote, or at least in the early part of the 19th century, first males should vote, then increasingly more and more males. Now we're starting to get to the point where people are considering allowing women the vote as well.
- 4.79 And Comte is arguing, that sort of democratic impulse is completely wrong. That's the source of our problems. Vast majority of people, not educated enough, not moral enough to be worthy of something so important as political power, deciding general policies on all of the big matters for society. Integrating the altruistic theme here, we're still in the press of the moral motto of positivism. Live for others. You don't live for

yourself. All of us talk about the rights to life, liberty, pursuit of happiness, me, me, me. No. First, others, others organized into the proper form of collective, with the right hierarchical structure, priests knowing their role of managing the civic sphere, women knowing their role managing the domestic sphere. That is the proper recipe for society.

4.80 All right, now we plunge into the first conversation between the woman and the priest. The woman says, "I ask you to begin your exposition by explaining in direct and precise language the radical sense of the word religion." So you, Comte, you're an atheist, but you're using this word religion. What do you mean, sir? The priest answers. "It expresses the state of perfect unity, which is distinctive of our existence, both individual and social, when all its parts, moral as well as physical, habitually converge toward a common purpose." That's religion, what religion's aspiration is, and we have a successful religion when we have achieved that.

4.81 The contrast here is to the idea that you have your life, you have your own ideas, and so do I, and so does everyone. We're having a social space where we can all go about our own lives as we see fit, coming together as we as individuals make a judgment and so forth. Comte is arguing that is not moral and is not proper political organization as well. We are one entity. We should all come together and be serving one common purpose, all of society organized for a particular direction.

4.82 Also, this universal religion, rather, is a universal religion. One of the modern themes has been, well, we have to expect a diversity of religions and a plurality of religions. People are going to take responsibility for their own religious beliefs, positive or negative. We're going to have to expect that there will be lots of different competing religions, and people will make their own individual choices. For Comte, that is a wrong approach. There is one scientific truth about reality and about humanity. That is what will be captured in the religion of humanity, so there should be one religion. "There is, at bottom, but one religion at once universal and final, to which all of the partial and provisional syntheses more and more pointed."

4.83 So whatever is good in all of the earlier religions that are out there, we will incorporate that into the one true religion of humanity, and it will be our common way of belief and worship. It's not just on perhaps what we might think of as more spiritual or psychological matters. Also, the governance of people's bodies and their health, including medicine, all needs to be incorporated into the religion of humanity and administered by the sociocrats. It's a "wise reincorporation of medicine into the domain of the priesthood, when the positive clergy shall have adequately fulfilled its conditions."

4.84 Then he goes on to say we can't leave it up to individuals to make their own health decisions because, basically, most people, again, they're too lazy, they're too unambitious. They come to believe all sorts of weird things. They're inconsistent in their applications. So the health, the physical health of the people, will not be where it should be unless it is under the control of the priests of humanity. "Men will not

generally submit to any practical inconvenience solely on the ground of their personal health, where each is left to judge for himself." We can't go in that direction.

- 4.85 We have to appeal to authorities higher than the individual. "Real efficacy, resting then on a social judgment which never admits uncertainty." The woman, after some discussion, says, "Well, I can see where you're going with this, and it's appealing, but how are you going to overcome those egoistic impulses in human beings, that individualism that seems strong in most people?" It's a radical difficulty. "Our personal instincts have, unfortunately, greater energy than our sympathetic tendencies."
- 4.86 The priest then acknowledges, "Herein, you have, my daughter, directly raised the grand problem of man's existence, which is in fact to secure the gradual predominance of sociability over personality, the collective over the individual, whereas personality is naturally predominant." And this is the big problem. Moral unity is impossible. It's impossible to get people to live for others if we take this individualism as predominantly. What we need to do is find some way to achieve this altruistic unity, as he calls it, which condenses all sound morality, again, in the law, live for others.
- 4.87 What Comte essentially is going to argue is that, just as science has made progress in figuring out how the planets move, the various laws of physical being, chemistry is making good advances at isolating all of the different elements and how they can combine in various ways to achieve certain results, our understanding of human beings scientifically is also making great progress. We're getting better and better at understanding ourselves physically, understanding ourselves psychologically.
- 4.88 Once the science is worked out well enough, those who are the true scientists, who are educated in that advanced science, will then be in a position to know how to, so to speak, push people's buttons in the right kind of way, to program them or to reprogram them to live altruistically. Human nature, with the proper applications of science, can remake human nature in the proper moralistic direction.
- 4.89 "Positivism was the direct result of this final discovery," the human sciences, "the completion of our long initiation, and as such, necessarily closing the preliminary era of human beings." All right. "I hope, my daughter, soon to make you see that it is possible to radically transform this egoism originally attaching to human labor." We can take human beings, with all of their natural desires and inclinations, and then the society as it has been currently made in a more individualistic, democratic, capitalist way, and with the proper political power in the sociocracy, and the proper scientific knowledge, radically remake human beings so they form a collective and work for the common purpose.
- 4.90 This naturally is going to mean that we need to take over the education system. All of education needs to be incorporated into the sociocracy so that, from the very beginning, when we take charge of the little children, we can make, and in some cases, remake them in the proper direction. The woman starts to get a little worried at this

point. "I am frightened," after listening to you, priest, "at my own insignificance in presence of such an existence." The world you are presenting, and my proposed role in that world, where I am totally remade into a servant of humanity and living only for others—what about me? I seem to dwindle to insignificance, "the immensity of which reduces me to nothing."

- 4.91 This is self-less and then self, even more less, less, less, less, until it seems like I become nothing in this system. "It reduces me to nothing more completely than did of old, the majesty of a God with whom, though feeble, I felt myself in some definite and direct relation." Many traditional religions ask you to subordinate yourself, suppress yourself, think of yourself as less, humble yourself, humiliate yourself, fall to the floor and press your face into the ground, and submit your will entirely to the will of a more powerful being. There are religions like that.
- 4.92 This seems even more self-sacrificing and self-abnegating than that. But even in the case of traditional religions that went down that road, there was still me that had some worthiness or some significance in the eyes of God, and I was participating in some sense in God's ultimate plan for the world. What do I have in your world? The priest answered, "It is sufficient if we see that, whilst humanity as a whole always constitutes the principal motor of our operations," that is to say, we're all servants of humanity, we're all acting only for humanity as a whole, not for ourselves, "constitutes the principal motor of all of our operations, physical, intellectual, or moral, the great being can never act except through individual instruments."
- 4.93 And that is Comte's answer to the woman's fear. You are still an essential instrument, as an individual, through your initiative, serving the great being, making possible the existence of the great being and the furtherance of its goals. So your significance will not go away to the extent that you merge yourself into this greater being, the collective that is humanity as a whole. All right. This is just of interest, a sketch Comte made for one of the temples of humanity, modeled on many traditional churches where everybody is going to be, where the offices are, where the sacraments are performed, and various sources.
- 4.94 He wanted to include not only the theory, but the architecture and designing everything in the society. Then his conclusion is, we'll put it on the slide here, "We come forward avowedly to deliver the West from this anarchical democracy," we saw that theme, "and from a retrograde aristocracy, so as to constitute, as far as possible, a true sociocracy." So the sociologists will be in power and remaking society, according to these three fundamental principles, the principle of altruism, the principle of order, and that we can progressively remake society in the proper direction.
- 4.95 Now, some indication of Comte's importance is, by the time of his death, there were temples of humanity trying to put into practices Comte's new religion, in many places in France, more even in England and various other places in Europe, and transplanted across the Atlantic Ocean to the Americas, both North America and South America. One

very interesting echo of Comte that is still with us prominently is, this is the flag of Brazil.

- 4.96 When the revolution occurred, that Brazil came into existence as its own country, achieved a full independence, it was followers of Comte who were significantly involved in that religion, and they were the ones who were responsible primarily for the design of this flag. If you read in Portuguese, the small print there right on the flag, order, sociocratic order is what is meant there, and progress. What is meant then is the development of human beings toward merging themselves in an altruistic collective. And Brazil, as a political project, according to these individuals, is meant to achieve that.
- 4.97 Here are the essentials. We take it as, again, axiomatic that self-interest and egoism are bad. Selflessness meant literally, collectivism and altruism are the good. Humanity, that collective being, all of us are a part of it, are to be not only the real entity, and sometimes Comte flirts with the language of being an organism, that we're all sharing in this greater organism. All of the apparatus and impulse of religion will be directed toward human, humanity's development.
- 4.98 Then this partly political, partly scientific, partly moral concept of sociocracy, a well-ordered moral society. It will be one in which the most scientifically educated, the most moral entities will be the ones who call the shots. I will leave you again with the big chart to fill out, should you so choose. How Comte would answer the big framing questions. Let's stop there.

Lecture 5: Mill

At a glance — Mill.

- 5.1 All right, let's begin in 1841 in England. 1841. John Stuart Mill, widely regarded as the most significant, important philosopher in Britain of the 19th century, and still common many decades later for standard textbooks in moral philosophy or ethics, that when they are including the concepts to cover, that will cover Kant's duty philosophy and John Stuart Mill's utilitarianism. And those two are often, for good reason, seen as opposed to each other in many fundamental respects.
- 5.2 But in 1841, John Stuart Mill is still relatively young for a philosopher, 35 years old. And I chose this year because he wrote a letter to Auguste Comte. Comte was huge, not only in France, but in Europe. And the younger John Stuart Mill is wanting to establish some connection with Comte. A kind of following and fascination with Comte's work and his career stuck with Mill over the course of his career. 1865, when he is now older and Comte has died recently, he publishes an entire essay devoted to Comte's philosophy, especially his positivism.
- 5.3 Now, despite this connection, often the connection in the case of Mill and Comte is a negative connection. Comte, as we know, advocated a hierarchical, dictatorial society wrapped up, we might cynically say, in nice language of religion and making up new words like sociocracy. But it is a kind of authoritarian dictatorship, however, a scientifically informed polity that he has recommended. John Stuart Mill is one of the great liberals, philosophically, of all time, and he was horrified by at least the political aspects and implications of Comte's philosophy. That explains part of his fascination with Comte, given his great significance.
- 5.4 In 1859, Mill wrote one of his most famous works. Perhaps his most famous work is *On Liberty*. Some of the themes of *On Liberty* are still with us today. Every time we have our contemporary debates about free speech, you can find a huge upsurge in the number of people quoting John Stuart Mill, particularly Chapter 2 of the absolute fundamental importance of liberty of conscience, robust discussion, robust debate, particularly in an education context, where students need to be exposed to all of the important positions, and advocated and argued by their most articulate representative, such that students can learn from the best of the best, and ultimately, a good education will leave it up to the individual student to make up his or her own mind, in an informed way, where that individual thinks the truth lies.
- 5.5 And Mill's, perhaps the most famous essay on the importance of free speech ever in the literature on free speech. Also in that same work, a little bit later, Mill argues forcefully for a kind of individuality, that it is individuals who should be able to enjoy their lives and put together their own lives' plans. We understand that people are different, and so we should expect a wide diversity of life plans that people are going to

adopt, and not merely tolerate the fact that people are choosing all of these wildly different life plans, but actually celebrate that diversity; and even celebrate the fact that there are people whom we all think of as rather eccentric or a little bit weird in various ways.

- 5.6 Not only because, as a matter of moral principle, they are doing their life their way, they're being the best they, but it also seems to be that it is the people who are rather out there in some respects, who are the ones who are the most creative, the most innovative, the ones responsible for coming up with the new inventions, the new ideas, the great musical and artistic accomplishments that we all then come to enjoy. And already in the mid-19th century, one of the things that Mill is worried about is this increasing action toward or reaction toward a kind of conformity, the idea that somehow we should all be the same.
- 5.7 We should all be doing the same sorts of things and pulling together for common purposes and various moral and political forces trying to make us into a unity, rather than celebrating the diversity. So rather, reacting against that tendency, a negative tendency, as Mill saw it, say, cultivating your individuality, cultivate your own eccentricity. "In this age, the mere example of nonconformity," I'm not going to conform, "the mere refusal to bend the knee to custom is itself a service." You want to prove not only yourself, but society, don't be a conformist. Mill is famous for arguing for a liberal individuality in that regard.
- 5.8 With respect to markets, against the rising tendency of socialisms, communisms, and Comtean type of, we want to organize a society, an economy, in order to serve the religion of humanity. Those reactionaries who disdain the idea that we're being commercial and putting a price tag on everything, Mill wants to argue that it is liberty of commerce, letting people make their own choices in their career, free and open trade, exchanging goods, ideas, people all around the world—this, more than anything, has made Europe more peaceful than at any point in its history.
- 5.9 Aristocrats fighting over lands, kings wanting to expand their glory and territory, religions and all of the nastiness and religious wars that have gone on, much of that ended by the early part of the 19th century, once England and other parts of the world started to become commercial democracies or commercial republics. We started to have international trade, and that is a matter of peaceful exchange of goods. If I'm an Englishman and I'm trading with France, and my customers are in France, and perhaps my raw materials are coming from Italy, well, think about the history of England, France, and Italy. For centuries, after centuries after century, they hate each other. It's just war, war, war, war, war, until we get to the modern world, and then suddenly the Italians and the French and the English are trading with each other.
- 5.10 If you're trading with each other, then you see your customers as your allies. It doesn't matter to you that, oh, it's those French people over there. They're giving you pounds. You want their pounds. You want their money. You want the [inaudible]. You don't

want war because war is going to interrupt your commercial relations and prosperity. We should be celebrating rather than denigrating the move toward a free market, open commercial society.

- 5.11** It is, as this quotation says, also from 1848, "It is commerce which is rapidly rendering war obsolete." The more commercial we are, the more we respect individual rights, the more we respect people's property rights, and we try to have international trade with each other, the more peaceful nations are going to be. So, a famous articulation of what is sometimes called the capitalist peace thesis, as part of a broader liberal framework, and Mill is quite well-known for articulating that.
- 5.12** Now, the ethics that underlies his liberal individualistic approach is developed a little bit later in the work that we're going to be focusing on, Utilitarianism, published in 1863. In some cases since, rather, Mill's views have changed a little bit. We can keep an eye out for those sorts of things. But another point that's going to be worth mentioning up front is that Mill is, aside from being a political philosopher and a moral philosopher, he is a deep philosopher who wrote on the foundations of logic and epistemology and addressed metaphysical issues and so on. He is a comprehensive philosopher.
- 5.13** One of the things he wants to argue is, while I may be liberal, individualistic, free market-oriented and so forth, I'm not coming out of that Lockean tradition, the John Locke tradition, where I think there are universal principles, rights to life, liberty, property, the pursuit of happiness, that are completely general and absolute, and that what I should do is somehow justify those very general abstract principles and then deduce various applications to them. Instead, I am an empiricist more ruthlessly than Locke. There are some influence of positivism in Mill as well, that what we need to do is start from the bottom and work our way up.
- 5.14** What is useful in this concept of utility? Not abstract principles, but what's practically useful and can be demonstrated to be practically useful on the basis of that, then cautiously we will come up with some—maybe principles is too strong a word, at least rules of thumb, general ways of acting, but we're not going to go all of that way. The language he uses here is this. "I forego any advantage which could be derived to my argument from the idea of abstract right, as a thing independent of utility. I regard utility as the ultimate appeal on all ethical questions."
- 5.15** What's useful is going to be fundamental. That's the ultimate appeal, and that needs to be demonstrated empirically, practically, and reasoned on the basis of. Hence, the name utilitarian-ism, taking that as our principle. Now, if we ask, and here we're telegraphing just a few key themes from Mill's ethics, so we can dive into them a little more deeply. I can use that telegraph metaphor because also the telegraph was invented in the 1840s, so it becomes chronologically apt. But what is useful? How are we going to say what's useful from what's un-useful or not useful? What's practical from what's impractical?

- 5.16** Here, what we're groping toward is what's going to be our fundamental distinction between the good and the bad, the either-or, the right or the wrong. And, when we do moral philosophy and we get down to our foundations, we have to find some way of grounding a distinction between the good and bad, some fork in the road, metaphorically speaking, in reality. What Mill is going to argue is that we're resuscitating an ancient Greek tradition called hedonism.
- 5.17** What hedonism had argued, back in Greek times, was that the distinction between pleasure and pain is the most fundamental distinction. We are biological creatures, as we now call ourselves. We are part of the natural world. We are part of the physical world, and built into us is already an indicator of what's good and bad for us, and it's pretty fundamental. If you were to put my hand out and start sticking pins into it and I start experiencing pain, how do I experience that pain? I experience it as a negative, as a bad. And somewhat automatically, I'm going to react against that.
- 5.18** If you try to ask me the question, OK, so you're experiencing this pain, but what's so bad about that? It's not like I need to come up with some other thing to explain why the pain is experienced as bad. It just is. That's fundamentally bad to me. Then the same thing on the positive side. Whatever your things are that you like to eat, chocolate or ice cream or whatever, and you take a morsel of that and you put it on your tongue and you let your mouth do its work and you experience the pleasure. You experience it fundamentally as good, as positive. If I were to ask you, yes, but what makes it good? Give me an explanation or some other principle that makes that good, you can't come up with it. It's experienced, fundamentally and basically, as good.
- 5.19** The claim is made by the hedonists, and that's to use the Greek word for pleasure, for gratification, things that appeal to the senses in a positive way, is then elevated. Hedonism is the principle that says the distinction between the good and the bad, fundamentally, is based on the distinction between pleasure and pain. That is written, so to speak, into nature and written into our constitution. Some things are naturally good and some things are naturally bad.
- 5.20** Now, this is an ancient doctrine. Hedonists such as Epicurus articulated it back in Greek times, and there were many schools of it. It largely went into eclipse during the Middle Ages with the ascendancy of religion, particularly Christianity, where concern with the body, with the physical, with pleasure and pain, was seen as less significant, morally, and perhaps even to be set aside. But it starts to become reintroduced in the modern world and what John Stuart Mill is going to do is offer a sophisticated, 19th-century version, updated understanding of hedonism.
- 5.21** He's going to argue, what is useful then is that which increases the amount of pleasure that we have in our lives, and that which is bad is anything that takes us in the direction of having more pain in our lives. That's the fundamental claim that we are making. Now, I want to telegraph, again, a couple of standard objections that Mill is going to be well aware of. When people say hedonism and the life of pleasure, it sounds to me, we

can start to say, well, that sounds like college frat boy or whatever the other variations of that are going to be; that you immediately go to, oh, that means drinking a lot and eating a lot and having lots of crazy sex and being promiscuous, et cetera, et cetera.

- 5.22** How could hedonism possibly be a doctrine of goodness that's nonetheless a principle of morality? In historical time, the kinds of examples that immediately come up are the case of Casanova, who are famous for being a seducer of women, seducer of many women, in a serial way, or a commitment to that kind of a lifestyle. How can we say that that's moral? He's even seducing married women, for goodness' sake. But he's pursuing a life of pleasure. Or entering into perhaps darker territory, the Marquis de Sade, famous for pursuing his life of pleasure through sexual means, but getting pleasure from torturing and humiliating and causing negative consequences to other people. But nonetheless, that was very pleasing to him. It aroused him psychologically and physically as well.
- 5.23** Or in the case of Masoch, Sacher-Masoch, who sometimes conjoined with Sade and sadism, masochism. The idea that somehow you are going to get your pleasure by being humiliated and subject to pain from other people. If we're going to say that pleasure and pain is fundamental, and we have all of these people pursuing a life of pleasure as they see fit and as they define it, doesn't it lead us into what seems to be, right off the bat, some rather bizarre moral territory, and we can just set it aside?
- 5.24** Now, again, just to indicate that Mill is well aware of this criticism. And one sort of thing he is going to do is to say this. "No human being should be a selfish egotist, devoid of every feeling or care but those which center in his own miserable individuality." So one way of his responding as a hedonist is to say, yes, we are about pleasure and pain, but there's another question. Whose pleasure and pain are we talking about, and who should be the judge of what counts as the right kinds of pleasure and pain? We're not going to leave it up to each individual with their own potential weirdnesses to legislate for themselves and for other people what counts as the appropriate.
- 5.25** So it's going to be, the kind of pleasure and pain that we are talking about is going to be a pleasure and pain that works for not everybody, that's too hard, but for most people. What we have then in the utilitarian moral standard is that it is what's useful. Useful is defined in terms of maximizing pleasure, minimizing pain, but for the most people, in whatever social grouping we happen to be talking about. The famous slogan that comes out of Utilitarianism, and this is the operative principle, is "the greatest happiness of the greatest number."
- 5.26** It's not going to be that we all have a happy-ever-after ending, that we're going to find some way of organizing our lives individually and socially, that everybody's always happy and so forth. There will be some mistakes. We have to be reasonable and pragmatic and lower our sights in some respects. But this majoritarian approach, which certainly fits in with the modern temperament, that we're going to be somewhat

democratic about not only our politics, but also our ethics, what works for most people most of the time—those will be the principles, morally, that we adopt.

- 5.27 Now, let's plunge in, as I like to do, to John Stuart Mill's words themselves, as he puts it, with my initial introductory gloss. As is common as a rhetorical trope, almost, but it's an anxiety that most philosophers feel when they become historically educated and they realize how long we've been arguing about ethical issues and particularly in the modern world, the great diversity of answers that come up with. "From the dawn of philosophy," if we go back even to Aristotle, Plato, Socrates, and the pre-Socratics, as far as we have records, they have been trying to raise these questions.
- 5.28 "The question concerning the summum bonum," or the greatest good or the summit, the highest good that is possible, "has been the main problem, occupied the most gifted intellects, and divided them into sects and schools, carrying on a vigorous warfare, after more than 2,000 years." We just have to stop for a moment and try to wrap our minds around 2,000 years. These numbers, they get so big that they start to lose their meaning. But how many generations of super-bright people, thinking about these issues, and where are we now significantly into the modern world?
- 5.29 "Philosophers are still ranged under the same contending banners." Yay, positivism. Yay, Kantianism. "Neither thinkers nor mankind at large seem nearer to being unanimous on the subject." All of the old Greek schools, all of the old Roman schools, all of the religious schools, all of the humanistic schools and so on, they're all still with us, and I'm not going to say we have a natural faculty or sense or instinct that somehow we're able to just see or not what's good or bad. He doesn't think we have any such instinct. We have had to abandon that notion that somehow it's a fundamental.
- 5.30 Here, he has a mention early on of philosopher Immanuel Kant, whom we are now familiar with. Kant recognized, as pretty much everybody recognizes by the middle part of the 1800s, as a new giant on the philosophical landscape. Here's Kant's *Metaphysics of Ethics*. "This remarkable man whose system of thought will long remain one of the landmarks in the history of philosophical speculation." Here's Kant's principle. "So act that the rule on which thou actest would admit to being adopted as a law by all rational beings."
- 5.31 All right, so that's the Kantian system, and we've read through the *Metaphysics of Ethics*, and Mill's reaction is to say, "Well, he fails." This is a nice, civil Englishman saying, "Almost grotesquely." It's very strong language for a 19th-century Englishman. "He fails almost grotesquely" to show that his system is properly grounded and that if you are clever enough, you couldn't find some way to rationally justify almost anything that you particularly want. So even the great luminous Kant failed to get ethics off the ground. So what I'm going to do is make an argument, I now being John Stuart Mill, for a better, more empirically, scientifically, physically grounded system that can be argued for and understood by anyone.

- 5.32 Now, there's a tricky thing that he is aware of, that says, I am going to do a scientific demonstration, and often what we want to come out of science is a proof. Here's the data, and then we go step-by-step, and we reach a certain proof. What we need to do then is have our proof, so to speak, be that the greatest happiness for the greatest number is the end result of this derivation that we are engaging in. This is a very hard thing to do because, as he puts it here, "Questions of ultimate ends are not amenable to direct proof. Whatever can be proved to be good, must be so by being shown to be a means to something admitted to be good without proof."
- 5.33 If I want to say, this is something that's good, and I have to say why that's good, well, I have to then say that this is good maybe because it leads to this. But what makes that good? Well, this is good because it leads to this. I might have a long chain of good things. It's good for me to put gas in my truck. Why? Well, because then I can drive to the store when I want to. But why do you want to go to the store? Because I want to buy some groceries. Why do you want to buy some groceries? Well, so I have something to eat. Why do you want to have something to eat? Well, so that I can function at work the next day. Well, why do you want to work? Well, because I want to make money. Well, why do you want to make money? We just keep on going, right?
- 5.34 So, what is this ultimate thing that is going to justify all of these other things that I am doing? What is the summum bonum, so to speak, or the highest possible good? And his argument is to say, well, wherever we get to that thing, whatever that is, it can't be because it leads to something else, because then we're just keeping on going. It has to be that is something that is good without reference to something beyond it. That makes it a different kind of thing, and that's going to be a hard problem. So he gives some examples here.
- 5.35 "The medical art." What is it to be a good doctor, a good nurse? Well, "it's proved to be good by its conducing to health." Good medical practice leads to health. But then if we ask, "How do we prove that health is good? The art of music is good, for the reason, amongst others, that it produces pleasure; but what proof is it possible to give that pleasure is good?" You're enjoying that chocolate taste in your mouth. Prove to me that that's good. What can you possibly say or what can you justify that in terms of? It just seems like it's just good in itself, but that's a hard problem. What he wants to argue is that there's a more expanded understanding of proof that he's going to need to articulate in order to answer that question.
- 5.36 A few prefatory remarks. He wants to say that the connection he's making is between the concept of utility and the concept of pleasure. We've introduced that. Some people want to say, oh, utilitarianism, that sounds like being practical. That sounds like something that's kind of boring. And what's useful is going to your job that you don't particularly like and paying the bills, et cetera, et cetera, and obeying the law. Being a useful member of society seems like something different from having fun and having a pleasurable life, which is not particularly useful.

- 5.37 That misunderstanding Mill wants to get rid of right off the bat. Many commentators, with respect to Utilitarianism, have made that mistake. Utility is not opposed to pleasure. Utility is the thing which maximizes pleasure. Let's clear that up. "Every writer, from Epicurus," the ancient, "to Bentham," Bentham an earlier 1800s thinker who was also a utilitarian, Mill is going to offer an upgraded version of that, "have maintained that a theory of utility, meant by it, not something to be contradistinguished from pleasure, but pleasure itself, together with exemption from pain." So don't make that shallow mistake.
- 5.38 By the greatest happiness principle, "happiness is intended pleasure, and the absence of pain; by unhappiness, pain, and the privation of pleasure." That is our fundamental distinction. So, pleasure and pain, that which is most useful at avoiding pain and maximizing the amount of pleasure, a life so constituted is going to be the happy life. That's the framework that we are trying to establish. Now, a criticism. "Such a theory of life excites in many minds the most inveterate dislike." Here we adopt a sarcastic tone of voice. "To suppose that life has, as they express it, no higher end than pleasure, no better and nobler object of desire and pursuit, they designate as utterly mean and groveling, a doctrine worthy only of swine."
- 5.39 Pigs, wallowing in the mud, eating whatever slop the farmer happens to throw for them, just lying there in the sun while the mud bakes on them, their feces and urine just running out, and they don't particularly care. But that's a pretty happy pig. If we're all about happiness, and we start endorsing this to other human beings, given what we know about many human beings, it sounds like we're just encouraging a big herd of human beings to adopt a rather swinish or piggish kind of life. Now, how do we respond to that?
- 5.40 "When thus attacked, the Epicureans," that is to say, the hedonists, and Mill is going to include himself in this category, "have always answered, that it is not they, but their accusers, who represent human nature in a degrading light; since the accusation supposes human beings to be capable of no pleasures except those of which swine are capable." So yes, maybe it's true. I sometimes like to dress in a relaxed fashion. I don't particularly care about my clothes. Sometimes I eat some junk food. I like to have naps in the sun and just lie around and whatever. So all of the kinds of pleasures that swine are capable of, we, if humans, also are capable of.
- 5.41 But if you think that that's all a human being is, then you are the one with the problem. You are the one with a base understanding of what it is to be a human being. The fact is, Mill then goes on, notice the word fact, "Human beings have faculties more elevated than the animal appetite." We have all of those. Yes, we like sex, food, drinking, sleeping, and so forth, but we are much more complicated than that. So whatever we're talking about human pleasures has to include all of those more complicated and more elevated things.

- 5.42 "When once made conscious of them, do not regard anything as happiness which does not include their gratification. It is quite compatible with the principle of utility to recognize the fact, that some kinds of pleasure are more desirable and more valuable than others." We shouldn't be considering only the quantity of pleasures. We should be considering also the quality of pleasures. It might be that I can, of course, eat a huge amount of food and enjoy that and then eat some more. But at a certain point, I want to have better foods.
- 5.43 And part of our education and maturity might be to say, yes, I am satisfied when I first taste a certain food and say, oh, that's really good, and I enjoy that, and then I eat all and only that. But then I start to learn that, not only is there some diversity in food tastes, and I should expand my range, but even in that category of things that I like, there are some things that are better than others, and then even better. Once I have acquired a taste and a knowledge that the better exists, it's hard for me to be satisfied only with the lower one.
- 5.44 I might, to take a very simple example, enjoy drinking water, and that is a great pleasure to drink water. But then also you learn that water can be carbonated. In addition to enjoying just plain water, sometimes you will enjoy carbonated water. It may be water that is then flavored with certain kinds of fruits. Then perhaps water that has been combined with grapes and fermented and cultivated into wine. Maybe the first taste of wine that you had in your teen years, you said, "Oh, I like this. This is something that I like." But then you start to learn that some wines are better than others and so forth. There's a whole gradation possible of drinks. The idea that all I'm ever going to do is drink one kind of drink, and just over drink, overdrink, or drink huge amounts of that the way a swine does, that's degrading understanding with respect to human beings.
- 5.45 The way Mill puts it is this way. "If I am asked what I mean by a difference of quality in pleasures, or what makes one pleasure more valuable than another, merely as pleasure, except its being greater in amount, there is but one possible answer." Here's the answer. "Of two pleasures, if there be one to which all or almost all who have experience of both give a decided preference, irrespective of any feeling of moral obligation to prefer it, that is the more desirable pleasure." You have to have experience of both.
- 5.46 When your mom or your dad, when you were a little kid, said, "Just try it," when you were resisting trying this new thing, they wanted you to say, "Yes, I know what you like to eat, but here's something else that you might want to consider and you might like it more. You're not going to find out until you actually try it." Then if you try it, and a whole bunch of other people have tried both, and we find that pretty much everybody who has now experienced enough, has legitimately tried both, says, "This is the better one," then that is the better one. That's the one that is higher in quality.

- 5.47 We pick up where we left off. I'm an amateur when it comes to wine, occasional wine drinker with dinner, with respect. I hear all of these people rhapsodizing about the wonders of certain wines and so forth. If I were just simply, as a young person, to say, "I don't know, I've tried this bottle of wine, or this kind of wine once. That's the only wine I'm ever going to try," that would be a lack of development in me. I know that there are other wines out there and that people who have experienced the wine that I drank, plus various other wines, have said, "These ones actually are better." It should be incumbent upon me, in part of my self-development, to at least give it a try.
- 5.48 What Mill is then arguing is, the reason why we can say some wines are, in fact, better than others is that, when we consult people who have tried a lot of different wines, it may not be unanimous, but there is a very strong tendency for them to say, "This one is better than this one, and this one is better than this one," all the way down. This is not simply a subjective fact about your own unique personality. It is based in experience, but it's based in the experience of people who have had multiple experiences, and a large number of people who have done so.
- 5.49 "Now, it is an unquestionable fact." Again, there's a fact here, "that those who are equally acquainted with both, and equally capable of appreciating and enjoying both, do give a most marked preference to the manner of existence which employs their higher faculties." Now, we've been using examples of food, drink, wine, and so forth to make the more general point. But Mill then goes on to say that, unlike the swine, we human beings, in addition to complicated physical faculties, we also have mental faculties.
- 5.50 And as a human being, the higher pleasures, the best pleasures that we can get, are more often psychological than physical. That's the claim that he is making here, they're higher faculties. This includes our emotions, our thinking, our rationality, our contemplating our existence all the way up to the meaning of life. Cultivating a stock of memory as our life goes on, that we can reflect on and get certain pleasures from remembering various sorts of things. All of these things humans are capable of, and most animals are not or are capable of doing so in various limited degrees that we're still learning about.
- 5.51 Then he makes the point, if this is true, and he thinks it is true, "few human creatures would consent to be changed into any of the lower animals, for a promise of the fullest allowance of a beast's pleasures." A little thought experiment. You are a human being. You've experienced lots of thoughts, lots of experiences. You've built up lots of memories. You can think about your future, you can think about your past, you can think about what's going on in the world, in your life. All of that goes on in your mind. Suppose you could become a dog.
- 5.52 Would you make that choice? And that would mean then you would stop really thinking about the future. All sorts of careers, possibilities, would be closed off to you. All of your musical preferences, maybe dogs have some responsiveness to simple

rhythms and maybe some simple melodies, but your entire musical life would go away. Would you do it? Even if I promised you, you would live the best dog's life possible. Tasty food, three times a day, or whatever dogs are supposed to eat. Nice warm bed, someone to pet you for a little bit of time in the evenings, top-notch medical, veterinarian care, and so on. Would you choose to live the best dog's life or a, perhaps, work-in-progress, not-yet-perfect human life?

- 5.53** And Mill's point is, no question. The human life is higher in quality. I, having experienced it, would not go back. Now, maybe you would say, I don't know, the dog's life, in certain moments, seems pretty attractive. Well, how about the life of a squirrel? We'll drop it down a little bit. The best squirrel life possible? No way. The best life of a lizard? No. Once you've experienced the higher, you can't be satisfied only with the lower. "No instructive person would be an ignoramus. No person of feeling and conscience would be selfish and base, even though they should be persuaded that the fool, the dunce, or the rascal is better satisfied with his lot than they are with theirs."
- 5.54** Then the famous line that is oft quoted from John Stuart Mill, "It is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied." So someone who's, put it bluntly, an idiot in contemporary life, just really foolish, but doesn't realize that he or she is completely foolish, believes all kinds of ridiculous things, is on the path for a certain low-level life and so on, but seems to be a kind of a happy person. And contrast that to, say, a philosopher like Socrates, who's not sure that it all really adds up to something significant and experiences some dissatisfaction. You don't want to be the fool. You want to be the dissatisfied, wise person.
- 5.55** "From this verdict, only competent judges, I apprehend there can be no appeal. According to the greatest happiness principle, as above explained, the ultimate end, with reference to and for the sake of which all other things are desirable, is an existence exempt as far as possible from pain," minimize pain as much as possible, "and as rich as possible in enjoyments, both in point of quantity and quality." We want as much pleasure as possible, but also the highest quality pleasures as much as possible. That's the standard we are striving for. Everything that we do, if we are thoughtful about it, is in the direction of training ourselves and acting in ways that will enable us to put together that kind of life. That is the happy life.
- 5.56** "The test of quality, and the rule for measuring it against quantity, being the preference felt by those who in their opportunities for experience, to which must be added their habits of self-consciousness and self-observation, are the best furnished with the means of comparison." So, people who've had the experiences, multiple experiences, so they are now qualified to do so, and we also know that they have good habits, so to speak, of self-introspection and what's going on in themselves to make their best, most fine, discriminating judgments as possible.

- 5.57 All right. Now, what this then is going to mean for Mill is, he says, look, we know lots of people who seem to be pretty smart and have a whole bunch of experiences, but they seem to have chosen base lifestyles. No one can argue, for example, that Casanova was uneducated or that the Marquis de Sade, embarking on his various sadistic activities, was uneducated. He was extraordinarily educated. He was a member of the aristocracy. He had everything. He had experienced every kind of thing. And nonetheless, he chose, from his perspective of privilege and experience and cultivation, to choose what seemed to be sadistic, pain-inflecting experience.
- 5.58 What are we going to say about people like that? And Mill's answer then is to say that we cannot take the happiness principle merely as an individualistic judgment call. "As little as there is inherent necessity that any human being should be a selfish egotist, devoid of every feeling or care, but those which center on his own miserable individuality." It has to be something more general, something more common, multiple people's experience. There always are going to be, from Mill's perspective, people who are odd. There's the exception to the general rule that goes on. And so the Marquis de Sades and the various others are going to be in that category as well.
- 5.59 It's also not going to be that you are to see your life as the Lockeans would have it, as your right or the ultimate, or a recipient here. If you are going to talk about the happiness, it has to be a more generalized, I don't quite want to say collectivized notion of happiness here, and a willingness to sacrifice as an individual for the happiness of others. In a certain circumstance, the way the world is, Mill wants to go on to say, well, there are actions that will make me happier, and they might even be higher quality things that will make me happier. But I'm in a certain social group, and it might be that my pursuit of that causes some unhappiness for other people.
- 5.60 It might be that my pursuit of my happiness, the way I see it, given the way the world works, is outweighed by the happiness of a larger number of other people, if I pursued this other action. And so Mill wants to argue, in those cases, utilitarian as he wants to say, it's the greatest happiness, not just of the individual. You have to be willing to sacrifice, in some cases, your happiness for others. The way he puts that point is here. "It is noble to be capable of resigning entirely one's own portion of happiness or chances of it; but after all, this self-sacrifice must be for some end. It is not its own end."
- 5.61 Now, this is then to say, look, we want every individual to be happy, and Mill is largely individualistic in lots of things. But with the logic of his position, if our goal is to maximize happiness, and we do recognize that we live in a world where some people's happiness conflicts with other people's happiness, the best that we can do is go for a majoritarian, greatest happiness for the greatest number. "Though it is only in a very imperfect state of the world's arrangements that anyone can best serve the happiness of others by the absolute sacrifice of his own, yet so long as the world is in that

imperfect state, I fully acknowledge that the readiness to make such a sacrifice is the highest virtue which can be found in man."

- 5.62 I must, again, a little bit later, emphasizing this point. Yes, I am individualistic, but I'm not at basis an individualist. "I must, again, repeat what the assailants of utilitarianism seldom have the justice to acknowledge, that the happiness which forms the utilitarian standard of what is right in conduct, is not the agent's own happiness." It's not your happiness as an individual, "but that of all concerned. As between his own happiness and that of others, utilitarianism requires him to be as strictly impartial as a disinterested and benevolent spectator."
- 5.63 The model we have here is, as we would say, we're a mini society here right now. We're all unique individuals, and some of us would like these foods, and some of us would like those foods and drinks and these pursuits and games and so forth. But to the extent that we are members of a society, if I am a moral member in that society, I want to maximize the overall happiness or the overall pleasure in the society. I am a part of this society, but his point is that I can't value my list of pleasures and pains more than your list of pleasure and pains and your weightings of all of those.
- 5.64 We need to aggregate and perform some rudimentary calculation of what's going to overall maximize the happiness. If that requires on some or several occasions that I sacrifice my happiness, but it increases the overall happiness, Mill's point is that that is a requirement of his ethic. He makes an interesting connection here to the ethics of Christianity. "In the golden rule of Jesus of Nazareth, we read the complete spirit of the ethics of utility." Now, which one he means exactly, "To do as you would be done by, and to love your neighbor as yourself." There is also a kind of egalitarian or equalitarian standard in here as well. "Constitute the ideal perfection of utilitarian morality."
- 5.65 Religion. Mill is not a religious man. He would, from his epistemological stance, not claim that he knows for absolute certain that there is no God. He would say something closer to an agnostic position, that he's not convinced by the arguments for the existence of God. The proper thing to do when one is not convinced is to disbelieve to that extent. But keep a mind open that new evidence and facts might come along. Nonetheless, if we are going to try to found moral science on something that we actually can know, we should go with what we know, and what we know are facts about the world, that human nature is what it is.
- 5.66 We have the pleasure-pain mechanism, but some physical pleasures as well as psychological pleasures. And so we should be articulating an ethic on that factual basis. But he wants to alleviate one kind of objection to non-religious ethics here. He wants to say that, when people make appeals to gods, they often have very different kinds of gods in mind. There's a difference between the kind of God that doesn't seem to care very much about human beings, that seems to be very angry and frowny-faced and always just waiting for them to make a mistake so we can do some nasty punishment to them and maybe even to wipe out the entire human species.

- 5.67 We have this very angry, vengeful God who wants us to suffer and sacrifice and is willing to kill and so forth. If your conception of religion is that kind of a God, well, then yes, we're not going to find very much connection between this utilitarian doctrine, which is about happiness in this world, and your religion. But if your conception of the deity or of God is of a more benevolent being, who created this natural and beautiful world and created us and made us a certain way and gave us a pleasure-pain mechanism and wants us to enjoy our physical being and our psychological being in this beautiful world that he has made; that is to say, if your conception of God is a God who wants us to be happy, then utilitarianism is exactly the moral doctrine that's compatible with your religion.
- 5.68 So he wants to make peace with some religious people, but not others. OK. Now, there's a question here about subjectivity. Because in one sense, we're talking this language of fact, we're talking this language of science, and we're saying there is such a thing as human nature and so forth. But it seems that the ultimate source of what's right and wrong and the ultimate standard is not in any way objective. One of the things that religious thinkers will often do is to say that we need to have a standard of morality that is outside of ourselves. We say outside of ourselves, objectively, there is a God. God has laid down the law, and therefore we know how to conduct our behavior.
- 5.69 Or some more naturalistic philosophers will say that there is things that are good and bad out there in nature and that we can sense, we have perhaps a moral sense, just like we can distinguish between red and yellow, we can sense the difference between good and bad. But out there, there's a difference between the good and the bad, objectively. But what Mill is suggesting is that the standard is this pleasure-pain mechanism, and that's inside the subject, which is to make it seemingly more subjective.
- 5.70 If we then start to add the obvious proposition, that individuals seem to differ in what they report to be pleasurable and what they report to be painful, is it not the case then that subjectivism is going to lead to this great diversity of standards of good and bad, a kind of relativism, and it's just going to come down to what I think is good and bad and what you think is good and bad is completely different because we are completely different subjects? So, how does Mill respond to this objection?
- 5.71 "The ultimate sanction, therefore, of all morality, external motives apart, being a subjective feeling in our own minds, I see nothing embarrassing to those whose standard is utility, in the question, what is the sanction of that particular standard?" His answer then is, "We may answer, the same as all other moral standards, the conscientious feelings of mankind." The best that we can do is, if we look at man not as discrete individuals with all of their sometimes peculiarities and eccentricities, mankind, we are all basically constituted the same way. Basically, the same sorts of things are, for the most part, going to give us pleasures and pains.
- 5.72 The fact then that I experience certain pleasures and pains in a certain way, and often to a certain degree, is going to be picked up with and agreed upon by you as well.

Always allowing that there are going to be some exceptions, but perhaps that is the best we can do. "Undoubtedly, this sanction has no binding efficacy on those who do not possess the feelings it appeals to," but those people aren't going to follow any moral standards anyway. What, ultimately, for example, can we say to someone like the Marquis de Sade? There's some person there and the Marquis de Sade hits the person with a whip. The person says, "Oh, that's painful." It may be the person cuts and is now bleeding.

5.73 We think of ourselves as normal, healthy people. We say, "That's disgusting. That's terrible. You're a bad person." And Marquis de Sade said, "Well, why? What's so wrong about that?" He says, "Well, you hit the guy." He says, "Yeah, I agree. I hit the guy." There's no factual disagreement here. He says, "Well, you caused him pain." And Marquis de Sade would say, "Yeah, I caused him pain. That was the whole idea." So no disagreement on that as well. You would say, "Yeah, but that's bad." He would say, "What's bad about it?" Then we say, "Well, what's bad about it is that it makes me feel bad. I feel psychologically tormented." He says, "I don't feel that. In fact, I feel the opposite. I feel good, while you feel bad."

5.74 So, we have this subjective feelings and now a competition between various subjective feelings. And Mill is saying we can't go anywhere beyond that. The best that we can do is to say, the majority of mankind, when they are confronted with people inflicting pain on each other, find it to be minimally distasteful, sometimes repugnant. They recoil from it. They don't like it. It causes them physical pain. They don't want it to be a principle, that people can just hit each other and cause them pain whenever they want. That's the greatest happiness of the greatest number. We can just say as well, some people are different, and we marginalize those people as much as we possibly can.

5.75 One other side point I want to mention before wrapping things up here is Mill wants to make a little bit of peace with Comte. He wants to say that he's open to the idea, not Comte's politics, which is much too dictatorial for him and much too universalistic for him. But to say that in the kind of liberal society that he is envisioning, we should be open to the idea that modernized religions are going to be a part of the mix, and so he makes a suggestion here that, as long as Comte's religion doesn't become a politics, as long as it becomes a voluntary church, another one that other people join, and that within that church, they urge everybody to think of themselves as part of a greater collective and to live only for others, Mill says that might be one of the moral forces inside of society, along with various other ones that can help us in the right moral direction.

5.76 And so, he says he recommends Comte's works, in this case, for that particular purpose. But then he does say, "I entertain the strongest objections to the system of politics," in that system. So I'm only talking about the social voluntary religion to the extent that it can be done so. I want to raise some more critical questions. These are ones that Mill is aware of. But one of the things I've been wrestling with, as I was

putting this course together, was that I desperately wanted to include Dostoevsky, Fyodor Dostoevsky, in the mix, and I couldn't quite make it so that he had a lecture of his own.

- 5.77** I'm going to bring him in as one of the great critics and responders to Mill and Mill's doctrine of utilitarianism, which became widespread in the 19th century, reaching as far as Russia, where the great psychological novelist, Fyodor Dostoevsky, became aware of it and brilliantly incorporated various kinds of utilitarian characters into his novels. One of the questions that immediately comes up is, Mill has talked about miserable individuality and somehow we have to go to the greatest happiness for the greatest number, and sometimes it's going to mean that you have to sacrifice your happiness for other people and expect other people—
- 5.78** If we take morality as a general social principle, what do we say, though, in a society where we have minorities of various sorts along various dimensions? Doesn't it seem like the doctrine of utilitarianism—this is the objection— is going to lead to a systematic undervaluing and sacrificing of those in the minority? If, for example, we are a group and we are saying, where are we going to go to eat? To take a very homey example here. It turns out that eight out of the 10 people in this particular group just really love Chinese food, and two people hate Chinese food, well, what is the greatest happiness of the greatest number principle going to dictate?
- 5.79** We'll say, well, OK, on this particular night, greatest happiness for the greatest number means we eat Chinese food. You two who really hate Chinese food, tough. Sacrifice. Put up with it. But then the next night, we're still the same group of Chinese food lovers and the same group. So doesn't it seem like then, consistently, that the people who don't like Chinese food are never going to get to eat the food that they like? And doesn't that seem a little bit odd as a prediction? So if we're celebrating the majoritarian or perhaps a more collectivized understanding of what is good, do we not need in some way to tweak the philosophy so that the minority groups, and perhaps even minority individuals, don't systematically get excluded?
- 5.80** Then particularly, if we are interested in the connections between ethics and politics, and we want to say, laws of the land, should be based on what we think are good moral principles. If we say that our operative principle is going to be the greatest happiness for the greatest number, that sounds nice from one sense, that we're going to be democratic and just vote on various things, but what if, systematically, what the majority is voting on is to the detriment of legitimate interests, perhaps, of the minority? This is a persistent criticism that is raised of utilitarians, and utilitarians, of course, have responses to it.
- 5.81** But this is where I want to bring in Dostoevsky with a couple of possible objections, because he brilliantly, in novelistic form, takes the utilitarian doctrine and subjects it to some thought experiment criticisms. One of his famous works, *Crime and Punishment*, published just three years after *Utilitarianism* was published. The theme is crimes. A

crime is committed, and the open question is, will punishment occur? Will justice effect be done? If justice is going to be done, given this crime being committed, what's going to enable it to happen?

- 5.82** But the major opening plot thing that occurs is, there's a young man whose name is Raskolnikov, and he is a very poor, very struggling, and a university student who wants to study medicine. He wants to become a doctor. But because he is poor, he doesn't have the money to finish paying for his education. So he is on the verge of thinking, I'm not going to be able to get my university education, and I don't have any other prospects. So, very likely then, I will end up living a very poor, desperate life. And not only will I be unfulfilled in my life, but also society, more broadly, will miss out on my services as a medical doctor. So it's good for me and it's good for society that I become a medical doctor, but I'm not seeing that happening.
- 5.83** Now, he's living in a very poor neighborhood, and he comes to be aware of the existence of this old woman, an old lady, and she's nasty. Nobody likes her. She's this nasty, old, bitter old lady. It turns out, though, that she has made a significant amount of money over the course of her career. She's a pawnbroker. She has squirreled away lots and lots of money. By accident, Raskolnikov comes to be aware that this old woman, whom nobody likes and lives alone in this remote part of this building, has a lot of money hidden away there, and he starts to think, what if I stole that money? Would that be all right?
- 5.84** Normally and conventionally, we say, no, you shouldn't steal. That's bad, but if I'm thinking about what's best for society as a whole, is it better for society that this old woman has this money? She's just got it squirreled away. She's not using it for anything. It's not even being invested in various businesses and so on. Or is it better for society that I have this money, given that I'm going to become a medical doctor? So this rule, "Don't steal," perhaps is outweighed by this rule about what's more socially useful, what's going to bring the greatest happiness or the greatest pleasure to the most amount of people.
- 5.85** He starts to realize that, in the course of committing a robbery, robbery sometimes can turn to assault if he is discovered, and what would he do? As happenstance occurs, he does decide to commit the robbery, and he justifies it on this principle of the greatest happiness of the greatest number. There's no absolute property, right? In the course of this robbery, he is discovered by the old woman, he ends up killing her, so she dies. He is now a murderer as well as being a robber. But then he is in a position to become a doctor.
- 5.86** If we take the principle of the greatest happiness for the greatest number, with all of its flexibility and so forth, in this case, we're pushing it to a minority, and the minority in this case is one human life. Suppose it's true that Raskolnikov will become a very good doctor and save the lives and improve the health of thousands of people over the course of his career. That's a lot of happiness. Does that outweigh the pain of the one

old lady and the death of one old lady? Many lives saved, one lost. Much pleasure, short amount of pain. If we want to say, no, it's not a matter of this calculation, there's some absolute universal principle— you shall never rob or kill people—where can we possibly get that principle? Mill has abandoned it. John Stuart Mill has abandoned it.

- 5.87** But what Dostoevsky is doing is saying, this is exactly what we need to think about when we're talking about these new scientific-based modern ethical principles, utilitarianism being one of the greatest ones. Of course, in this case, we've made it even worse. We've said, this is an old lady who doesn't have any kids, so it's not like her heirs are going to suffer. Nobody likes this old woman. Nobody's going to be sad that she is no longer a part of their daily lives. She becomes a nonexistent. If there is still something in you that says, "No, that's wrong," then the utilitarian theory has a problem.
- 5.88** All right. A couple of points in conclusion. Mill also wrote shortly thereafter another work called *The Subjection of Women*, where he argued very strongly and persuasively in the English context for the equality of liberty rights for women as well as men. He was, for a period of time, a member of parliament, so an active politician, but also one who had a great reputation as a philosopher, as an economist, and so his voice was widely heard.
- 5.89** This is a book he wrote in consultation with, many conversations as he went, with his wife, Harriet Taylor, who was a very intelligent, articulate, and educated woman, so he gives her full credit for it. But part of the principle, as he sees it, of moral philosophy, is to say that the greatest happiness for the greatest number should include women. If we are committed to some majoritarian, modernizing ethical philosophy applied to politics, we should be expanding the franchise in this particular direction as well.
- 5.90** So, to wrap up, in terms of essential concepts as potential takeaways, pleasure is the fundamental good; by contrast, pain is the fundamental bad. That's the factual scientific basis, arguing that human beings, given their nature as physical and psychological beings, have both lower and higher pleasures. They're both in each category. There are lower and higher physical pleasures, lower and higher psychological pleasures. So we need to have a well-worked-out science of psychology, a well-worked-out science of physiology, in order to have that work with our well-worked-out moral philosophy.
- 5.91** That we are interested in what's useful, its utility, what's practically successful at maximizing pleasure, minimizing pain. The standard is, I'm going to call it majoritarian, the greatest happiness for the greatest number. There's an important last chapter in the book that we are not going to cover here, but he wants to say that justice and various other moral standards are important, but it's not a different thing than pleasure and pain, or different thing from usefulness, but rather, ultimately, justice is a matter of our recognizing things that seem, most of the time and in most circumstances, to achieve the greatest happiness for the greatest of numbers. We adopt those as more

firm principles of social interaction, but we don't then say that somehow they come from some non-scientific unknown source. Let's stop there.

Lecture 6: Nietzsche

At a glance — Nietzsche.

- 6.1 1844. To start with this individual, younger Charles Darwin, back from his epic five-year journey around the world. And in 1844, for years of further reflection, still a relatively young man, he wrote what was to be the first overall sketch of his theory of evolution. Now, he didn't publish it in 1844. He was rather shy, didn't like controversy, didn't like all of the nastiness that comes with being a public figure enunciating a controversial doctrine, so he basically sat upon it.
- 6.2 But the themes of a struggle for existence and extinction, life and death, and some species and members of a species being better suited to their environment and the competition for resources and mates, all of this is put together, added to the millions and perhaps billions of years of time that modern science and geology had given, came together in a first draft of the theory of evolution, Darwin's version.
- 6.3 Also in 1844, the battle against slavery is in full swing. Many anti-slavery societies had been founded toward the end of the 1700s at the height of the Enlightenment. They are starting to do great reeducation, moral campaigns, social campaigns, political campaigns. By the time we get to 1844, the British navy, as the most powerful navy on the planet, is devoting significant resources to stopping the slave trade in and out of Africa.
- 6.4 There's a striking phrase I've extracted here from a manual that was issued to all officers involved. It had this line here. "The slave trade has been denounced by all the civilized world as repugnant to every principle of justice and humanity." So evolutionary ideas in the air and Darwin's theory, shortly to be published, the slave trade, the modern world is, again, in full swing.
- 6.5 Also in 1844, our principal subject of this session, Friedrich Nietzsche, is born in Germany. By all accounts, just a genius, a brilliant student, precocious, fascinated by languages, particularly ancient languages, became a master of many ancient cultures, especially loving the Greeks and the Romans. Went off to university and, something that was almost unheard of before he even finished his doctoral degree, his PhD degree, was appointed professor at a university in Switzerland. And given the intense competition for professor positions in Germany and Switzerland and more broadly in Europe, the fact that at a relatively young age in his early 20s, without the PhD degree in hand, he got this professorship is an indication of the great esteem he was held in by his own professors and to-be colleagues.
- 6.6 In 1872, he published his first major work, and this is a work that is still widely read, more by classicists and people interested in philosophy of literature and philosophy of art, because what we have is Nietzsche, reflecting on and philosophizing about the fact that the Greeks wrote amazing tragedies, profound works of art. Out of all of the

cultures in the world, why this literature was developed in this seemingly small, isolated culture in one part of the world, and that what was articulated in those novels is still speaking to us over 2,000 years later—what is going on?

- 6.7** He has a brilliant, although unconventional, interpretation of Greek tragedy that is wrapped up in an understanding of not only Greek philosophy, but also philosophy in general. The subtitle is out of the spirit of music. There's an interesting connection to Schopenhauer, whom Nietzsche read avidly and saw as one of his great mentors, someone whom he thought he had to overcome and surpass. But nonetheless, this theme, that there is something fundamental, metaphysically fundamental, about music speaking to us, and that in literary form, the tragic form of art does.
- 6.8** Now, I want to draw a few things from an essay that Nietzsche originally wrote. It's called *The Greek State*. He originally wrote it to publish it as part of the *Birth of Tragedy*. It's a complete essay. He was ready to send it off to the printers. But toward the end of the editing process, he decided to take *The Greek State* out. The reason for that is that it is more political in its focus, rather. What he wanted to do was make sure that the *Birth of Tragedy* remained essentially focused on literature, art, tragedy, music, and we'll save the politics for another time. But nonetheless, the political lessons, it's all interconnected, the politics and the philosophy and the art and the music and the religion and so forth. I want to draw on a few themes from *The Greek State*.
- 6.9** Now, Nietzsche was largely disdainful of the efforts of moral philosophers up to his generation. Suppose we take a perfunctory survey of what moral philosophy has developed, boiling it down to some essentialized formulas. We'll add, of course, a little sarcasm here to try to get into the Nietzschean swing of things. What is it to be a moral person? Well, be a good boy, be a good girl, and do your duty. Be obedient. How does that sound? Be selfless. Think less of yourself. Think of yourself as less important, and think about yourself less. Denigrate yourself, put yourself down. You're lesser. How does that sound?
- 6.10** Live for others. Others are more important than you are. Of course, we'll try to convince them that all the other others are more important than they are. But everybody's more important than everybody else. Everyone is equal. Merge yourself with a collective. Stop trying to be so individualistic. Be part of this bigger collective thing. Greatest happiness for the greatest number. We're familiar with these formulas. And Nietzsche's reaction is, are you kidding me? What person with an ounce of self-respect is going to fall for any of those moral slogans? The greatest happiness for the greatest number? I mean, have you met the greatest number? Have you seen these people? Just go to the mall or go stand on the street and watch the greatest number of people go by. Their happiness, that's what I'm supposed to be living for?
- 6.11** The collective. Everyone is equal? Come on. Pretty much every dimension. Some people are much better, some people are much worse. Equality? What kind of myth is that?

Live for others? I'm supposed to think of other people's lives as more important than my own? I'm less than other people? There's a bunch of duties that somebody has decided on, and they're going to impose them on me, and I'm just supposed to be an obedient, willless person doing what other people have decided for me? Where's your dignity? Where's your self-respect? Don't fall for any of that. That's Nietzsche's first emotionalist reaction to the history of moral philosophy.

- 6.12** What he then asks us is to say, look at history and look at the people who've actually done something important, something significant, something innovative, something that has elevated human beings beyond what they were, back when we were cave dwellers, nomadic hunters with short, brutal lives, et cetera, et cetera, the long march of history. The great works of art. There are great works of art, ones that are awesome, amazing, astounding. Where did they come from, and what kind of people made those kinds of works of art?
- 6.13** "The origin of the great works of art," this is from *The Greek State* now, "that through them a higher form of existence is inaugurated." We respond to certain sorts of art. Not only do they astound us, but they make us stand up a little straighter and realize greater and fuller possibilities and instill in us more energy to be better and to strive in a certain direction. What kind of people made those works of art? The average? The collective? Did we form some sort of greatest happiness for the greatest number collective committee and say, "Let's make a great work of art?" No, it's not how it happened.
- 6.14** Now, we can talk about art, literature, music. In other domains, when we read history, who has inspired human beings, "In the highest castes, one perceives already a little more of what in this internal process is involved at the bottom, namely the creation of the military genius." There have been military geniuses across history, and we all know their names, Alexander the Great, Julius Caesar, Napoleon. They inspire us, maybe inspire us with horror and terror, but nonetheless, we read their stories and we start to realize greater what the possibilities are.
- 6.15** We create the Macedonian Empire, the Roman Empire. We come this close to controlling all of Europe and the Middle East and North Africa. What ambition. We all want to read the story of Napoleon and Julius Caesar, rather than this guy who spent his life harvesting rye wheat in eastern Prussia and died. Alexander the Great, here are the names, Julius Caesar, Michelangelo, Beethoven, Napoleon. What kind of men, in this case, all of them, were they? Were they selfless? "My creative vision, my ambition, matters less than what other people want."
- 6.16** Did they say, "We need to come together in some sort of collective decision-making body and create a new symphony"? Can you imagine Beethoven being part of a committee? Nietzsche's point is going to be, everything that is great in human existence, that has elevated us, has been the work of individuals who are not, quote, unquote, "moral" according to the standards of morality that say, "Be selfless, merge

with the collective, put the greatest happiness of the greatest number before your own, do your duty and be a good boy and girl." They were the opposite of that.

- 6.17** Now, the Greeks, and why Nietzsche is so fascinated with the Greeks, is partly because they are pre-Christian. One of Nietzsche's theses is that Christianity has been a seductive poison of a moral code that has weakened us over the course of the century. If we go back before the time of Christianity and we look at the cultures that actually accomplish something significant, like the Greeks, we can learn certain moral lessons.
- 6.18** One of the lessons we learned from the Greeks, when they rose up and conquered whom they wanted, "The Greeks, in their instinct, never ceased to utter out of a brazen mouth such words as, 'To the victor belongs the vanquished, with wife and child, life and property. Power gives the first right. There is no right, which is at bottom not presumption, usurpation, violence.'" Now, I've got highlighted the word "power is the first right."
- 6.19** What makes something right? The capacity to make it happen. Power. Someone has some sort of power. It might be artistic creative power, literary genius, military genius, scientific genius, some way of getting their act together in some domain or other, typically far above what most people are capable of doing. They have the power. They make it happen. They make it right. Given the nature of the world, we live in a rough world. At bottom, it takes violence against people with different power agendas and people who don't want to follow along your power agenda. You have to make them do it.
- 6.20** What this then means is, if there are such people who are great and some people who are average and some people who are basically just there to play a supporting role in culture, change the bedsheets, milk the cows, drive the carts—they have no agenda, they have no creativity, they have no special power—but in large masses, they can get the basic work of culture done, so that the people who can actually get the greatest things done can do their work. And so Nietzsche, in this essay, *The Greek State* makes the conclusion.
- 6.21** "Accordingly, we must accept this cruel-sounding truth," and this is a cruel-sounding truth only to modern ears, now that we are sensitized to these notions of the rights of humans, et cetera, et cetera, that everybody should a chance, et cetera, "slavery is of the essence of culture." So all this anti-slavery, to make everybody free, everybody should be treated equally—for Nietzsche, this is a retrograde notion. It's going to weaken the human condition.
- 6.22** Now, this reference to slavery and an endorsement of the slavery that was part of Greek culture, Roman culture, pretty much every culture known to human history, is the first mention in Nietzsche's published writings of what comes to be his most famous doctrine of morality. The contrast between what he calls master morality, the morality of the kind of people who can not only master themselves, really become the

master of themselves, get their act together and make their vision happen, but also, when necessary, master other people, get them on board, nicely or not so nicely, to use them to make their agenda happen.

- 6.23** In contrast to people, to put it bluntly, who really are just fit for being slaves or something close to slave. They don't have their own agenda. They don't necessarily have their act together. By themselves and left to their own devices, they would lead a relatively insignificant life and not accomplish very much. But if they are organized correctly, by the right people, something in a supporting role can come out of them.
- 6.24** This is where we make a connection to Darwin and evolutionary theory because one of the themes that comes out of a study of biology is the distinction between those who survive and those who don't survive. Those who survive typically don't survive by being nice guys in the animal world. They survive by having an agenda, by being aggressive, by having as much power as they possibly can to get the best mates, to get the best food, when necessary to kill, to take the energy of the species or the animal that you killed, its power, so to speak, and incorporate it into yourself so you can carry on. That's the life of animals.
- 6.25** There's a natural biological distinction between predator species that have evolved this kind of strategy and prey species. Typically, prey types of species, if we think about cows or deer or rabbits or sheep, they're not particularly aggressive. They like to stay together in large numbers in the herd for safety. They don't ever strike off on their own and do their own thing. They're typically scared of all of the predator animals out there, and they really would like everybody to be more like sheep and so forth. We give this description of what it is to be a prey kind of animal.
- 6.26** The predator types are obviously aggressive, powerful. They have sharp talons, sharp teeth, big muscles. They are fast. They are aggressive. When a predator kills a prey animal, it doesn't feel sorry for it. Oh, poor rabbit. No, they enjoyed their meal and so forth. What we have biologically are species that have followed different evolutionary strategies, some adopting a lifestyle that's more prey-like and some adopting a lifestyle that is more predator-like. And Nietzsche wants to map that onto the human type, to say that some of us, so there's going to be a spectrum here among human beings, have evolved to be more like sheep, to put it bluntly.
- 6.27** We're scared of the world, not particularly bright. Like to hang out with other sheep, content to just have a nice patch of grass to chew and a warm place to sleep at night. Once in a while, maybe I have a sexual urge, so I'll make some more baby sheep, and they will just carry on doing the same thing. There are humans for whom that seems to map onto their psycho-biological type, and that's a large number of them. But also are humans who are born with energy, with purpose, with assertiveness. You can never tell those little kids, even from day one, what they are supposed to do and make them share their toys with other people and not do what they are going to do of their own sort.

- 6.28** Naturally, according to their bio-psychological type, they are more self-masters, and they are going to be masters of their own fate. We can array human beings along that agenda and then argue that human beings since we are rational, we tend to rationalize whatever feels natural to us. There are some people who want to be part of the herd, they want to be part of the crowd, they want a nice, safe, comfortable life, and to be secure and have everything provided for them. They're going to generate a moral code that valorizes that kind of a lifestyle. They're going to say, "Oh, anybody who stands out from the crowd, anybody who is dangerous to us, that's a bad person."
- 6.29** But then, by contrast, people who are more the master type, they also are going to generate a moral code that rationalizes the kind of being that they are. They will valorize ambition and recklessness and power and dominance, and that feels natural to them. What we have then in human history is a battle of moral codes, but really it's a battle of psychological and biological types because human beings are not all the same. It's not the case that we pre-discovered morality out there written in stone, or that there are some institutions that just came up with the right answers that they're supposed to legislate for all of us instead. Morality is this subjective projection based on instinctually evolved psycho-biological types. Nietzsche's name for those is the master and slave type.
- 6.30** Now, perhaps his most famous or notorious work is now jumping into the next decade. We're going to plunge into the text a little here, is a book called Beyond Good and Evil. It's a provocative title because once we have here is the phrase good and evil. We're used to this language. Some things are good, some things are bad, but the really bad things, those are evil. Some moral codes are really obsessed with identifying the evil, the evil that might be inside of us or the evil that is out there in society, and valorizing a certain conception of the good. From Nietzsche's perspective, it's primarily going to be a Judeo-Christian religious tradition that has been the dominant moral tradition.
- 6.31** That's the tradition where we find this language of, there's the absolute good that we find in God, and there's the absolute evil that we find in humanity, and perhaps all of the story of humanity and our ultimate destiny is this great struggle between the forces of good and the forces of evil, and it's a big drama that's ultimately going to resolve itself. It's a very exciting story because we all like polarized good versus evil stories. But Nietzsche's theme, as he is suggesting here, is that we need to get beyond that in some way. Whatever we take good and evil to be, get past it. There's something not quite right here.
- 6.32** Let's go to the text a little bit and read Nietzsche in his own words from Beyond Good and Evil. I want to say a few things about the rhetorical style of this work. We've seen dialogues, we've seen fictional creations who are embedded in narrative, we've seen various sorts of essays and treatises and so on. Nietzsche is famous for writing in aphoristic style. This is a self-consciously chosen style where you will write sometimes just one sentence and then break and write then another sentence that's not even

necessarily directly related to the first sentence. You collect all of these aphorisms or short sentences. Sometimes you'll elaborate on them for a few paragraphs.

6.33 But the idea is that we're not trying to be, quote, "scientific" in the sense of saying, we start from this fact and this fact, and we put them together in this logical, organized fact, and here's my overall structure of a moral theory. We're not trying to be mathematical philosophers and say, "Here are my axioms and I deduce this theorem, and here are some corollaries over here." Rather, what Nietzsche wants us to do is to take each of these aphorisms, some of which are underexplained, and become, ourselves, philosophers. And say, Nietzsche is not going to necessarily explain what this means. What do I think this means? How could I interpret this? How does this fit with that aphorism? I remember we read that one several pages changes earlier, to start making our own connections.

6.34 The philosophy, in this sense, is a do-it-yourself enterprise, not to be spoon-fed by someone who knows better than you. And now here's your next lesson, and here's your next lesson, and so forth. So deliberately short, underinterpreted, not necessarily in a logical order, so that you become stronger in your own mind. You master the material. You stop being a student, being lectured at by a professor, and become a masterful, powerful thinker in your own right. That's the rhetorical style that, for the most part, Nietzsche adopts in most of his major work. It's not exclusively; he does experiment with some other styles. Let's start here.

6.35 Provocative phrase in the preface. "Christianity is Platonism for the people." For students or otherwise read people who know something about Plato, Plato is almost always an insult for Nietzsche, the philosopher who, as he said, was a coward about facing reality as it was. Plato wants to say, "This world is so ugly and brutal and messy. I want to believe that there's a higher world of all of these perfect forms and spend my time in this ideal world."

6.36 But Plato was a philosophical genius, and so he came up with what we can now call an idealistic, otherworldly, perfect philosophy. The argument here is that, basically, Plato is for the philosopher, and Christianity is for the common people. It's the same philosophy, but it's a cowardly, otherworldly philosophy. It's not willing to look at the world as it actually is, in all of its sometimes ugliness and brutality.

6.37 A point about subjectivity. This is now moving on to part one. You can see this is section six, so I'm going to be jumping around even within Nietzsche's jumping around. "Gradually, it has become clear to me what every great philosophy so far has been; namely, the personal confession of its author and a kind of involuntary and unconscious memoir." This is Nietzsche signaling that he is not in any sense an objectivist or an intrinsicist. Philosophers for millennia have said, "My job is, and my quest is, to come to know the truth that is out there. But I'm not going to be subjective and just import my own ideas, my own values, my own goals. I might even set myself

aside because the goal is to come to know reality as it really is. And so I'm going to be objective."

- 6.38** Nietzsche is of the generation after Kant, two generations after Kant, that says that is an impossible project. And what we have to start realizing is that what we are doing when we are thinking is not recognizing what's out there and trying to come up with an objective portrait of it, but rather we are creative beings ourselves, and that we are a certain kind of person, and we are not that much different from artists or other kinds of creative people. What we are doing in our philosophy is articulating and systematizing something inside us, something that's important to us. This is how I look at the world. This is what I think is important, not the world is going to tell me what's true and what is important.
- 6.39** We should start reading philosophers as autobiographers, not as allegedly impartial or objective, scientific, fact-oriented types of people. That then means that what you should do anytime you are reading a philosopher is not ask, is what this guy saying is true? The question you should ask is, what kind of person would say this? What kind of guy would want this to be true? You start reading the philosophy as a psychological portrait of the author, not as an allegedly characterization of the way reality is.
- 6.40** "In the philosopher, conversely, there is nothing whatever that is impersonal." Philosophy is intensely personal. It's all about your person. "And above all, his morality bears decided and decisive witness to who he is." If you have a philosopher who says selfless, selfless, selfless, what does that guy think about himself? What is he trying to get himself to be? He wants to think less of himself. I want to merge with the collective. What kind of person wants to merge with the collective? Erase all individuality. That's someone who has no individuality or doesn't like his individuality.
- 6.41** I want to live for others. The person has no personal reason to live, no personal goals, dreams, aspirations? Tell me what I should do with my life, you others. I will live for you. What kind of person would do that? But this is an ancient story. We're jumping from aphorism 6 to aphorism 9 because Nietzsche has gone on to talk about some other related things, but he comes back to this point. It, that is to say philosophy, "always creates the world in its own image." It's not that what's my philosophy inside my head is an image or a reflection of what's out there. Rather, the order of creation goes the other way. My philosophy creates the world in my image.
- 6.42** Then what is behind all of that? If we think of Schopenhauer with his emphasis on the will over reason, "Philosophy is this tyrannical drive itself, the most spiritual will to power." It's a will. Whereas in Schopenhauer's case, the will was rather chaotic and irrational. For Nietzsche, every person's will has some sort of direction, something that it wants to strive to achieve. It wants to exert power in order to achieve that drive. "A living thing," jumping to number 13, "seeks above all to discharge its strength. Life itself is will to power." Everything ultimately reduces to centers of will that are inside each of

us that want to externalize themselves and to acquire as much power as possible to make their will real out there in the world.

- 6.43** Another important thesis, Nietzsche does not believe in free will. He wants to argue, what kind of a being you are, whether you're more slave psychology-like, whether more master psychology-like, you come out of a long line of evolution, and your psychological aspirations are more or less set by whatever kind of line you come out of, and you cannot change that through any sort of act of will. You can't ask a rabbit not to act like a rabbit and feel like a rabbit and think like a rabbit. You can't ask a wolf not to want to do what wolves want to do. You can't take a wolf and a rabbit and say, play together and be friends. That's just not natural. They are what they are.
- 6.44** The same thing in more complicated form in human beings. The only difference is that, among human beings, some of these wills are strong and some of them are weak. "In real life, it is a matter of strong wills and weak wills." Some people are just weak. Some people are strong. Some people might have a whole bunch of different wills, different things that they want to do, but they can never quite get it together and have some dominating will. This is what I'm going to do in my life. And so they flit along and diverge their energy amongst a whole bunch of different things.
- 6.45** Other people have a will, a unified will, a strong will, and they go out and make it happen. That's just the way it is. Now we get the suggestion toward the end of part one, "Psychology is now, again, the path to fundamental problems." We want to figure out what is really important about the human being. It's not going to be sociology, it's not anthropology, it's not religion, it is psychology. This is the new mother science that all philosophy will be based upon.
- 6.46** "One must shed the bad taste of wanting to agree with many. 'Good' is no longer good when one's neighbor mouths it. And how should there be a common good?" Going after this very common phrase, the idea that there should be some sort of universal morality, a common good, some one thing that all of us should be striving for, that we should all be agreeing with. Of course, if we're going to call it the common good, then it has to be pretty common, nothing special if it's going to fit the common run of people.
- 6.47** Nietzsche is going to suggest, no. All genuine goods are, in fact, uncommon. They are special. They are unique. The common good, as he puts it here, "The term contradicts itself. Great things remain for the great, abysses for the profound, nuances and shudders for the refined, and in brief, all that is rare for the rare." There are special, awesome, wonderful, unique things, but they're not for everyone. In fact, most people are not going to be able to get to them. That's just the way it is.
- 6.48** Now we start to think about all of these modern doctrines, the "equality of rights." Really, Nietzsche says, do we think that everyone is equally deserving, equally worthy? We're going to do politics and make important decisions about international affairs? Should we go to war with this country or that country? We want to say, everybody

should have a say in this. Have you ever actually tried to do that? You go and talk to people, they don't even know where that country is. They don't know anything about its history or its religion, what the issues are. Oh, but they should have an equal vote.

- 6.49** What moron would give an equal vote to the vast majority of people who are completely uninformed? What policies are you going to get from completely uninformed people? Uninformed stupid policies that lead to self-destruction. How many people actually know what is going on, care about it, and are in a position to do something? Again, that is a few, few people. "Sympathy for all that suffers." We should be compassionate. How many times have we heard this phrase? We should feel pity for those who are suffering. We should dedicate our lives to alleviating the suffering of the many.
- 6.50** Life is suffering. It's a huge amount of suffering. It's pain, injury, death. That's the thing that makes life go on. Predator eat. First, they kill the prey, and they don't say, oh, I pity your suffering. It's a weakening to make that. "Where and how the plant 'man' has so far grown most vigorously to a height, we think that this happened every time under the opposite conditions," where we said people are unequal and we respect the inequality of human beings, and those who are at the top, who have whatever power we're talking about, artistic power, intellectual power, political power, etc, they do what they want with the rest to make certain things happen. Out of that, great literature happens, great politics happens, mankind advances.
- 6.51** Never has mankind made a single advance by feeling sorry for everybody and treating everybody equally. It's always the opposite. "We think that hardness, forcefulness, slavery, danger in the alley and the heart, life in hiding, stoicism, the art of experimenting and devilry of every kind, everything evil, terrible, tyrannical in man, everything in him that is kin to beasts of prey and serpents, serves the enhancement of the species 'man' as much as its opposite does."
- 6.52** Now, we could say, yes, we want to make human beings a nice big nation of sheep, or we can make a nice nation of eagles and cultivate as many eagles and wolves as we possibly can. That's the choice that we are faced with. About Christianity in particular. "The Christian faith is a sacrifice." Nietzsche uses the concept of sacrifice in its rigorous philosophical sense, a net loss for the person. "A sacrifice of all freedom, all pride, all self-confidence of the spirit." What do we mean, a sacrifice of all freedom? Obedience. First thing you must learn is, be obedient to higher authority. You are not a free agent.
- 6.53** Of course, that might mean obedience to God in your formal theology, but really it means obedience to God's representatives on earth, whatever religious institution that you are talking about. They're going to make rules, you are going to obey those rules, you will do their will. From Nietzsche's perspective, this is really just a power play. They're using the religion as a tool of controlling you so they can achieve their ends.

- 6.54 Pride. Well, "I'm pretty amazing. I'm pretty great." You're not supposed to say that. You're not supposed to think that. You're supposed to say, "Oh, I'm nothing special. I'm modest," or even more, "I'm humble. When I'm in the presence of my religion, I go down on my knees or I prostrate myself. That's to show how lowly I am. I'm just like a worm on society," the opposite of pride. "All self-confidence of the spirit; at the same time, enslavement and self-mockery, self-mutilation." So harsh words for the strongest forms of the Christian religion, as they have come down, as Nietzsche sees them.
- 6.55 "To ordinary human beings, though, finally—the vast majority who exist for service in a general advantage, religion gives them an inestimable contentment with their situation and type." What Nietzsche is doing, saying here is that religion is a consolation prize for people who know that their lives are not going to amount to much, that they really are nothing special. They don't really have some great agenda, something that they really want to do with their lives. In their heart of hearts, they think of themselves as just ordinary, and that's OK.
- 6.56 I want a religion that tells me it's OK be ordinary, or I think of myself as a loser, as a failure. But I want someone who nonetheless is still going to accept me and maybe give me some nice things, not in this life, but maybe in some next life. That makes me feel a little better about my life in the here and now. This way, it sounds pathetic, and that's Nietzsche's point.
- 6.57 "A people—" Why do we have societies? Not for the general advancement, not for the greatest happiness of the greatest number. "A people is a detour of nature to get six or seven great men." It's the one in a million, the one in 10 million. That's what we're going for. There will be 10 million people who have zero artistic creativity. They will be the farmers, they will be the cart drivers, they will cook the food, clean the houses. There will be one in 10,000 that have some artistic capacity, some vision, some energy that they will dedicate their lives to being artists.
- 6.58 Out of that one of 10,000, 999, whatever my numbers are now, will be average or terrible as artists. But out of that, there will be one Michelangelo. That justifies the whole lot. In sports, the one great athlete. In science, the genius scientist. In every domain, those are the ones who make it possible for us to respect what it is to be a human being and who thereby elevate the entire species. Those are the ones we should be valorizing.
- 6.59 "To our strongest drive, the tyrant in us, not only our reason bows but also our conscience." Coming back to a psychological point now, people who have good self-knowledge, develop their introspective skills to find out who they really are. What do I really want? Will find something in them. This is the strongest drive that I have. I need to be authentic to it, true to it, whatever language we want to use, to make that happen. I will bend everything to make that happen. I will rationalize it. My reason will bend to it. I will bend my moral code in order to make it happen. It will be a tyrant. That's what makes things happen.

- 6.60 If we think about military conquerors. I want to conquer whatever. I really want it. That's my strongest drive. I will get my act together. I will acquire a position of power where this is possible. But I will use all sorts of rationalization and, in many cases, outright lies and propaganda as part of the tools in order to enable me to achieve my great ambition. Anytime I have to do something that seems morally terrible, I will find some way to bend the rules of morality to say it's necessary in this case; the end justifies the means in order to make that happen. That's how all of the good and really great things in life happens.
- 6.61 Morality has been largely accepted as a given by the time we get into the modern world. In many cases in the modern world, as we got more rational, instead of just saying we're going to accept this moral code on faith or because it's a matter of tradition, that now that we are modern and more rational, we need to make an argument for it. For the last couple of hundred years, that's what philosophers have been trying to do, John Locke, Immanuel Kant, and various others. And so what Nietzsche is arguing is that they are taking a certain moral code as the given and just trying to find clever ways to prop it up.
- 6.62 Nietzsche wants to say, if we're going to be philosophical about this, you have to recognize that there are, in fact, many moralities. This is one of the things that he thinks the history of morality teaches us. We start studying different cultures and we start to realize how few, if any, things are common to all moral codes across all time. So the real, I would—rather, to say, they never laid eyes on "the real problems of morality, for these emerge only when we compare many moralities."
- 6.63 Now, here we come back to an endorsement of slavery again. This is now 15 years after The Greek State. "Slavery is, as it seems, both in the cruder and in the more subtle sense, the indispensable means of spiritual discipline and cultivation, too." What we mean in this case is, Nietzsche is saying that, look, what we've tried to do in the modern world is get away from the notion that slavery is appropriate. We start talking about liberty and equality, et cetera, et cetera. But again, learning from history, what we realize is that all of the cultures that have created great things have been cultures based on slavery.
- 6.64 The ancient Arabic cultures, the ancient Samurai culture, the ancient Hindu culture with its caste system. Europe originally was shot through with slavery. The Greeks, the Romans, everybody used slavery, and that is the great lesson of history. It's the indispensable way of making the best possible. Now, we might start to think that Nietzsche is an individualistic thinker, and there is an issue of controversy in Nietzsche's scholarship and interpretation about all of this because it sounds like what he is doing is saying, great human beings have their own individual agendas, and it's justified for them not to sacrifice themselves for others, but rather to sacrifice those others for themselves to achieve their own individualistic ends.

- 6.65 What Nietzsche wants to do is say, we have to take biology seriously. So his readings of Darwin and the other theories that say that morality and human life, just like all of animal life, does not operate at the individual level. It operates at the species level. What we are trying to do is not, and I'm starting to slip to the we language, what we are trying to do is not say to individuals, be the best that you can be and hope that some of you will lead a special life in some way. What we are trying to do is improve the species.
- 6.66 The species is part of an evolutionary process, and it's going to be certain special individuals who will do certain, sometimes brutal, but often creative things, and that might be good for them, maybe not. But the important thing is that they improve the human condition as a whole. It's the species. It's some sort of collective, not that you as an individual are an end in yourself. The way he puts it, this is in this section here, "Nature's moral imperative is not addressed to the individual."
- 6.67 It doesn't care about the individual wolf or the individual sheep. Instead, what it wants is for this wolf to try to be a little faster so that that wolf can pass on its fastness to the next generation, and then wolves as a species will be a little faster. It wants this antelope, say, to develop—and we're going to stick with speed here—slightly quicker reactions. That might be good for this antelope, so it can evade the cheetah a little faster. But the more important point is, we want to make antelopes as a species a little quicker in reaction and improve the species that way. That's what we are striving for.
- 6.68 We are human beings, and Nietzsche's big phrase is that we want to get beyond human beings as they are now to something over man. The over man, sometimes translated as the superman. We want to make human beings better. "The highest and strongest drives, when they break out passionately and drive the individual far above the average and the flats of the herd conscience, wreck the self-confidence of the community, its faith in itself," and so forth. "Morality in Europe today is the herd animal morality." This is the big problem that Nietzsche is trying to diagnose in the middle part of the 18th century.
- 6.69 He has a view about what has made human beings worthy of respect so far, the certain special artists and scientists and military conquerors and so on. Rather than learning from the lesson of history, what we have been doing is starting to valorize various kinds of moral codes that are going to undercut that possibility. Moral codes that tell us to be more like sheep, more like herd animals, to try to strive for real equality and merging with various collectives and so forth. That is the big problem.
- 6.70 So if you think, for example, about democracy, as he identifies here, rather than saying politics is only for certain special individuals who are smart enough and are able to play the grand game of international politics, we want everybody to play the game. That's going to make us worse at the game. Do we want to say everybody in sports competitions is going to get a trophy, to use another slightly anachronistic example? We're going to undercut the idea that there are special athletes and that there are

some performances that are worthy of special honors. If you evaluate and honor everybody, then that takes away all honors.

6.71 If you think we should be more socialistic or communistic, that is to say, everybody's supposed to work at assigned jobs and everything is going to go into a common pot and everything is going to be shared out equally by a hopefully benevolent government who's controlling all of these things, well, what you are then going to do is consign the greatest among us to working at jobs not of their own choosing, and they are just going to be supporting people and devoting all of their energies toward people who are not ones who have anything special to offer human beings. So democracy, the idea of equality of rights, socialism, communism.

6.72 Nietzsche is also obviously concerned with the religious revivalism that's going on. Kierkegaard, we spent a little bit of time with him in an earlier lecture. But again, the idea that what I want to do is sacrifice myself to higher authority and do its will, and that everybody should be selfless and sacrificing and so forth—he sees that religious revivalism as another part of the great problem. What we need, though, is people who are unafraid of being tyrants and first and foremost, being tyrants with themselves, to say, look, I am special, and I have something special in me, and I am going to set aside all distractions, all of those moralities that want to weaken me, and empower myself, and make myself into the kind of person who can actually make something special happen.

6.73 Then socially, if that means I have to be rude and impolite and sometimes coercive with respect to you, tough. That's life. This is the hope for mankind. And this then is going to involve philosophers who are trying to legislate the morality that is going to elevate human beings to the next level. They have to play their part as well. "Genuine philosophers, however, are commanders and legislators. They say, 'Thus it shall be!' Their knowing is creating, their creating is a legislation, their will to truth is will to power." We also need philosophers who are willing to step up and valorize and justify the kind of morality that's going to make it possible for human beings to do so.

6.74 What about self-interest? We've had a number of philosophers beating up on self-interest and egoism. Nietzsche's argument is going to be, well, there's a relativism here. Self-interest is good if you have a self that's worthy of some respect. If you're mostly a non-entity, ordinary kind of self-person, well, I don't particularly want you to be selfish and egoistic. If you exist for service, then don't try to impose your own agenda.

6.75 "I honor and exalt a man free of self-interest if he's the sort of people who should not be advancing his own self-interest. The question," the right question as he puts it here, "is always who he is and who the other person is. In a person, for example, who is called and made to command, self-denial, modest self-effacement would not be a virtue, but a waste of virtue." So take two people. Take Michelangelo and take a not particularly bright person who, at their highest level of confidence, can keep Michelangelo's apartment clean and clean up in the studio after he is done.

- 6.76 Do we want to say morality should be the same for both of those two people? Do we want to say that Michelangelo should be a little more self-effacing, that he should count his interests and this other person's interests equal? No, what we want is for Michelangelo to be the most ruthless, egotistical person he possibly can be. We want this other person to be as invisible, as self-effacing, and to play his role, as not as egoistic as he possibly can be. Different moralities for different kinds of people.
- 6.77 All right, I can't resist one more thing before we switch over here. Nietzsche is one of the best name-callers in all of human history. Plato was a coward. Kant was a spider, a catastrophic spider, because he was spinning all of these webs here. He was well aware of the utilitarian philosophers, Bentham and John Stuart Mill and so forth. His confession is, when he reads them, "Oh, they're so boring. Boring." Then his explanation is, "Well, your philosophy is an expression of who you are. If you're a boring writer, you're a boring person. The utilitarians, they are simply old, cold, and tedious frogs." Over there in the murky, swampy area, and they're not going to really do very much. But that's from another book, so that's a bit of an interloper.
- 6.78 Now, to conclude, though, what our project should be is not liberal, not individualistic, not egalitarian, not socialistic, communistic, not sociocracy, not trying to cultivate the oneness of being that the Eastern religions have incurred in us. Instead, what we want is "the cultivation of a new caste that will rule Europe," a caste of special people who have the will to power and an agenda to make it happen. That's the hope for the future. A historical point, "Every enhancement of the type 'man' so far has been the work of an aristocratic society—and will be so again and again—a society that believes in the long order of rank and differences in value between man and man, and that needs slavery in some sense or other."
- 6.79 We had a taste of The Greek State in the 1870s, now Beyond Good and Evil in the middle part of the 1880s. Nietzsche was working toward the end of his working life on what he considered to be his greatest work. He had it all written out, and he was trying different arrangements and reorganizing things. He was never quite satisfied with the organization before he became dysfunctional. This is an unpublished manuscript, but it was later published, initially in an abridged form, but now there are full scholarly editions that are available to us. This work is called The Will to Power.
- 6.80 Now, The Will to Power is a phrase that we've come across already several times. It's old territory, that now. But I'm flagging this just to say that, for scholarly purposes, Nietzsche did not pull the trigger, so to speak, and actually publish this work, although he was very close to doing so. So take that into account anytime you cite it or read it. Now, what's interesting, I just want to pull out one passage in closing, that what Nietzsche has suggested in The Will to Power, it's a big, long, fat book divided into, at least at the time he became dysfunctional, four major parts.
- 6.81 He works through his metaphysics, his epistemology, his understanding of human nature, his value theory, and so on, is toward the end to suggest something that's a

little original, that is thought might be evolving in a certain direction, that for all of his career, he has polarized human beings into master types and slave types. I suggested that the slave types are unworthy of perhaps even the label of being human. They're a bit of a disgrace to human beings, particularly those that accept that they ought to be more slavish in their morality and how they live, and valorizing the master types, those who have the power agenda and a willingness to do whatever it possibly takes.

- 6.82** He has, over the course of doing his historical analysis, wanted to say, when we look at historical cases, we see the Judeo-Christian tradition, and it's all been about humility and hoping that the meek will inherit the earth and hoping that God will save them and being humble, et cetera. That's a morality that is a rationalization of a certain kind of slave type. Then by contrast, we can look at the Greeks, we can look at the Romans that rose up and imposed their will and created a mighty empire and made no bones about the fact that they had power and they were using the power for their own advantage at the expense of others.
- 6.83** What we find interestingly, toward the end of *The Will to Power*, is a dialectical suggestion in Nietzsche that maybe in the grand sweep of human history, in the grand sweep of human evolutionary development, we should not see the master types and slave types aligned along, say, a spectrum and human beings occupy various places along that spectrum; that maybe we shouldn't polarize them into opposite types and see only one as containing the potential for the human future, while the others are a bit of a disgrace and just baggage or along for the ride or existing for support.
- 6.84** Because he's struck by the character of Jesus Christ as a historical figure, someone who absorbed the Jewish tradition and internalized it. We can take another philosophical dichotomy and divide human beings into more physical types and those into more psychological types, or more into more body types versus more mind types. That what has happened in much of human history has been a struggle materialistically with respect to military power for ascendancy. We can recognize certain human developments and great things that have accomplished on that side of the equation.
- 6.85** But maybe we have to be open to the idea that the religious traditions have been focused on a different kind of human development, a more internal, psychological, spiritual discipline. If we think about the kind of discipline that it takes to become Julius Caesar, we can understand that. But if you think about the discipline it takes to become a Jesus Christ, or as close as you possibly can, that they might be two different kinds of disciplines speaking to different parts of the human being as a whole—again, this is a suggestion where Nietzsche says, maybe the next development of human beings will be the kind of people who can integrate both.
- 6.86** He has this formulation, The overman will be a "Caesar, but with the soul of Christ." We integrate what seem to be two opposites, and that's what the dialectical concept is supposed to capture in this case here. I've given you the citation there. It's in section 983, so you can, at your leisure, read that one and its context. To wrap up in

conclusion, these are my extraction of some key concepts that we should take from Nietzsche. That biology is, in effect, the mother science, particularly as biology is expressed in human psychology, given that we are a psychological type. But our psychology is a projection of our underlying biological power type.

6.87 Power is the first right. Biologically and psychologically type, some people are more slave-like, some people are more master-like. That's just the way it is. Our moral codes are rationalizations, conscious articulations of what is underlying biological and psychological types. What we are striving for, what we should be striving for, is the improvement of the human species beyond man to the ubermensch or the overman or superman, something superior to who we are. Again, here's our chart. Feel welcome at your leisure to fill that in with the Nietzschean concepts. All right, let's pause there.

Lecture 7: Benedict & Ayer

At a glance — Benedict and Ayer.

- 7.1 All right, let's begin in 1908. Here, in Africa. This is a map of Africa a century and a bit ago. I want us to focus on that black chunk, huge chunk of territory in the center of Africa, where some of the worst things to have happened to human beings, by human beings to each other, in all of human history have happened. Focusing on these four individuals, not only the long history of the different tribes with their ethnic rivalries and hatreds, religious and other types of political conflicts, killings, tortures, enslavements, including capturing fellow Africans of a different tribe and being willing to sell them into slavery to foreigners.
- 7.2 On the left side here, I have two of those foreigners deeply involved in the slave trade in the early part of the 20th century. Tippu Tip, who died in 1905, were the most well-known, notorious, powerful of the Arab slavers, deeply involved in slave networks over much of Africa, but centered largely in the Congo, where he would purchase many slaves, transport them to the east coast of Africa to be shipped off or transported across the Sahara to be sold off in the Middle East, and he died in 1905.
- 7.3 1908, King Leopold II of Belgium dies. Another nasty individual who largely ran the Congo as a personal fiefdom, enlisting much of slave labor on various rubber plantations and brutal treatments for any of the workers who did not meet quotas in various ways. But there are changing times, and many of the Western liberal anti-slavery ideas are not only predominant in Europe, in the Americas, and other parts of the world, but also reaching into Africa itself. There's a changing of the generations.
- 7.4 On the right, I have the two philosophers, thinkers, moral thinkers, whom we're going to be focusing on today, both of whom are born right around this time. Ruth Benedict, sorry, graduated around this time from college, and then in the next generation, A.J. Ayer was being born about this time. So a changing of the guard, both reflecting on what's going on not only in their local communities and their own moral traditions, but more broadly in the world. Now, that's 1908.
- 7.5 I want to jump to 1980. Congo is now called Zaire. It has achieved its independence from the colonial powers. I want to choose 1980 because now getting a little autobiographical, that's my first year of university. In the summer after my first year of university, I did not have very much money, so I went to work, as students do. I was working as part of a construction crew. My foreman was an older man named Ross, who had worked all over the world, and he was a great storyteller. We were working hard. He was telling us all these stories about jobs he had in all these places all over the world.
- 7.6 One of the places where he had worked had been in the Congo, in Zaire. He was an explosives expert, very good at basically blowing things up as part of large-scale

construction projects. He told us and me after a couple of beers one night about the time he had spent in Congo. He'd become very good friends with this huge black man, as he described him, a Congolese, who was the foreman of the construction crew under him. They became very good friends over the course of this project. The Congolese man was also getting older.

- 7.7 When the project was over, and Ross was about to return to Canada, where he was from and where I am from originally, they apparently had a mildly drunken, tearful farewell, lots of hugs and so forth. The Congolese man said to Ross, "Ross, I've written you into my will. When I die, I want you to come back to Congo. As part of my funeral ceremonies, they will take my heart out of my body, and they will cut it into pieces, and everybody who is in my will will get to eat a part of my heart, and you're in."
- 7.8 Now, let's pause for a moment. How do you feel right now? Chances are good that you're starting to feel, what? That's disgusting, to eat someone else's heart. Now, this is some other guy, so just try for a moment to put yourself in the situation where you're at a funeral. The guy's body has been opened, his heart has been taken out, cut up into cubes. Imagine trying to pick up that little chunk of heart and put it in your mouth and chew it so you can swallow it. Possibly. OK.
- 7.9 Now, that's one possible reaction. On the other hand, suppose I said, suppose you had been born in Congo and raised in Congo, and you had gone to funerals and heard about funerals, and someone said to you, "When I die, you will get a piece of my heart." Perhaps you would feel honored and you would feel no aversion. The question is, when we say, "It's wrong and nasty to eat other people's hearts. That's cannibalism; don't do that," is that really a bad thing, or does the badness of it depend on your cultural upbringing? There's no right or wrong here.
- 7.10 Now, A.J. Ayer, Ayer for Jules Ayer, professor at Oxford University, when he was still a relatively young man, super smart guy, wrote a book in 1936 called *Language, Truth, and Logic*, where in effect, he argued that when we do morals, we're not doing anything logical, factual, or rational. Instead, what we are doing is reflecting on our emotional reaction to things and expressing our emotions. Ew, or yay. Or we are doing descriptions of various people's emotional reactions, including our own.
- 7.11 There's no intrinsic goodness or badness underwritten by God or some divine otherworldly beings. There are no natural facts that we are reading off from nature that we can observe. Instead, where we get good and bad from is from a subjective reflection on our emotional states. This is a very modern way of thinking about ethics.
- 7.12 And by the time we get to the 20th century, a certain moral tradition that has not only recognized the failures of certain other meta-ethical traditions to ground ethics, to say that there is some intrinsic objective source that we can ultimately appeal to to ground our ethics, to saying, oh, maybe there's some natural source to ground our ethics, to go inside and say it's a personal, perhaps intellectual reaction, to now, there's nothing

external about it. It is just a purely subjective, in many cases, relativized to the individual reaction to various kinds of phenomena.

- 7.13** Now, this question, I'm going to say, is a modern question, not only for these philosophical grounds, but if you consider the history of the modern world, historians will typically date modernity from around 1500 or so. That's the generation of Columbus crossing the ocean. We start to think about the world in a much more global sense, instead of just vaguely aware that there are other people out there. We're seriously interacting with them. So 1492, 1500, it's close.
- 7.14** Michelangelo, Leonardo, the Reformation era in religion, the birth of modern science. But part of these travels is Europeans, and we're largely focusing on the European tradition in moral philosophy right now, started to suddenly be aware of other cultures around the world. In many cases, those cultures do things in radically different ways from the ways that we do them. It doesn't seem that, in many cases, those cultures are dysfunctional. In some cases, it seems like they are doing better on some things than we Europeans are.
- 7.15** We go from a pre-modern context where, of course, we'll have some arguments about moral issues and so forth. But by and large, we are pretty sure that our way of thinking about morals is the right way of doing morals and thinking about morals, and that we can generalize that and universalize it to the human condition. But now we are confronted with other cultures and we start to say, well, maybe our way of doing things is not the best way of doing certain things. Maybe we should be open to the idea of adjusting our moral code and perhaps learning from some other cultures.
- 7.16** Of course, we do some things pretty darn well. We can export our way of doing morals to various other cultures and so on. But we're getting away from this idea of rather uncritically just accepting that our moral code is the right moral code for all of human beings. A more modern idea of import-export with respect to culture. Our good ideas will be adopted by other cultures. We'll drop our not-so-good ideas and import some other good ideas from various other cultures, and ultimately, we will improve our moral code.
- 7.17** Now, this was also especially a difficult era for religious philosophers. Then, in the context of Europe, when Christianity is the most prominent culture, because then if we take the official standard version of Christian theology, there is one God, and the one God issued one set of commands for all of humankind. We more or less accept this on faith, perhaps, or as matters of dogma, or as seeped into our culture by various traditions, and we valorize those traditions. We think of ourselves as not only the best culture but perhaps the best religion. How do we then explain all of these other cultures that seem to be, in many cases, doing pretty well, but they've never heard of Jesus Christ? How is this even possible?

- 7.18** The world exploration and many reports of what's going on in other parts of the world, Europeans are soaking it up. It's very interesting, a vicarious way of travel if you can't do it yourself, but it forces certain reflections on religion, on morality. This is also the era in which there's a widespread revival of interest in Greek culture, ancient Greek culture, ancient Roman culture. Again, we have the question, these are both cultures that are pre-Christian cultures, and they're amazing. How on earth could the Greeks and the Romans accomplish so many awesome, awesome things without the benefit of our religion, which we have, for so long, thought is the one true religion, without which nothing good can be accomplished?
- 7.19** We're seriously into modernity. At the same time, we're trying to be more scientific and more rational. We have to argue for various things, and that puts pressure on us to try to come up with justifications for moral beliefs that we more or less took for granted. If we can't do a very good job of rationally justifying them, and if science is starting to make progress and science is starting to come up with lots of answers to life's questions that are in conflict with our traditional religious beliefs, all of this is very modern and part of the mix. By the time we get to the 20th century, many of the traditions are reaching increasingly subjective, skeptical, and relativistic conclusions.
- 7.20** So A.J. Ayer, I want to just dip into him for a few moments. Language, Truth, and Logic, 1936 book that took at least the English-speaking philosophical world by storm because of the ruthlessness of his drawing certain conclusions with respect to metaphysics, knowledge, or understanding of value, even aesthetics. This is chapter one. I just want to highlight the title here, the Elimination of Metaphysics. That is to say, any thesis that says we can have a grand understanding of the way the universe as a whole works, behind the apparent physical phenomena, there is some metaphysical realm.
- 7.21** It's not only that we can't rationally justify that, but that when we are using that language, we are just talking nonsense. There is no way not only to prove that such things exist, but rather the words that we are using, we are abusing language, and we should just stop using that language. "We begin by criticizing the metaphysician who claims knowledge of transcendent reality by inquiring from what premises his propositions were deduced. Must he not begin, as other men do, with the evidence of his senses?"
- 7.22** If we're going to start with our senses, and at some point, we're going to talk about the unity of God's tri-part being, well, we can't get from our senses to proving that that proposition is true. It doesn't even compute. We don't even know what that is. Signaling that he is drawing on a now well-entrenched philosophical system, that of Immanuel Kant, whom we've referenced a few times now in this course, and he's saying, essentially, Kant is right on this. We cannot do metaphysics. We are subjective, fundamentally, the structure of our minds. There is no way to get outside to some transcendent ultimate reality.

- 7.23 That then ultimately becomes a meaningless concept. Ayer is in fact going one step a little bit further because Kant had said, "We know that there must be something out there, that comes in through the structure of our minds and is presented to our conscious minds and so on. We just can't know what it is." But Ayer wants to say, "Can we even make sense of this distinction between outside and inside? How do I know that there is something outside? I can't even verify the existence of something outside because I've never seen it or smelled it or tasted it and so forth."
- 7.24 And so the big standard problem that emerges from this is, how do I know that my perhaps unconscious mind isn't just totally creating what I take to be my subjective reality, and there is no outside unknowable source that's providing the raw material for it? Kant then, as Ayer reports here, said, "Human understanding becomes lost in contradiction when it ventured beyond experience." When we are not able to say there is something outside and we can't make sense of that, we should just stop using that language. It becomes a meaningless term.
- 7.25 If we can't ground the distinction between inside my mind and some transcendent reality, just drop that language because language is only meaningful if, in some sense, we can verify what we are talking about. The only way we can verify what we are talking about, given that we are human beings, is by being able to connect it in some sense to our sensory input. So drop any language that does not do so. What this means is, metaphysicians for millennia have just been abusing language, and it ultimately is nonsense, and rational people don't do that.
- 7.26 I want to jump on to the next conclusion from this, because then we say, metaphysics is one philosophical subject, and we're going to eliminate metaphysics. Well, what about ethics language? Good, bad, right, wrong, value language. What about aesthetic language, where we talk about beauty and the sublime and various other evaluative context in that? We're now jumping to chapter 6. We're drawing all of these conclusions out. "We must address judgments of value, which we will contend are simply expressions of emotion which can be neither true nor false."
- 7.27 Here we go back to the example of "here's a piece of heart for you to eat," and you have a reaction, eww. Is that a true reaction? Is that a false reaction? In one sense, it doesn't make any sense to say whether it's true or false. If someone, raised in a different culture, were to say, "Oh, I am honored or I feel honored by being able to participate in this ceremony," is that person's reaction true, and your reaction is false, or the other way around? Or are we just using this true-false language in a way that doesn't apply to this? It's just an emotional reaction. There's no right or wrong.
- 7.28 In which case, when we are doing anything in ethics, we should stop using language like true or false, right or wrong. We just eliminate that language and recognize it for what it is. "If we say, 'X is wrong,' this may be a normative moral judgment about X," normative, a value judgment, "or it may be a descriptive statement that X is repugnant to a particular society." It's fine to say, if I offer you a piece of heart, and you go "Eww,"

my statement, "She went 'eww' when I offer her the piece of heart," that can be true or false because that's a fact, or a statement about fact, and we can verify it. "I actually heard her say 'eww.' I saw her facial expression."

- 7.29** All of that is factual, but "eww," by which we mean that there is something morally wrong about what's going on here, there's no way to verify that. That's just something external to her and so forth. We're only concerned with normative ethics, and there is no way to do so. "We begin by admitting that fundamental ethical concepts are unanalyzable, as there is no criterion of validity." There's no God or divine being to underwrite it. Here's a piece of heart. That's a factual statement. I'm offering this piece of heart to you. That's another factual statement. You react with certain facial expressions and broken vocal utterances. That's all factual statement.
- 7.30** But there's nothing observable, a little flag that pops out and says, "Oh, this is bad. This is wrong." The facts are neutral with respect to that. All we are left with is an emotional reaction that is subjective to the individual having that. That's what ethics is all about. So, all of this exercise and work that we've been doing over the centuries, trying to ground and argue about morality, is misguided. It is a waste of time. In fact, it's a waste of time because we are abusing language, so we should just stop doing that.
- 7.31** "They are mere pseudo-concepts," not real concepts, because they're not verifiable. "It is impossible to find a criterion for determining the validity of ethical judgments. They have no objective validity whatsoever." They are purely subjective and confined to the emotions. The way, in that middle paragraph there, "the ethical word is purely emotive." Then Ayer ends, this is highly abridged here, and says this is why we have all of the frustrations that we do when we try to talk about ethics in some objective or intrinsic terms.
- 7.32** We just start, anytime we confront someone who has a different set of emotions than we do, we start trying to put words to them and trying to convince them by appeals to facts or appeals to gods. All of that is irrelevant, and we get frustrated. When we get frustrated, various other emotions start to kick in and we start to use verbally abusive language. But the verbally abusive language doesn't really communicate anything, except that "I don't like you very much right now, and I wish bad things would happen to you because that would satisfy my frustration that I'm feeling in this time."
- 7.33** So recognizing that all we are doing is emoting whenever we're using these value languages hopefully can then be a social corrective and undercut some of the nastiness that typically arises. All that we can do then, if we're interested in, so to speak, a science of ethics is describe individuals and how they react to various things. But we're never going to evaluate them because that's just going to be our emotional reactions to whatever is going on with that other person.
- 7.34** Or, of course, we might say, yes, every individual is different, but also individuals tend to be raised in certain cultures, and maybe their emotional reactions are a result of the

conditioning that they've experienced as a result of being raised in a particular culture. So, "What are the moral habits of a given person or group, and what causes them to have these? This is a job for the social sciences." It's not the case that moral philosophy is its own difference. We have to go and look at the social sciences and how people—

- 7.35** So, turning to the social sciences, I want to now go to Ruth Benedict, who is a social scientist. She was not British, but rather American. Just two years before A.J. Ayer had published *Language, Truth, and Logic*, 1936, she published this enormously interesting and influential work in anthropology called *Patterns of Culture*, in 1934. She had been a student on the East Coast of the United States, eventually became a professor at Columbia University in New York.
- 7.36** This is a book that was widely disseminated outside of anthropological circles, and particularly with respect to her interest in questions of ethics and morality, right and wrong, because in addition to integrating her own work as an anthropologist, but also the work of many other first-rate anthropologists studying different cultures by the time of the early 20th century, she is philosophically astute and starting to draw out some implications for how we should think about morality, ethical issues, given our now-social scientific understanding of much more of human history than was available to human beings in previous centuries.
- 7.37** Let's go to this text. *The Science of Custom*, chapter 1, define your terms. "Anthropology is the study of human beings as creatures of society." We break the term down. *Anthropos*, man, mankind, humankind. A *logos* or an *-ology* is to give an account of, and hopefully a rational scientific account of. We're trying to do a scientific account of what it is to be a human being. But what is this phrase here? Creatures of society, creation of society, human beings, the suggestion then is, come into existence as part of a society, and they are created in their identity by their membership in a society.
- 7.38** "It fastens its attention upon those physical characteristics and industrial techniques, those conventions and values, which distinguish one community from all others that belong to a different tradition." So human beings are born into a culture. They are created by that culture according to its various ways. But we also know that there are different cultures with different ways and different traditions, and so individuals are created differently in different cultures. We're going in a relativizing direction here.
- 7.39** From the anthropological scientific perspective, "our customs," that is to say, this would be now 20th-century American customs, "and those of a New Guinea tribe," other side of the world, "are two possible social schemes for dealing with a common problem, and insofar as he remains an anthropologist, he is bound to avoid any weighting of one in favor of the other." What she is pointing to here is now a part of social scientific methodology, that you don't want to take your own cognitive biases or your moral biases as an individual, nor the cognitive and moral biases of whatever

culture you happened to grow up in terms of, and interpret and evaluate another culture in terms of those.

- 7.40** In some sense, what you need to do is try to be impartial with respect to your own personal values and your own social values, so that you can be scientific in objectively describing what's going on in another culture. One of the criticisms she mounts of earlier generations of anthropologists was that they did not do that. They were aware of that as an issue, but it was very easy for their own biases of various sorts to slip into even their basic reporting of what's going on in other cultures. They're starting to use value concepts that come from their tradition in describing what's going on in another culture. So that's what we need to try to do.
- 7.41** But this is a cognitive problem that takes us into epistemological issues and it's a question of whether it's possible for us to do so, because if we really are creatures of our own society and how we look at the world and how we evaluate the world has been conditioned in us from birth, how is it possible for us to step outside of our own framework and evaluate or even describe a completely different way of thinking? She points this problem out.
- 7.42** "No man ever looks at the world with pristine eyes." They are already clouded, colored, tinted, filtered in various ways by your upbringing, and you can never get outside of that. "He sees it edited by a definite set of customs and institutions and ways of thinking. Even in his philosophical probings, rather, he cannot go beyond these, or behind these stereotypes. His very concepts of the true and false will still have reference to his particular traditional customs."
- 7.43** So that then is to say, in some fundamental way, we are trapped, and it's not even possible for us to be objectively scientific, much less objectively evaluative of other cultures. To some extent, we're always going to be trapped in our own culture's biases and evaluatives. A mention here of John Dewey, a colleague of hers at Columbia University, another famous philosopher. We're not including him in this course, but we do have coverage of John Dewey, the pragmatist philosopher, in our postmodern philosophy course.
- 7.44** Coming back to Ruth Benedict speaking in her own voice here, this point about conditioning. "The life history of the individual is first and foremost an accommodation to the patterns and standards traditionally handed down in his community." That is to say, first and foremost, you are not an individual with your own mind, with your own capacity for observing and evaluating. First and foremost, underscoring those concepts here, you accommodate to your culture.
- 7.45** "From the moment of his birth, the customs into which he is born shape his experience and behavior. By the time he can talk, he is the little creature of his culture, and by the time he is grown and able to take part in its activities, its habits are his habits, its beliefs his beliefs, its impossibilities his impossibilities. Every child that is born into his group

will share with them, and no child born into one on the opposite side of the globe can ever achieve the thousandth part."

- 7.46** Here we have a strong statement of what we more generally call environmental determinism. Who you are is determined by the environment into which you are born, but then more specifically by the social environment into which you are born. Human beings at birth are plastic or plasticine or largely malleable. You can take the same infant human being, raise it in this culture, and it will turn into an adult human being with this set of beliefs and values. If you had taken the exact same infant human being and raised it in a very different culture, by the time it's an adult, it would have been conditioned into dramatically different beliefs and values.
- 7.47** And she says, once you've been raised in one culture compared to the other, there's no way for you really to get outside of your own culture's framework and truly immerse yourself into another culture. Now, she says we are struggling then with this. She has some historical reference. By the time we get to the 20th century, we are Western civilization, pretty advanced in many respects. We reflect on the history of the science, Copernicus, Darwin, and others. We are now well aware not only of the world, but also of these cognitive and moral philosophical problems within which we are trying to do our science.
- 7.48** Now, we have one other issue to put out here that, why this becomes an important issue for Benedict, morally speaking, because part of the time we get into the modern world, we have our own internally complicated society, and we're trying to understand ourselves. Partly, we in the West have been very much an immigrant society, so we have people coming into the West from all of these different cultures. We're grappling with the issues of how to get them to have, in some basic sense, beyond the same page, culturally speaking, so that we can all say that we are part of one society, have respect for the same general set of laws and so forth. That's a very difficult problem that we are grappling with, and to a large extent, it's a uniquely modern civilisational problem.
- 7.49** At the same time, what's going on as we become increasingly global is all kinds of other cultures are coming into contact with each other and sometimes collision with each other. Sometimes it goes OK, but a lot of times it goes quite messily, and sometimes it goes quite badly, so to speak. Now, I'm using all of these moral concepts—well, badly, messily, and so forth. Is it then the case that, well, I am just a 20th-century Westerner, I now being Ruth Benedict, and I am bothered by this?
- 7.50** There's a sometimes unpleasant collision of cultures that go on. Am I merely projecting my 20th-century Western moral framework onto this moral situation? Or are there really issues here that we should all be addressing, given that we are now a modern global society, with all of these different traditions? The way she puts it is this way. "Modern existence has thrown many civilizations into close contact," in a way that has

never happened before in human history, "and at the moment, the overwhelming response to this situation is nationalism and racial snobbery."

- 7.51** She's worried about this. My nation is better than your nation, and perhaps my nation should have the right to conquer your nation and take your stuff and do what we want with you. She doesn't like that. Or a standard response when people of different races, and here it's not quite only biological racial issues, but races in terms of ethnic organization and so on, has been for, pretty much universally, all the races to say when they confront another race or another ethnicity is to have this, "My race and my ethnicity is better than your race," and to put you down in various ways and think that we can do various things. She sees these as problems.
- 7.52** What she is hoping is that anthropology will be able to help us here. It will enlighten us in some perhaps modest way, even if we can never get entirely out of our own conditioning and biases. "There has never been a time when civilization stood more in need of individuals who are genuinely culture conscious, who can see objectively," and I've highlighted the word objectively because this is a hard word for Benedict to be using at this point here, "the socially conditioned behavior of other peoples without fear and recrimination."
- 7.53** She's going to argue, and this is where we're going to end up in a few minutes, that what we hope is that a proper social science of anthropology will help us solve all of these cultural conflicts that are going on, from the unthinking chauvinism, and my culture is just automatically and dogmatically the best one, that if we can get people to be a little more aware, they will be a little bit more objective, they will be a little more tolerant, and then interactions will be a little more peaceful.
- 7.54** But that requires that we step out of our own cultural framework, as much as we possibly can, and start to become aware of just the amazing diversity of human culture. I want to march through some of these. Benedict assumes that we all basically know our own culture pretty well. So what she does, interestingly, is, has some cultures from Papua New Guinea, from the American Indians and a few different tribes there, some of the Northwestern tribes up in what is now British Columbia of Canada, other places in Asia, Africa, and so on. It's an amazing integration of anthropological studies from all over the world.
- 7.55** She selects quite consciously some of the things that are always seemingly important to human beings, like how do we think about going through puberty, children becoming young adults? What do we think about marriage? What do we think about sexuality? What do we think about killing each other and so on? All of the biggies, so to speak. And notice, as she wants to, will point out repeatedly how different human beings are with respect to all of these things.
- 7.56** Let's take adulthood. Central North America, so the American Plains Indians, the Sioux and others. "Honor in it is the great goal of all men." What is it to become an honorable

man? That is the top value. Now, in other cultures, honor, of course, is important, but it's not the top value. There are other things, like being able to make a living, preparing for a job, becoming self-responsible, self-supporting, we might say. That's in other cultures, but that's not honor. There might be some honor attached to it, but it's a different approach.

7.57 How do you become an honorable man? Becoming good at war. "The constantly recurring theme of the youth's coming-of-age, also as the preparation for the war path at any age, is a magic ritual for success in war." The top goal for young men is become a good warrior. If you are not a good warrior, you will be dishonored and you will feel shame yourself through the course of your life. That's the top value. How do you become a great warrior? Well, obviously, there's lots of physical training that will be engaged in, and we can find lots of cultures, of course, across history that are engaged in physical training. That's very important.

7.58 But when we study these particular tribes, there's all these magic rituals that they engage in. "They torture not one another but themselves." We take the young men, 12, 13, 14 years of age, as she describes here. "They cut strips of skin from their arms and legs." I want to become a great warrior. I'm going to cut some skin off my body here and throw it away. OK, now what's your reaction to that? Oh, that's just wrong. Of course, they're like, no, that's right. That's right. If I am not manly enough to do this to myself, I feel shame, and no girl is ever going to look at me. There's other consequences as well.

7.59 "They strike off their fingers." They will take a wooden stake and their pectoral muscle, drive the wooden stake under their pectoral muscle, so it comes out the other side, attach leather strips to both of it, and then put heavy weights at the end of the long leather strip, and then show that they can drag the heavy weights along the ground. That's how manly I am. Then, of course, there's scars on my chest as a result of this, but these are badges of honor. I am proud of them. That's just for the boys. Of course, in these cultures, for the girls, it's very different. Girls are on a very different track.

7.60 Puberty rights for girls, nothing to do with war, so it's completely relativized by sex or gender. "One of the most naive of these," and now we jump to Africa as an example. There's, what does it mean for a girl to become a woman, and particularly an attractive woman, who's then going to be able to get a mate and get the best mate that she possibly can be? "One of the most naive of these is the institution of the fattening house for girls in Central Africa. In the region where feminine beauty is all but identified with obesity." The most beautiful woman is a fat woman, and fat to the point of obesity. If you are a stick-insect kind of woman, ugly, unattractive, not at all good.

7.61 The point then is a ritual that the girls look forward to where they will be secluded from the rest of the tribe, not engaging in very much physical activity and basically eating as much as they possibly can for a certain period of time so that they become nice and fat. Then when they come out, all of the boys and the young men will go, "Wow, she's what

I want," and she will get the best husband that is possible. "Sometimes the girl at puberty is segregated, sometimes for years, fed with sweet and fatty foods, allowed no activity, and her body rubbed assiduously with oils," et cetera.

- 7.62 OK, so puberty rights all over the world, just a couple of excerpts. Now we're all going, wow, that is so weird. But of course, the point would be, if you were raised in those cultures, you would not see them as weird at all. You would say, "Look at what those Western Americans are doing. That is so weird." It's culturally conditioned. How about killing people? Bad. "We might suppose that in the matter of taking life, all peoples would agree in condemnation." That's our automatic reaction, as people raised in Western society.
- 7.63 "On the contrary, in the matter of homicide, it may be held that one is blameless if diplomatic relations have been severed between two neighboring countries." We have the normal diplomacy that goes on between your tribe and my tribe. That's broken down. At that point, if you kill someone in the other tribe, you get zero blame at all. You might even get a little bit of honor if you are particularly a young man trying to prove yourself in many cases, killing someone from another tribe is a necessary condition for you to be fully accepted into manhood.
- 7.64 "Or that one kills by custom his first two children." You don't do that? Something wrong with you. "Or that a husband has a right of life and death over his wife." Wife kills her husband, that's bad. Never. She has no such right. On the other hand, a husband has a right at any point to kill his wife, and no blame will be attached to him. That's his power. "Or that it is the duty of the child to kill the parents before they are old." Maybe we will think there's an economic explanation behind this. If we are in a subsistence tribe and living from one year to next, it's pretty tight, particularly getting through the winter, if food reserves are low.
- 7.65 Old people, they don't hunt, they don't farm, they don't contribute, they become a drain on the culture. So, the obligation then of the children is, once the parents get old and to that point, to kill them. Again, that is a matter of moral responsibility, a good thing to do. If you say, "Oh, I love my parents, and I want them to enjoy their grandchildren," well, there's something wrong with you. You are violating a moral principle, et cetera, et cetera, et cetera. The point is, you go all around the world and you collect stories about when it's appropriate to kill or not. It's all over the map.
- 7.66 How about religious beliefs? Of course, we are the great diversity of these ones here. You might think the most important thing life is not success in war. The most important thing in life is not attracting the most powerful husband you can. It might be connecting with the gods. A huge amount of your value training is preparing yourself to be able to engage in connection with the supernatural beings. "The most conspicuous of these is probably the practice of obtaining supernatural power in a dream or vision." You want to connect with the gods, show your religious commitment, and the gods require that

we do various brutal, sometimes sacrificial, self-flagellating things in order to grant us the right kinds of visions.

- 7.67 "On the western plains, men sought these visions with hideous tortures," again, "cutting strips of skin off their arms. They struck off their fingers. They swung themselves from tall poles by straps inserted under the muscles of their shoulders." That's a little bit different. You put them under these muscles here, have yourself suspended, get swung around. Then hopefully the gods will communicate with you, and you have achieved your big goal. We said, man, that just sounds so weird.
- 7.68 And then pointedly, she points out, well, you Christians or we Christians in North America and Europe, we believe in human sacrifices. Remember the story of Isaac and Abraham, and what happened to Jesus? Well, he was nailed to a cross, and that was a good thing, or was that a bad thing? But we are supposed to be like Jesus, and that means that we are to accept martyrdom, if necessary, in our cases.
- 7.69 Sometimes we go out of our way to try to become martyrs, and maybe we will, when we are praying, try to get the sin out of ourselves by cutting ourselves or hitting ourselves with whips that have little pieces of metal at the end, such that strips of skin come off of our backs and we are bleeding. Isn't that rather similar? We think that's OK within our traditions to what's going on weirdly. We can find, as Benedict is pointing out, 20th-century Christians who are engaged in these long-standing Christian practices as well.
- 7.70 OK, how about sex and attitudes with respect to sexuality, and the connection of those to marriage? Well, she goes rather to the Dobu tribe. Very interesting culture where, of course, men and women get married. But in contrast to Western civilization, where we expect a man and woman get married, they get married for life, maybe a century or so ago, there was an expectation that they were not to have sex prior to marriage, and that once they got married, they were going to have sex only in the marital bedroom, between the husband and wife. Adultery is just a terrible, terrible sin to commit in various respects.
- 7.71 So, the Dobu, by contrast, they have a custom of marriage, but they don't expect, really, the man or the woman to remain faithful. There's an expectation that adultery is going to happen pretty frequently by both the man and by the woman. Now, this is interesting because it's not only that it's put up and tolerated. We're married and we have our children, we look after our children, but we have our sexual interests, and so we just maybe turn a blind eye or have an agreement that there's going to be some mutual sharing that goes around. The way she puts it, there's among the Dobu, it becomes almost a social ritual, almost to put anachronistic words on it, a soap opera that is celebrated within the tribe anytime there is an adultery that occurs.
- 7.72 Notice the description here. "Adultery within this group is a favorite pastime." Someone cheats on their spouse, and then the rumor mill starts up, and everybody gets

excited about it, and they start talking about it. The spouse who has been cheated upon, the husband or the wife, eventually is going to hear about it and feels something or other, but at the same time, pretends perhaps to be more outraged than he or she really is, and goes stomping around and breaking things and demanding that the person give an account of themselves and bribing kids in order to get more information about it.

- 7.73** The point is that it becomes a kind of drama, a sexual drama, in which the entire community is participating. And maybe the soap opera analogy is not so far off, the same reason we like to watch soap operas and all of the sexual shenanigans that goes on. Yes, it's cheating and it's kind of bad, but at the same time, we kind of like it, we kind of expect it, and we turn it into a big social ritual, and that's the Dobu. "If it is the husband, he breaks his wife's cooking pots." There, that'll show her. "If it is the wife, she maltreats her husband's dog." Yeah, kick the dog. Yeah, that'll show him, cheating on me. Everybody has a lot of fun with all of this that's going on.
- 7.74** Now, we go to northwest, getting on up to Yukon, Alaska, northern British Columbia. What about cannibalism? Another one here. The Kwakiutl, the cannibal society within this particular tribe, they had particular individuals who were celebrated for their cannibalism. Anytime they had a village feast or a tribal feast, there would be a cannibalism ritual that would be incorporated into the cannibalism. Sorry, into the festival or the dinner. "Its members," that is to say, the ones who had been trained in the cannibalism rituals, "were given seats of highest honor at the winter dances, and all others must hold back from the feast until the cannibals had begun to eat."
- 7.75** We might think, "Oh, cannibalism, just never do it. That's just awful. I would never do that. I would rather die than have to resort to cannibalism." If there was, well, maybe as a matter of absolute desperation, if we are stuck in the Andes mountains or at the Donner Pass trying to get through the Rocky Mountains, and it's literally life or death, we have to eat, unfortunately, one of the members of our party who has died. OK, we might do that under various circumstances as well.
- 7.76** Or we have had a war between our tribe and your tribe, and we defeated you, and there's the dead body there. For us to demonstrate and plant a flag, so to speak, on our dominance over that other tribe, I will take some flesh from my slain enemy and incorporate it into myself, as a matter of wartime ritual. Or as she describes it here, we're going to have a big winter festival, and the most honorable people within our tribe will have been trained in certain cannibal rituals. They get the best seats, they get the first choice of the flesh, and not until that ritual is done do the rest of us eat the rest of our food.
- 7.77** So, the guy dances, the guy does various prayers and so forth, and at a point where he works himself into the right kind of frenzy, "he fell upon the onlookers with his teeth and bit a mouthful of flesh from their arms." That is to say, the other people in the tribe jump on them and try to bite them and get some flesh from their arms. Of course, this

is largely ritualized. We're not really doing cannibalism. It's just a ritual that we have incorporated into our society. Or sometimes it's OK to actually do eating, as long as it's the body of slaves who have been killed for this particular purpose. "On great occasions, the cannibal ate the bodies of the slaves who had been killed for the purpose."

7.78 Then Benedict, of course, wants us then to start thinking, "That sounds so weird. That sounds so disgusting." Our belief that we should never engage in cannibalism for real purposes or even for ritual purposes, well, what about Christianity? This idea that, during various religious services, we approach the altar and we drink the blood of Jesus, or we eat the flesh of Jesus; and some Christians who want to argue that you really are drinking the blood of Jesus and eating the flesh of Jesus and other versions of Christianity, they'd say, "Well, it's just symbolic. It's just a ritual. It's not really the blood of Jesus." But there's a kind of connection to some sort of ancient cannibalism that's coming on up through this tradition. So maybe all of this is not so weird after all.

7.79 What about moving on to homosexuals? How do we think about homosexuals? She reports Western civilization in the modern times—this is now the 1930s—has been largely saying that this is a bad thing. One should not engage in it. We might tolerate it at the edges, but in many cases, we'll get fired up about it and start putting homosexuals in prison for what they are doing. "Western civilization tends to regard even a mild homosexual as an abnormal." Something wrong with this person. It might be a moral weakness or it might be a psychological weakness.

7.80 "The clinical picture of homosexuality stresses the neuroses and the psychoses to which it gives rise, and emphasizes almost equally the inadequate functioning of the invert and his behavior." All right, so that's our culture 90 years ago, and how we thought about homosexuality. She goes on to point out, well, if you go back to the ancient Greeks, for example, what we find in the greatest philosopher, or one of the great philosophers, Plato's Republic, is a presentation of homosexuality as an honorable state of human beings. It's perfectly fine, perfectly acceptable, not so much between women, but if it's an older man and a younger man, and they are in a mentoring relationship, and it slips over into some sexual intercourse as well, that's perfectly acceptable and perhaps even an honorable thing. So completely the opposite.

7.81 What do we think about men and women, and particularly men who aren't sure if they are men, and maybe they think of themselves and feel themselves more like women, what we now call transgender people? The term that Benedict uses is the "berdache", borrowing from the French. "In most of North America," this is not contemporary North America, but North America prior to the widespread establishment of European culture, "in most of North America, there exists the institution of the berdache, as the French called them. These men-women were men who at puberty or thereafter took the dress and occupations of women. Sometimes they married with other men and lived with them. Sometimes they were men with no inversion."

- 7.82 That is to say, they didn't want to have sex with other men. They just wanted to be women. "They were persons of weak sexual endowment." So maybe I was a young man and I didn't feel particularly masculine, and I didn't think that I was going to be able to satisfy a woman. I didn't think I'd be able to father a lot of children. So maybe instead of avoiding all of that shame, I'm going to adopt the role and persona of a woman to avoid all of that, "particularly the jeers of women," as she put it here.
- 7.83 So if I'm a more effeminate feminine guy, and I don't come across as powerful and honorable, and I'm going to go out and be a tough guy on the battlefield, of course, it's not only my fellow males who will be mocking me and making fun of me, but even worse, the young women and other women in the tribe will be mocking me. Just to avoid that whole thing, I will abandon, so to speak, masculinity and become feminine. That's a whole bunch of variations on transgenderism.
- 7.84 "These berdaches were never regarded as of a first-rate supernatural power." But then we go to Siberia and we find that there, they have also men-women. It's not with respect to questions of honor and sexual prowess and so forth. It's that these are special individuals. These are the ones to whom the gods speak especially, because of their not fitting into the stereotypical role. We will honor them and elevate them to a more priestly type of rule. "They were never regarded as of the first-rate supernatural power of similar men-women in Siberia," and so forth.
- 7.85 All right, now we have all of this survey, and we're going through cannibalism and killing people and puberty rights and marriage and faithfulness and so forth, and what is the big message of all of this? What are we to take away? "Social thinking at the present time has no more important task before it than that of taking adequate account of cultural relativity." Morals are not universal. They are not absolute, is her claim. They are relative, dependent upon cultural decisions.
- 7.86 It's also, they are relative, not at the individual level. It's not, according to Benedict, that we individually have our own emotions and we make our own decisions, and every individual has their own moral code, so to speak. We as individuals are creatures of our society and condition, and so it is a cultural relativity. "It," that is to say anthropology, now that we are towards the end of the book here, "has pointed out its incongruity," what social science teaches us, "with the orthodox dreams of permanence and ideality." That is to say, the traditional right-thinking way about morality, that there's one right set of moral principles, and they are permanent for all times.
- 7.87 Yes, we understand that people are variable. They don't live up to these various ideals; nonetheless, there is one set of ultimately permanent moral ideals that we can identify and should be striving for. "And with the individual's illusions of autonomy." So all of those moral philosophers who have stressed the individual, who have stressed your capacity for thinking for yourself, making your own decisions, forming your own character, taking responsibility for your own actions—all of that, from Benedict's anthropological perspective, has been exploded as an illusion.

- 7.88 Now, this sounds skeptical, and it sounds like there might be some other problems lurking in the wings here, but she wants to draw a positive moral from this, and it's this. "We shall arrive then at a more realistic social faith, accepting as grounds for hope and as new bases for tolerance, the coexistence, the co-existing, rather, and equally valid patterns of life which mankind has created for itself."
- 7.89 What we need to do is recognize that there are all of these different cultural traditions, and each has its morality, and they all disagree with each other. Except that's how it is. We can never say that one culture is better than any other culture, and we should avoid those judgments. Then if we can do so, then that will lead to tolerance between the different cultures. They will not be morally condemning and then thinking that we are better than you, so we therefore have the right to do various negative things and control you and take over you.
- 7.90 Here's Ruth Benedict, honored with a stamp in the US Postal Service history. Here's a summary of what I would say are the key takeaways from her anthropology-based approach to moral philosophy. Anthropology is the mother science, so to speak, from which we will do all human thinking. That's because we need to think of human beings as socially conditioned, as part of their cultures. This has implications for two kinds of relativism. The moral standards, what we take to be good and bad, is conditioned by different cultures. There's no way of translating from one into the other.
- 7.91 Also, purely cognitively, we all learn to look at the world through the lens, so to speak, of our social conditioning, so we can't think outside of our conditioning. This requires that we adopt then a non-judgmental standard with respect to other culture's ways of doing things. We can't say that any one culture is better than another, and that requires then, or implies, rather, that tolerance is the appropriate stance to take. All of this, obviously, is controversial, just like all of the other philosophies, moral philosophies we've looked at, are controversial. Obviously, this is posing great challenges to the philosophers we have looked at here.
- 7.92 But let's try also to raise some of the standard and important criticisms of this approach here. We end with this call for tolerance at the end of Patterns of Culture. There's a question here about what status tolerance has, because is Benedict trying to elevate tolerance to being some universal standard that we all, around the world, all members of all cultures, need to be more tolerant with respect to each other, so that we stop killing each other and stop trying to dominate each other and so forth?
- 7.93 Now, if so, then we have at least a tension, if not a contradiction, in our thinking here, because if my conclusion is that any set of values, including the value of tolerance, is merely a socially conditioned value that I happen to have been conditioned into because I was raised, say, in upstate New York or wherever, why can I now say that my culture's valorization of tolerance should apply to other cultures? What about cultures that don't think tolerance is particularly important? Why should I then say, "No, you have to be tolerant"? That sounds like a tension there.

- 7.94 Now, there's two ways of raising this. One is to say, what we are perhaps interested in, and let's take the perspective of Americans, North Americans, Canada and the US, coming out of a certain culture, what we are interested in in our particular culture, because we are so religiously and politically and philosophically diverse, and we are open to immigration for people from all over the world, what we are trying to do just within our culture is get all of the different cultural moral traditions to be a little more peaceful.
- 7.95 And so what we're trying to do is, anytime anyone shows up inside our culture, so that they're not all at each other's throats and they're not being dogmatic and intolerant and so forth, is to say, for our culture, the value is going to be tolerance. "Come here, be a tolerant person, and then we will get along with all of the other members of our society." That's all that we're trying to say. But we still have the same problem, because then, if part of our culture is to say, we have a whole bunch of different subcultures, why would we take one of those subcultures and say that that subculture and its values get to speak for all of the other subcultures?
- 7.96 Why wouldn't we say, people coming from whatever part of the world with their own moral traditions and they have some intolerances along some dimension, and we say, "No, you shouldn't be doing that," well, what gives my subculture the right perspective and the right authority to be able to say of that other subculture that its way of doing things is wrong? If I say, well, you're now in, say, the United States, and we have the United States government, and it's trying to enforce a certain set of laws, and all we're saying is, one of our subcultures has become dominant in our culture, and it now has the power of government behind it, and it's going to make you do what we want us to do if you are going to be here.
- 7.97 But then that's just a power play of some sort. There's a tension here that needs to be thought about more and resolved. That's for internal issues. Now, we might then say, well, it's not only for these internal peace, tolerance issues. We are now a global society, and one of the things that we're recognizing is there's all these other cultures out there with their different moral traditions and political traditions and religious traditions and so on. What we want is more international peace and cooperation and tolerance.
- 7.98 But the same issue is going to arise. Why would we want to say that international peace should be the universal value? We're saying everything is relative and our culture wants everything to be more peaceful. But there are lots of cultures out there that don't think peace is particularly good. They like war; they like conflict. That's their tradition. If we are saying, "No, you have to stop with your traditions and adopt our traditions," how can we do that consistently? And that is the problem.
- 7.99 Or maybe the issue is, what we are concerned with, particularly from an American perspective, now, by the time we get into the 20th century, that America is the most powerful nation in the world, then what we are doing is we are looking at the history of

other powerful nations across time. What has been the norm for them is, we've got the power, we conquer you, we take your stuff, we take your women, we make you do what we want you to do, including possibly even make slaves of you. But we don't believe in that anymore by the time we get into the 20th century.

7.100 Now that we are the big power in the world, we are trying to reform this long history of, so to speak, predatory imperialism that so many cultures across history have engaged in, and we are not going to do predatory imperialism anymore. We're going to have a kind of international order that's based on trade and peace and mutual respect and tolerance and so forth. But are we then not just doing the same thing, taking our particular set of values and trying to export them and make other cultures adopt to those values?

7.101 If they are then, say, warlike and trying to interfere with the peaceful intercourse among nations, and we step in with our military and we stop them from doing so, well, aren't we then being predatory imperialists ourselves, but just in the cause of peace? We're still taking our universal values and imposing them on others. Now, one of my favorite stories with respect to this, when we start talking about imperialisms of various sorts, is the British, when the British were in India. They were then the great empire power, a century and a half ago, and very early on, they realized that they were in a culture that, in many respects, was completely alien to the British way of doing things.

7.102 In this particular case, what to them was this horrifying practice of "sati", where a man died, and particularly if he was a more prosperous man, he would be burned in a funeral pyre, a kind of cremation, and there would be great ceremony attached to that. But the expectation was, and the long-standing practice was, that when the man died, if his wife was still alive—she is now a widow—she too would be burned alive during the funeral cremation of her now-dead husband.

7.103 Here we have a representation of the dead guy is inside, and there's the woman, still alive, placed on the funeral pyre. Everybody is around, ready to engage in the funeral rites. You light the fire, you cremate the man, you burn the woman to death. The British were horrified. They say, "You don't do that. That's wrong. Absolutely wrong. Stop it." What is the response of Indians who are engaged in this practice? "This is our long-standing cultural tradition. We've always done this. We think it's right with this or a proper way to honor the dead man. Who are you, foreigners, to tell us how we should do our important funeral rights? Stop being so imperialistic."

7.104 Here we have a dilemma. Because if we want to say, "Well, we should be tolerant of other cultures' traditions," then we should be tolerant of this. If we're not willing to go there, then we have to say there's something wrong about this, something objectively wrong about that; and that takes us directly back into moral philosophy. What exactly is objectively wrong with that, if what we think is objectively wrong is not simply a matter of having been culturally conditioned in some different way?

- 7.105** I'll end with a British general, very famous now for this one anecdote, who was part of the British forces in India at the time. Napier. He wanted to say, "Look, don't do this." I'll just read the anecdote. The Indians said, "Well, this is our practice. Don't tell us what to do." He says, "Well, you say that it is your custom to burn widows. Very well. Well, we also have a custom. When men burn a woman alive, we tie a rope around their necks and hang them." Interjecting, that's the British way of doing things. So, "build your funeral pyre, and beside it, my carpenters will build a gallows. You may follow your custom, and we will follow ours."
- 7.106** Now, in one sense, this is a perfectly multicultural solution. We will respect your culture; you will respect our culture. We will both do our own thing. Now, we might say, no, really, what's going on here, that's one interpretation, of course. Say, no, this is really just predation because he's speaking ironically. "I am the British general. I have all of these truths. We have more power than you do." The subtext is, "If you continue to do things your way, we will kill you." The expectation then is, of course, that the Indians will say, "We are outpowered in this particular case, so we will bow to the superior power." It's really just another form of predation here.
- 7.107** Or we might say, no, really, the British are right. This is another possibility. Killing a woman just because her husband has died is wrong. There's something objectively wrong about that. So, yes, they are having to use power to enforce this moral, but that's the correct moral. Once again, we are back into at least a three-way debate over moral codes. We'll pause there. Come back soon.

Lecture 8: Foot

At a glance — Philippa Foot.

- 8.1** 1967, Philippa Foot, whom we will be focusing on in this session, published a journal article that received huge attention, such that, half a century later, many memes on social media play around with the trolley problem, as it is called. Here we have a trolley on a track. We have two possible tracks it can go upon, and then someone standing by the switch. Description of it is this way. Let's read together to get into the spirit of things.
- 8.2** "There is a runaway trolley barreling down the railway tracks. Ahead on the tracks are five people tied up and unable to move. You are standing next to a lever. If you pull this lever, the trolley will switch to a different set of tracks. But or however, there is one person on the side track, and you have two options. Option one, you can do nothing, in which case the trolley will kill the five people on the main track. Or you can pull the lever, which will divert the trolley onto the side track where it will kill one person. What is the right thing to do?"
- 8.3** What is the proper thing to do? What is the good thing to do? What is the best thing to do? We put you, first person, into a real situation and force you to make an either-or decision. Abstract philosophy, moral theory, should come out in actions with respect to each of us individually. This is what we hope it will do. It'll help us solve all of the difficult issues that we need to solve and make the best decisions we can in those circumstances. What is the right thing to do in this situation?
- 8.4** Well, one thing you can do is to say, "I don't really want to be a part of this." I can say, "Look, the situation was the way it was. I'm not driving the trolley. Someone was irresponsible, or some accident happened. The trolley is just going along before I got here, and it was already set that somebody else tied these five people to the tracks. If I weren't here, what would happen is the five people will die, and that's just outside of my control. I don't have any moral responsibility for that."
- 8.5** But at the same time, you are there. You have been put in this situation. You may have just wandered up and said, "Oh, there's this situation. Oh, there's this lever." And then you look and you can see what is possible. So, if in that situation, now that you are involved, independently of whatever may have happened before, you do have some agency. And how you use that agency then makes you morally responsible for at least part of the outcome.
- 8.6** Then you might say, "Well, I read my John Stuart Mill, greatest happiness for the greatest number. There are five people on the one track. There's only one person on the other track. And so logic dictates that the right thing to do is save as many people as possible in this situation. What I have a moral responsibility to do is pull the lever, so that the trolley goes to the other track and only one person gets killed." Morally, best

option as well. "On the other hand, when I think further about that, I pulled the lever. And when I think about that one person who died, I am morally culpable and complicit in the killing of that person because of the decision that I made."

- 8.7** Now, we have just, in the space of two minutes or so, spun out a number of possibilities, and it's a hard problem for us to start thinking through. Suppose we start adding some other variables. Say, yeah, greatest happiness for the greatest number, et cetera. There's five people there, but that one person is my spouse, my husband or wife, my child. So yeah, it's five versus one. "But hey, I don't care. Die, you five. I'm saving this one person whom I care about more than all of the other five put together," and so on and so forth.
- 8.8** Now, this is a very rich paper that an entire industry of philosophical discussion about the trolley problems came into existence as a result of Philippa Foot writing it. Now, part of what made this exciting was not just the particular device of the trolley, but that in the context of 1960s moral philosophy, in the most advanced and sophisticated forms in which it was taking place, there was a widespread sense that moral philosophy had reached a series of dead ends, that we'd collectively, over the course of many generations, all these super smart people explored every single possible way of doing moral philosophy, and all of them failed in various respects.
- 8.9** I have a quotation here from Professor Ernest Moody, who was at the University of California at Los Angeles, a very strong philosophy department, a well-regarded philosopher who had become the president of the American Philosophical Association, the main professional body. At the main annual conference, he's giving the president's speech or the president's address to all of the collected philosophers at the time. He, as is appropriate, gets all philosophical about the state of the philosophy profession, and he says, "Things are pretty dismal right now." Let's read through this quotation here. This is where we are.
- 8.10** "In the courses on moral philosophy, we analyze ethical judgments and show that they are cognitively meaningless." There's A.J. Ayer, 1936. Now, that influence has permeated the philosophy discipline. It's not only that some views are right or wrong or were only probabilistic and so forth. We can't even make sense of what we are trying to talk about when we are talking about moral language. "Or that they are equivalent to imperative sentences." They're not making statements of facts. We're just trying to influence each other by ordering each other around. Do this, do that. "Or they're just reports on one's emotional state."
- 8.11** Again, A.J. Ayer and the entire school built around it. It's nothing about God's will, it's nothing about the way things are in nature. There are no facts. It's just emotional expressions. "And if we take up the classical ethical theories, we convince the student, by the time he has finished the course, that none of them is dependable as a guide to the decisions that have to be made in life." If you're a competent philosophy professor in the 1960s, well-versed in Socrates, Plato, Aristotle, Epicurus, Cicero, Augustine,

Aquinas, the entire tradition, you have learned as part of your professional training how to shoot every single one of those down and show them as inadequate.

- 8.12** Philosophy is completely useless to sorting out life's most difficult. It's not at all a guide to life. So part of the excitement then, of Philippa Foot, is then her bringing into philosophy, once again, this question—how actually would I solve actual human problems? Because sometimes I do have to make trolley problem-type decisions and so forth. Here we are reaching the end of this particular course, and I'm the philosophy professor, guiding you through some of the big names in the discipline. What conclusions have we reached?
- 8.13** We looked at Kant of a certain sort. Moralities about duties, but they come from some unknowable realm and we can't ultimately make sense of them. We're supposed to take this absurd leap of faith into God, the way Kierkegaard wants us to do. We're supposed to allow Comte and his disciples to set up a collectivist dictatorship and tell us what to do with our lives. Or we're supposed to go with what the majority thinks is going to be maximizing their pleasure and minimizing their pain, according to a kind of John Stuart Mill approach.
- 8.14** It's all about instincts and power instincts and domination, according to a Nietzschean philosophy. It's all just subjective expressions, according to the individual, perhaps with some social conditioning and/or, if we look at the one woman we've covered so far, we are all creatures of society, and there's just all these different traditions, and they really can't talk to each other, and we can't even understand a different way of looking at the world. Or we could add Schopenhauer to the list and ultimately say, nothing is of value, and it would be better, in fact, that we don't exist at all, embrace a kind of nihilism.
- 8.15** We take all of that, and here we are in the 1960s. This is not encouraging. Philippa Foot, an Oxford-trained philosopher, a professor at Oxford, publishes a series of papers, trolley problem being one of them. In 1960s, 1970s, she comes to have high standing and was well-regarded in the profession. By the time she gets older, just before she dies, she publishes this book, Oxford University Press in 2001, called *Natural Goodness*. That is the kind of title that sends reverberations through the philosophy community because she's using the word natural goodness.
- 8.16** The idea that we can talk about natural goodness, that it's not just some subjective thing or some socially conditioned thing, or we just have to take on faith some religious tradition or other, that somehow we can show that goodness and badness are natural. This is an eyebrow-raising project in contemporary philosophy. Partly, it's because every philosophy student learns that naturalism is a fallacy, such to the point that the whole idea that you can ground goodness, rightness, or wrongness in nature or in certain natural facts about the world, that's just a fallacy.
- 8.17** Such that many philosophy students, philosophy professors will say, "Anybody who claims that they can make a connection between facts and values, between is

statements and ought statements, or descriptive statements and normative statements, you can be absolutely sure that person is making a mistake and just set that entire project aside." So this is called the naturalistic fallacy. Now, as part of the skepticism, there has been supernatural approaches to ethics, and most philosophers will say, "Well, that also is a fallacy." Then we try to ground ethics in nature. Most philosophers, by the 1960s, said that also is a fallacy, and so we're into some skeptical and relativistic place.

- 8.18** So Philippa Foot is taking up this challenge, and what she wants to suggest is that, in fact, the naturalistic fallacy is itself a fallacy, that there is proper way to connect descriptive facts and normative facts. We can ground ethics in a naturalistic understanding of human beings. Now, David Hume has come up by, mentioned a couple of times in this course. We have a course in modern philosophy where we devote significant time to David Hume. If you are interested in sideways reading or sideways connection, that's one place to start.
- 8.19** But the naturalistic fallacy is mostly identified with David Hume, who was an empiricist in the 1700s, and he argued, if we are going to make sense of any of our beliefs and say that they are meaningful and possibly true, they have to be grounded in sensory knowledge. So he is an empirist in that sense. If you are not able, whatever idea or concept, belief proposition or whatever, if you are not able to show what the referent of that term is or what that proposition breaks down and connects to, what it refers to in the facts, then not only are you not talking about something truthful, you're not even talking about something meaningful.
- 8.20** If I just made up a word, framister, right now in your minds, that is a meaningless word. What is a framister? If I have a point of various other words that I throw around, if I'm not able to point out something or other that grounds the concept of framister or the word framister, it's just a meaningless word. We have to be quite ruthless about this and stop with all the speculative verbiage that philosophers are notorious for, and get serious about taking every single concept and proposition, breaking it down, and showing the sensory basis that gives rise to the meaningfulness of this concept.
- 8.21** If we apply this to moral concepts, Hume claims we cannot do it. We start talking about "God's grounding it," but we cannot make sense of the concept of God, the argument is here. We can't see, smell, taste, touch, and we can't, even if we start with our sensory awareness, biological process, arrive at a conclusion that shows that God exists. So that ultimately is not going to be the right approach. The same thing holds, Hume wants to argue, for any naturalistic approach. When we sense, smell, taste, touch, et cetera, there is no way to get from those descriptive statements about what one is experiencing to evaluative statements, to ought statements, to this is good or this is bad.
- 8.22** No little flag pops out and says right or wrong. I can say that something is tasty or not tasty. It has a certain sound or it doesn't. I can describe the way scientists do, but out of

those descriptions, you don't suddenly get to good or bad statements. There's a gap then between descriptive statements, is statements, and ought statements. The claim that you can never get from one to the other is the description of the naturalistic fallacy. Here is a little bit of text from Hume, where in his Treatise of Human Nature in 1730s, he makes this point.

- 8.23** "In every system of morality, which I have hitherto met with," so all these various moral philosophies that I have read, "I have always remarked that the author proceeds for some time in ordinary ways of reasoning, and establishes the being of a God." So I might lay out certain facts about the world and argue, logically, therefore a God exists, and so forth, "or makes observations about human beings." Here's these human beings, they are doing this, they're doing that, this guy is doing this. Just all these descriptions and logic.
- 8.24** "When of a sudden," that is to say, all of a sudden, "I'm surprised to find that, instead of the usual copulations of propositions, is and is not," that is to say, just state forward factual descriptive statements, "I meet with no position that is not connected with an ought, or an ought not." So suddenly we move from descriptive statements to normative statements, or from is statements to ought statements, or from neutral statements to now value statements. Where did that extra bit that is supposed to be carried by the value statement, the extra meaningfulness or the extra importance, where does that come from?
- 8.25** There's no way to show that it is grounded in any of the preceding is statements. If we're going to be factual and logical, we can't just start adding extra stuff, meaningfulness into those statements. We have to be neutral. Wherever we're going to be scientific, we can't also try to be moral philosophers. We have to be value neutral. Any way of trying to bridge that back is impossible. "The change is imperceptible; but it is, however, of the last consequence. For as this ought, or ought not, expresses some new relation or affirmation, it is necessary that it should be observed and explained."
- 8.26** If I want to say, "This is good," I can say, well, this has a certain weight, has a certain texture. I'm not going to do this, but it has a certain taste. If I tap on it, makes a certain sound. It is good. What am I looking at, smelling, tasting, pointing to? What is this goodness thing? No idea. "What seems altogether inconceivable, how this new relation can be a deduction from others, which are entirely different from it." There's this big gap between the is and the ought, or what we now call the naturalistic fallacy.
- 8.27** Many generations of philosophers after Hume referred to it, and this is exactly what Philippa Foot wants to take up. There are a number of variations on it, is versus ought, fact versus value, descriptive statements versus normative statements, intrinsic versus subjective. The idea, in some sense, those that can be connected in any way whatsoever is the naturalistic fallacy. If you are of a scientific mindset, then the idea is going to be that you have to strictly limit yourself to things on the left. You can make is

statements, you can make fact statements, you can describe things, you can talk about the way things are out there.

- 8.28** Or you can try to be a moral philosopher and start talking about ought and ideals and values and so forth, but you can't pretend that you're doing anything scientific or even connected to scientificness anymore. What Philippa Foot then is setting up for herself and for us to think about is, if we're going to overcome this alleged fallacy, we have to show that there is a way of connecting fact statements to value statements. That we can, contra David Hume, get ought statements from is statements. Good is natural, part of the natural world.
- 8.29** What Philippa Foot asks us to do is—this is an interesting thing—not to start with sociology or religion or anthropology, but rather biology. Adopt the pose, since human beings are very complicated, of being a biologist studying other living organisms. We will then just start quite naturalistically, factually, the way a biologist will talk about various other organisms. Let's do it. Here's a picture of some plants. But let's pause here for a moment. The plants have leaves. We can investigate. We know under this sandy soil, there will be roots. In the distance, we see some water. There's a sky, cloud, sunlight, mixed. There's light, plants, leaves, roots, soil, water. We have this plant in a little tiny part of an ecosystem. We can do lots and lots of descriptions of the plant.
- 8.30** Let's try another one. Take the plant and now we add a bird and we look at it and we say, wow, that's actually pretty. But notice that the shape of the bird's beak fits into the shape of the flower of the plant. The bird has an eye, enabling it to observe. It has wings that enable it to fly. We can describe this as the bird is getting the nectar from the plant and it's going to nutrify itself and fly off to the next plant and so forth. We give a description of the life of the bird.
- 8.31** Here we have an animal that eats plants. It doesn't just take the nectar, it becomes a nice big animal. It's an elk of some sort. It's been fairly successful, judging from the size of it as well, but it is surrounded by some wolves who are hunting it. If we were to look at the wolves pretty closely as well, we would see they've got sharp teeth and they're pretty fast. They're smart. They hunt in packs and they develop various kinds of strategies for tiring the elk and harassing it in various ways until, maybe, they will be able to kill it and eat it, or maybe the elk will get lucky or have various resources at its disposal to escape the wolves and survive for another day.
- 8.32** We do a lot more biological descriptions of the elk as well. Here we have a lioness and then the little one, which in her protective position. She has given birth to the lion cubs, and she protects them. Initially, she feeds them. And, this moment, she's perhaps teaching the baby lion or the lion cub how to hunt and playing with it at various points, so it develops its coordination and skills and various sorts. We give descriptions of the lion and its cubs. We've come from basic nutrition and nutrifying and photosynthesis and all of those descriptions for the plant to stay alive.

- 8.33** We talk about the hummingbird's wings and the shape of its beak so that it can nutrify itself and be mobile in the environment. We talk about more sophisticated animals that engage in strategies of hunting, sometimes socially, as wolves do. In this case, reproduction of oneself for the next generation and then a process of learning or training and education that goes on, so that the life of that species can carry on as well. Now, I'm trying to speak as neutrally and as descriptively as possible in working through all of these range of examples.
- 8.34** This is how Philippa Foot wants us to start thinking about the subject of ethics, naturalistically, like biologists, studying increasingly complicated life forms. She uses this language in *Natural Goodness*. "It is necessary for plants to have water." I'll elaborate. "It is necessary for birds to build nests," to engage in a construction process, for protection against the environment. "It is necessary for wolves to hunt in packs, and for lionesses to teach their cubs to kill." There are nutritional necessities built into nature. There are, in many cases, construction necessities built into nature. There are social coordination issues necessary, built into nature. There are education issues built into nature. We're not making these up.
- 8.35** Now, the necessary point—I've got that word highlighted—why is it necessary? If we ask that question. We say it's necessary because if the plants, the wolves, the birds, the lionesses, do not perform these necessary functions, they will die. If they do perform those functions and perform them—and now we're introducing a normative word—successfully, perform them well, they will live. The successful performance of certain functions enables the organisms to live. If they don't, they die. What we have here then is a fundamental distinction between living and dying that organisms are confronted with.
- 8.36** When we do moral philosophy, we're concerned with fundamental distinctions between the good and the bad, the right and the wrong. The suggestion here is that we will be tying our normative language to descriptive scientific, biological language rooted in the distinction between living and dying. Nothing magical about it. These are facts about the world. All right. Longer quotation here.
- 8.37** "We start from the fact." Now, we start from the fact. We're starting with facts. "That it's a particular life form of a species of plant or animal that determines how an individual plant or animal should be." You'll notice this in that statement, we've moved from an is statement, a fact statement, to a should statement. You are a plant, not you. But we're a philosopher for plants, so to speak. You are a plant. You are a particular kind of life form. You have certain needs, certain capacities. So how you, so to speak, ought to be as a plant is dictated by the kind of life form that you are.
- 8.38** You are a bird; you ought to fly. You are a wolf; you ought to hunt. You are a lioness; you ought to raise your young. All right, now that's a move. Immediately, if we're a philosopher, we say, wait a minute. Are we going too fast here? Because we're going from descriptive statements to normative statements. But Foot's point is to say that, as

biologists, we can easily move from descriptive statements to normative language. There's nothing particularly weird about saying, "It's bad for plants not to have water." That's a fact, but it's also a normative statement at the same time.

- 8.39** The normative statements are a certain kind of fact statement for living organisms. Carrying on here. "And all the truths about what this or that characteristic does, what its purpose or point is, and in suitable cases, its function, must be related to this life cycle. The way an individual should be is determined by what is needed for the development, self-maintenance, and reproduction; in most species involving defense, and in some cases, the rearing of the young."
- 8.40** All right, abstract philosophical description, though, then, of saying what an organism is, is something different from non-organic things. Organisms can live or they can die. But what it is for any given organism to live depends on what kind of a living organism it is. It has certain needs, that it has certain capacities, that it has to function in certain ways. If it does those things and does them well, then it will stay alive, and if not, it will die. We're building up a vocabulary of biological descriptiveness, but connecting it to ought language as well.
- 8.41** Let's try some examples. It's a fact that, for any organism, it has certain needs that must be met in order to survive. Plants need to photosynthesize. Plants need water. Hummingbirds need nectar from flowers. Wolves need protein from certain animals. Lion cubs need their mothers to teach them how to hunt. Any problems? No, no problems whatsoever. These are all straight scientific facts. At the same time, we are then able to spell out part of that description that we've just made.
- 8.42** I'm the organism, whatever organism "I" is; out there in the environment are things that we will call resources. Water in the cases of plants, nectar in the case of hummingbirds, caribou in the case of wolves, antelopes in the case of lions, and so forth. From the organism's perspective, there are things out there that are resources. Now, what do we mean, though, when we call something a resource? Because there's lots of things out in the environment, and some of them are irrelevant to the living of the organism. By designating something as a resource, we're making a relational statement. There's that thing in relationship to the organism's needs.
- 8.43** The organism has a need; that's a fact. There's some resource out there that, whatever it is, has what the organism needs, and if it is successful at getting that resource, its needs will be satisfied. To talk about something as a resource is to make a relational statement. The sun is a resource for the plant. Water is a resource for the plant. The water is necessary for the plant, but there's not some intrinsic thing about water. Plants need me. It is the water and its chemical structure in relation to the structure of the plant that means there is a fit of a sort.
- 8.44** The organism, we can not talk about what's out there, we can talk about its dispositions or its structures or its internal whatevers. The plant, for example, it has roots, and the

roots have certain biochemical structures that enable the root to extract the water from the soil, along with whatever nutrients also are in the soil that it needs. Its roots are a certain capacity. Its leaves have a certain chemical set of structures, the chlorophyll and so forth. That's a chemical structure that has a capacity for, when struck by light, transforming the light into the kind of energy that the plant needs and so forth.

- 8.45** So we're giving all of these descriptions, but now we're talking about the needs of the organism, resources that are out there in the environment, the capacities that the organism has, as the kind of being that it is, to either act to get the resources or, if the resources are brought to it, to process the resources in the right kind of way. We move on to actions and with more complicated animals, plants don't really act too much, but hummingbirds do. They fly. The wolves engage in hunting strategies and so forth. They're engaging in various kinds of actions.
- 8.46** Then we can talk about the consequences of those actions. The organism is able to incorporate the resources in a certain way using its capacities, and so it survives and then is able to carry on as its life form. Already, we're into a very complex set of descriptions here, but at the same time, it's very commonsensical. This is all the stuff that we learn as kids when we are growing up. What we are trying to get to then is what makes this normatively significant, all of this scientific description.
- 8.47** When we get to a more complicated being like ourselves, the human being, we want to say, well, it's going to be the same story. We are an organism. We can live or we can die. We have certain capacities, capacities for moving around, for communicating, certain physiological capacities. My heart beats, my lungs process air, and so forth. Why are all of these capacities being exercised? Well, so that I can, in some cases, act in the environment to get the resources that I need, or when the resources are brought to me, I can take those resources in and operate on them, so that I can stay alive.
- 8.48** For me as a human being, I have particular resource needs; I have particular capacities that have to be exercised, et cetera, et cetera. The story becomes more complicated. Now, what Foot is doing then, after all of these long descriptions, then, is to say that we can make a general point. "The evaluation of human action depends on essential features of specifically human life." The way to start doing ethics and moral philosophy is first to start looking at humans biologically. This will be a biologically based understanding.
- 8.49** Human beings are a life form with particular needs, particular resources out in the environment that can satisfy those needs, and a set of capacities that, if exercised, can enable it to act as a human being in the environment to get the resources it needs in order to maintain its life. If we repeat the formulation from before, we can say there are certain things that humans need, just as with other animals, there's a continuity. "It is necessary for plants to have water, for birds to build nests, for wolves to hunt in packs, and for lionesses to teach their children," and so on.

- 8.50** Just as we would say, look, if there's a lioness that's not attending to her cubs, she gives birth to the cubs and just abandons them, we say there's something wrong with that lioness. That is a defective lioness because she is not performing a necessary function in her role as a lioness mother in this case. Then from the perspective of the lion cubs, this is bad for the lion cubs to be abandoned by their mother because there is something that they need in order to become successful mature lions as they grow up. It's going to be the same structural story that we do in the case of human beings as with any other animal species but relativized to the kind of being that we are.
- 8.51** The way Philippa Foot puts this point is to say, "Evaluating human capacities and actions has the same 'logical grammar' as evaluating other sub-rational living things' capacities and actions." What that means then is to say, just as we would say in the case of a bird, take the hummingbird. This is cruel. Don't do this. Capture the little guy, take a big pair of scissors, cut off its beak, its long beak. That's bad for the hummingbird. I just used an evaluative term. It's bad for the hummingbird, but it makes perfectly good natural sense to say why it's bad.
- 8.52** Because given that the hummingbird is the kind of being that it is and it has certain needs— it needs to get pollen, it needs to exercise the beak's particular powers in order to get that pollen so that its nutritional needs can be satisfied—you have just made the hummingbird incapable of performing one of its basic life functions. That's the same thing as saying, you have just made it this hummingbird incapable of living.
- 8.53** If we were to take another example, we take the lioness, and she has just taught her lion cub some stealthy hunting tactic. Now, at the beginning of the day, the lion cub did not know how to do that. At the end of the day, the lion cub now knows how to stealthily approach the prey. Good job, mama lion. Now, I've just used the evaluative concept. We have said this is a good thing that has happened for the lion cub. We're not adding extra magic dust to the process here. What we are saying is, now the lion cub has capacities that it did not have at the beginning of the day.
- 8.54** And those capacities, the knowledge that it has, the skills that it now has, better enable it to be a hunter, which means that it can act appropriately, get the resources that it needs in order to live as a lion. The language of good and bad falls out of the descriptions of the facts in the case. The same thing then is going to apply for human beings. We are part of nature. In some ways, we are continuous with other organisms. In some ways, we are distinct from other organisms. We have to look at ourselves the way first biologists would do so.
- 8.55** Here's the big conclusion here. "The grounding of a moral argument is ultimately in facts about human life. It is obvious that there are objective, factual evaluations of such things as human sight, hearing, memory, and concentration, based on the life form of our own species." Take a human being, gouge out its eyes. That's bad. Not because God said so, not because it's just a social convention that somehow traditionally we just

said, "Don't gouge out people's eyes," but other cultures, maybe they're fine with gouging out people's eyes. Say, "No, eyes are a capacity that human beings have."

- 8.56** Human beings need to be observing their environment, to the extent that they can observe their environment. They can process various knowledge about the environment; that will guide their actions in the environment so that they can get the resources that they need to satisfy their needs and live as human beings. You gouge out a human beings' eyes, you are putting it on the road to death. You're not killing it outright, but you are taking it away from it being able to do what is good for the human being. Again, no magic. This is natural biology.
- 8.57** Now, if this is right, and of course, it gets more complicated, because as she suggests, we have other senses. We have memory, we have concentration, we can think. "Why then does it seem so monstrous a suggestion that the evaluation of the human will should be determined by facts about the nature of human beings and the life of our own species?" That's meant to be a rhetorical question. It's not monstrous. In fact, it's completely ordinary and rational to try to connect evaluative statements about what's good for human beings to facts about what human beings are as biological beings.
- 8.58** Now, when we get into human beings, we start to talk about more complicated things. I can talk about my respiratory needs. I need oxygen. It's good for my lungs to be in a certain state so that they can extract or process air that is extracted, separate the the oxygen that I need from the other gases in the environment, and exhale them. The functioning of my respiratory system in a certain way is good, and it will be bad if it doesn't do that. But we have other systems, and some of these other systems are more complicated than the systems that other animals have.
- 8.59** We have a bigger brain, for example. But the brain also is a set of functions that, if we learn to do them in a certain way, we will then be more successful as living human beings. Learning how to use our eyes well, how to concentrate, how to remember all sorts of information that comes in from our eyes, to make connections, to form more abstract concepts, to start functioning, logically and rationally, figuring out how to do experiments in the world, all of these things that we can do as human beings, the full flourishing, educated development of our brains and minds, that's good for human beings to do.
- 8.60** Just as it's really good for lions to have sharp claws, just as it's very good for wolves to have sharp canine teeth, just as it's very good for hummingbirds to have that long beak, it's very good for human beings to become smart, to learn how to be rational, and figure out the way the world is. What we mean then by a virtue language, when we use good or virtue, we're talking about the dispositions and characters that human beings have, if we say, just to take the example that we are working with, if I am, as a human being, then committed to education, learning, getting as much information as I possibly can, sorting out the true from the false, keeping up to speed on experimentation and so on, I am devoted to the better execution of what goes on in my brain.

- 8.61** That's good for me, just as it is good for the wolf to keep its teeth sharp; just as it's good in this example here for a bee to keep its stinger stocked with whatever the little toxins are that are in the stinger and to keep its stinger sharp so it can defend itself against various sorts of predators. We start to talk about more sophisticated language. What are the values? What are the virtues? What are the proper traits of being a human being? But we're going to cash those all out in terms of dispositions that we can learn to do more proficiently in various ways, but they're going to be connected to our actions, so that we can survive better in the world.
- 8.62** Our species, now getting down to human beings, now that we've got the logical grammar sorted out, "The good of survival itself is something more complex for human beings than for animals." Now, this is obvious. We can do basic respiratory functions. Sunlight is also good for us. We can also perform basic actions in the environment to gather various things that we need. We can also hunt like many other animals can do. But then it seems like we start to do more sophisticated things. We start to do farming. We start to do metallurgy and working with metals. We start to build more complicated societies and various kinds of processes and so on.
- 8.63** Obviously, human beings are a lot more complex, but our point is going to be that the complexity—we can build up to it on this biological foundation that we have established here. The most important feature for Foot is to say that human beings are creatures with a big brain. That's the biological description, but because of the particular structure of our bigger brain, the part that makes it really bigger is that we have the capacity for abstract, conceptual, rational thought. That's our distinctively important function, our distinctively important capacity and moral virtue, and the ability to acquire the values that we need as human beings is tied to that.
- 8.64** "Human beings are creatures with the power to recognize reasons for action and to act on them." Then a very interesting formulation here. "While animals do go for the good thing that they see," I'm a wolf, I see a caribou over there, I go for it, "human beings go for what they see as good." It might be, if I'm hunting caribou to feed my family or whatever, I see the caribou, I also will go for it. But there's something different between me and the wolf. I have recognized my action as hunting in a bigger context because I am a rational being, and I can think about hunting in a more strategic, scientific, perhaps even more technological way, because of the power of my big brain compared to the power of a wolf.
- 8.65** Now, the diversity of human goods, and this is where someone like Ruth Benedict with the anthropological studies, look at the diversity of human beings, or if we do any amount of history and we say, "Wow, look at all these different human individuals and human cultures with their great diversity," and so forth, it's very easy then to say, well, it's just too diverse and just too complex. There is no way to sort all of it out to a fundamental set of principles that are really good and really bad. And that's what Philippa Foot wants to challenge.

- 8.66** You can't start at the really complex stuff. Always start at the basics. Start with plants, build your way up to human beings in an orderly fashion. "In spite of the diversity of human goods—the elements that can make up good human lives—it is therefore possible that the concept of a good human life plays the same part in determining the goodness of human characteristics that the concept of flourishing plays in the determination of goodness in plants and animals."
- 8.67** Take all of that. If we want to say, just take any plant. We have this concept of a healthy plant and an unhealthy plant. If we know anything about plants, and you've learned something, that becomes pretty obvious what the difference is. But we can acquire more and more scientific knowledge about what makes it possible for a plant to flourish, comparing to a plant that is not flourishing and approaching death. The difference is, fundamentally, this one is going to carry on living, this one is going toward death as a plant. We can identify the resources, the capacities, the actions that the plants need to take in each particular case, and all of that gets put together in a concept of what it is to live well as a plant and not to live well as a plant.
- 8.68** That is the concept that we use quite naturally in biology about flourishing, a flourishing plant or a flourishing animal. It's doing well. Its life is going well. It's doing good things for itself as opposed to the bad things that might kill us. Now, the conceptual structure point that she is making is to say the same thing holds for human beings, just in a more complicated form. The conceptual structure is the same. This is how a man ought to live if we have a good biology. Of course, now we know that the big brain is important. We also need to have a good psychology.
- 8.69** The psychology, though, is integrated with the biology, so we have a really good scientific understanding of human beings as, say, I don't know, if you were an alien from some other planet coming and studying human beings. Just as we go into other animals' ecosystems and study them, it would be the same story that we would develop, and we would be using normative language to describe what's good for human beings.
- 8.70** So these are the four or five key concepts that need to be integrated. The concept of a need, biologically based. Concept of a resource. The concept of dispositions or capacities that organisms have, and then actions, where those capacities are exercised to acquire or process the resource, ultimately needs being satisfied, and that's the good consequence. The organism continues on in its life. So ethics is complicated. Morality is complicated because, in making any sort of a complicated or standard evaluative statement, we have to be talking about all five of these.
- 8.71** What is good is identifying the need that that is being satisfied, the capacity that's being exercised, the resource in the environment that is being acted upon, and then the organism carrying on in its life. For human beings, it's more complicated because we need to do an additional step. We don't have instincts or rudimentary training in

the basic actions. Rather, we need to identify what we need to do consciously in terms of abstract principles.

8.72 Even if we're going to go from basic hunting to farming, farming requires even basically, we are thinking in one-year time cycles. "I'm going to harvest the seeds and not eat all of the seeds over the course of the winter. I'm going to save those seeds, plant them in the ground in the following spring. I'm going to look after them all summer until they grow up, and then again, harvest them in the fall when the fruits or the grains are right, consume some of them to meet my needs, but then again, with foresight, save some seeds for the next year." That's a very big-picture conceptual identification of lots of resources, lots of capacities, lots of needs in an integrated statement. That's just to talk about farming. When we talk about more complicated types of social structures, the story will get even more complicated.

8.73 Now, I want to wrap here by saying that Philippa Foot is an original philosophical thinker in the latter part of the 20th century on into the 21st century. One way of making connections to the history of moral tradition is that the Aristotelian tradition, going back to the 300s BCE, so 2300 years or so ago, Aristotle was, of course, a great philosopher, but he was also a great biologist. If you look at his corpus of 40 or so books, he wrote a majority of those books on biology, where he was trying to figure out, as the first great biologist, all of the different needs and capacities and resource fit between the needs and capacities of the animals and their environments.

8.74 He was fortunate in one respect that one of his students was Alexander the Great. When Alexander the Great was off conquering the world, he remembered his old teacher to whom he was largely devoted, and he always sent his troops out once they'd conquered a new place to gather up lots of samples of plants and animals and insects and so forth and have them sent back to Greece. There was a steady inflow of stuff. Aristotle, with his great philosophical and scientific mind, spent a huge amount of time doing the dissections and the classifications and building all of this up.

8.75 When he turned to doing his moral philosophy, the *Nicomachean Ethics* is the most significant work here. I recommend that you look at the first book. It's a 10-book, it's a pretty weighty tome, but look at the first book. What you'll find is many of the seeds, so to speak, of what Philippa Foot is talking about two and a half millennia later—identifying needs and functions and capacities of human beings, what makes us distinctive, what enables us to flourish as human beings.

8.76 Also, I would mention, in the previous generation, Ayn Rand, her objectivist approach to ethics, you'll find great structural similarities between what Rand is doing in the 1960s and what Philippa Foot is doing toward the end of her career, a little bit later. Both of them are modern Aristotelians trying to update that essentially Aristotelian biological functionalist approach to ethics, where what's good is a species of the natural. So, biology, as the mother science, we have to understand each species as a particular form of life. The good is natural. But there is a relativism depending on what

kind of species you are talking about because different species have different needs, capacities, et cetera.

- 8.77** See human beings as part of the natural world, just as a more complicated and distinctive form of life. And so we should be able to do ethics objectively, as a science, albeit an extraordinarily, perhaps the most complicated science possible to us. If you wish, here again is the chart to fill in. If you follow through on this exercise, this will be hard work. We have, over the course of the course, looked at 11 different philosophers. If you fill out the chart with 11 different philosophers answering, "Where do we get our ethics from? How are we supposed to arrive at these conclusions? Are they universal or relative? Why should we be doing all of this?"
- 8.78** One of the reasons I chose these 11, squeezing them all into this eight-lecture series, is that they do represent very different packages of answers to all six of those questions. When you fill the chart in, if you go ahead and do so, it becomes initially a little bit overwhelming and bewildering to recognize just how many different possible combinations of answers to all of those questions are.
- 8.79** Now, this is also billed as a course in modern ethics. I want to say in conclusion why I did a little bit or why I'm emphasizing the modernity of all of this. Part of it is the great diversity of moral thinking and moral argumentation that started to occur in the last 500 years or so. Comparatively, if we look at earlier cultures and earlier civilizations, again, there would be debates and different agreements, but by and large, those cultures were homogeneous on their moral thinking. We have long ago lost the expectation in modern society that we are all going to be on the same page.
- 8.80** Partly, it's a recognition that all of this is a lot more complicated than perhaps we thought it was a thousand years ago. Part of it has to do with, as we have become more modern, we have become more individualistic, we have become more rational and scientific, and we have, with, of course, great controversy about whether we should be so individualistic and so scientific and rational or not, nonetheless, we are, and we are, we have been culturally expecting more and more people to engage in the process of really thinking for themselves about the big philosophical questions, that the meaning of life is not something that is handed to you by the powers that be beyond your authority.
- 8.81** It's up to you to think through all of the issues, make your own decisions, take responsibility for your life, and so forth. Now, that statement of how human beings ought to live is, of course, itself, morally controversial, and lots of people will say that's the wrong way to do it. Modern world is a giant mistake, and we should be doing something completely different. But that's the way it is right now. What I would commend to you is to say, as modern human beings, aware of all of these issues, see yourself as part of the great conversation. I like that metaphor a lot.

- 8.82** We have a conversation that has begun, starting with John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, or what a top value should be, and various other philosophers coming along, recognizing that the earlier philosophers are ones that they need to know something about and to either disagree with or agree with, and making it up for their package of moral beliefs for their own selves and then representing them in a way that hopefully they think is compelling to other people. We're all part of that process.
- 8.83** We end in the early part of the 21st century with Philippa Foot. We started in the 1600s with John Locke, so we have covered a big chunk of time and some areas of agreement and overlap among many of them, but much disagreement. I invite you to carry this on for yourself and work out your own answers to the big questions.
- 8.84** I was wondering what the argument against Philippa Foot's natural goodness argument is?
- 8.85** OK, so what comes next?
- 8.86** Yes. What are the critics saying? Because I very much resonated with her ideas.
- 8.87** OK. All right. Well, I think one way to do this, and this will be a bigger project question, would be to say, as a philosophy student or a philosophy learner would do, is to say, all right, what I should do is pretend I am Ruth Benedict now and channel my inner Ruth Benedict as a cultural relativist. What would I say to Philippa Foot? Where would I find the big sticking points to be? Or if I were Søren Kierkegaard, channel my inner Kierkegaard, what would I find most objectionable? What that will then do is probably bring to the fore in your mind where the biggest difference is and probably the most fundamental difference is.
- 8.88** In the case, for example, if we take those two, just as an example, if we start with Søren Kierkegaard, probably the biggest thing he would say is, well, if we are to think of ourselves as natural beings, and it's all about life and death and so forth, and we do this big complicated structure and so on, the end result is death. That means that I have to accept my mortality and that all meaning of life, however we're going to cash that out, is going to be in naturalistic terms. Chances are good that every fiber of Kierkegaard's being is going to rebel against that. I, for whatever reason, need to believe that there is something beyond, something more significant, something greater.
- 8.89** So, the distinction then for him is in part then going to be a metaphysical distinction, naturalism versus supernaturalism of some sort. That would be one exercise. If we take Ruth Benedict as an example, probably, if I were to do this, we would say, well, Philippa Foot is emphasizing reason and rationality. And when you fill that out more, she's talking about the individual's ability to observe the environment; the individuals have their own particular social or survival needs, that I need to learn how to make my body healthy and strong, make my mind healthy and strong.

- 8.90** By emphasizing all of this, I'm sounding very individualistic. It might be, of course, I'm going to learn things from my parents and from my teachers and do things in teamwork. But fundamentally, it's a more individualistic approach to ethics. It sounds like she is saying—she, Foot—that in the function of my mind, I've got some autonomy. From my Ruth Benedict perspective, I'm going to say, no, human beings are totally a creature of society. Whatever ends up in their minds is not a result of people learning to think for themselves and develop themselves as individuals, but rather they are completely cultured.
- 8.91** So, do we have some sort of autonomy as individuals in a robust way, that Philippa Foot would say, or is that completely an illusion? That's to take us to the volition versus determinism issue, which is about human nature, not so much about the metaphysics of naturalism or supernaturalism. And I think if you were to do the same thing with the other philosophers, you would find big issues popping out. Good.
- 8.92** Professor Hicks, thank you so much for an amazing lecture and your passion for teaching this. I also really resonated with Philippa Foot, and I wanted to know, what would be your suggestion on how—because I feel like this is a long process of learning the morality of the human and getting all the way up to cases of abortion and all those things.
- 8.93** Yeah, absolutely.
- 8.94** But how is it that we can maybe put our own footprint into—I'm thinking also, like, food cases in America. We already know so many things are dangerous and unnatural for us, yet we still continue to serve it and to provide it in big abundance. We also know how there's a little bit of a system with food and health and pharmaceuticals. With all of this philosophy, what would you say is the best step forward to move?
- 8.95** That's a very good question. You're pointing out just how complicated and difficult all of this is. I think what someone like Foot would say—I'm turning us all into disciples of Philippa Foot now. It sounds like she struck a chord here— is to start with yourself and to say, if I take Philippa Foot's approach to ethics and then I think through for myself, "What are my nutritional needs and my broader physical needs and then my psychological needs in developing my mind?", and part of the development of my mind is thinking about Philippa Foot and how to apply it in various other ways, that is a big project.
- 8.96** I think the first thing to do is to say, this will be a personal project, and I will see if it—when I think further about it, and as you're suggesting, if I start to read some criticisms of Foot—where do the sticking points seem to be? Once I've worked out in my own mind what I think the right approach to meta-ethics is, and that's what Foot is doing here, then I start to work through all of the specific issues. Then I think about pharmaceuticals, I will think about the food industry, and I will think about political issues, and I will think about religious issues and so on. That will be a big, huge project.

- 8.97** If we want to then say, it is me, but it's also me in a context, rather, of a big, complex society, part of it has to then be to say that there's a division of labor in a couple of ways. I need to do this for me, figure out my best moral framework in life, but I also want other people to be doing the same sort of thing, so that, ultimately, if they are rational beings, they're going to reach, generally speaking, the same sorts of conclusions. There will be an educational process that gets spread out through society so people are more or less on the same page thinking about these moral issues in the same way.
- 8.98** But then at the same time, all of that is going to be more than one person can do. So, what we are going to need in a complex society is people who are able then to say, if we take this naturalistic Footian framework and apply it to pharmaceuticals, apply it to nutrition, apply it to the legal structure of society, apply it to economic issues and so on, there will be, hopefully then, philosophically astute people who have the particular expertises working out those answers for the benefit of us all. That's the best that a philosopher can do in two minutes.